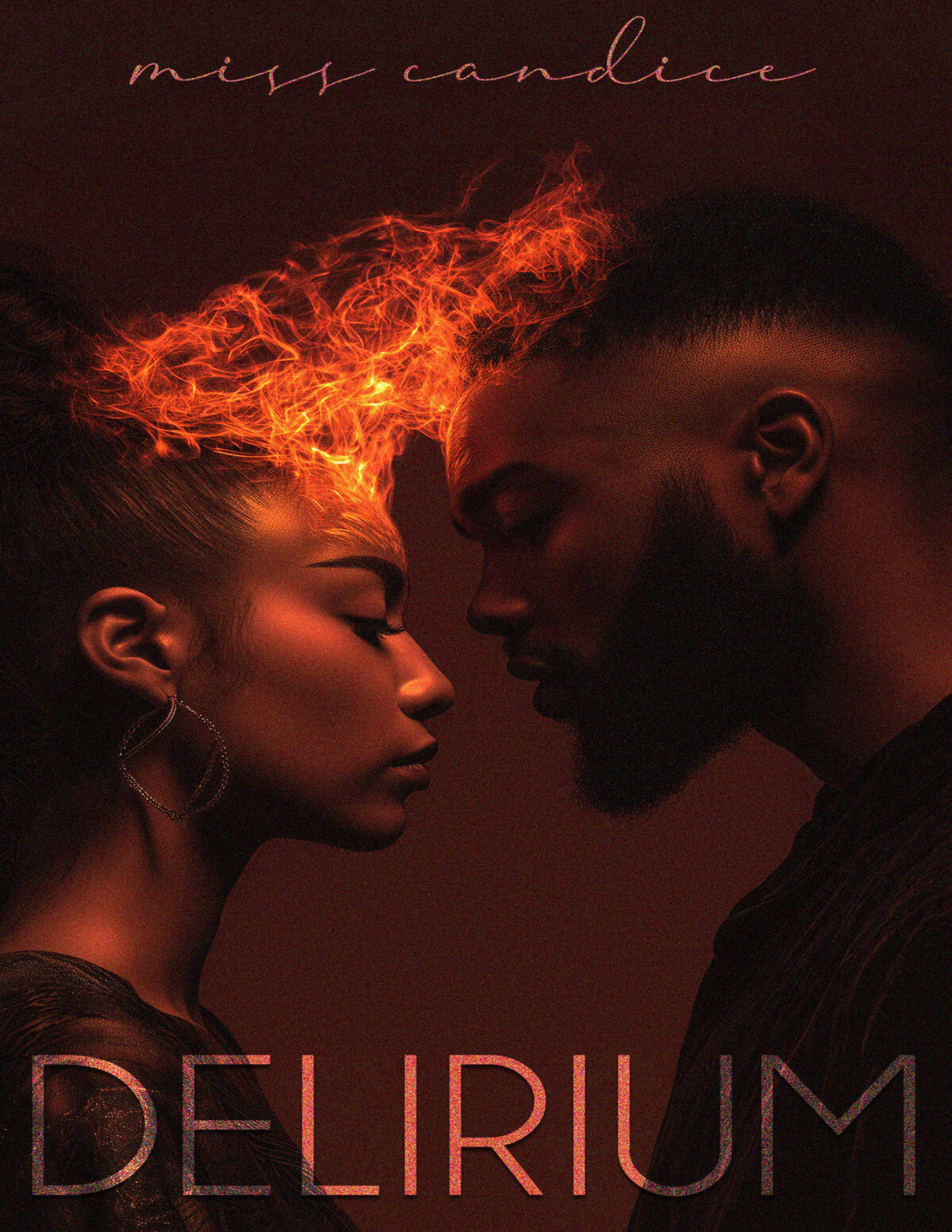
miss candice



DELIRIUM

DELIRIUM

miss candice

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PRONUNCIATION

Sereia (Suh-ray-uh)

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

Hey bae.

Before you dive in, I have to give a disclaimer. Delirium is a three-part series. Yes, yes, I know. You prefer a standalone. It's okay though, bookie, I'm about to take you on a wild, emotional, gripping ride that's going to keep you hooked the entire way through. First though… if you know me, then you know that part one to any series I write is the foundation. The ground work. And without a solid foundation, the 'building' will crumble.

I appreciate you.

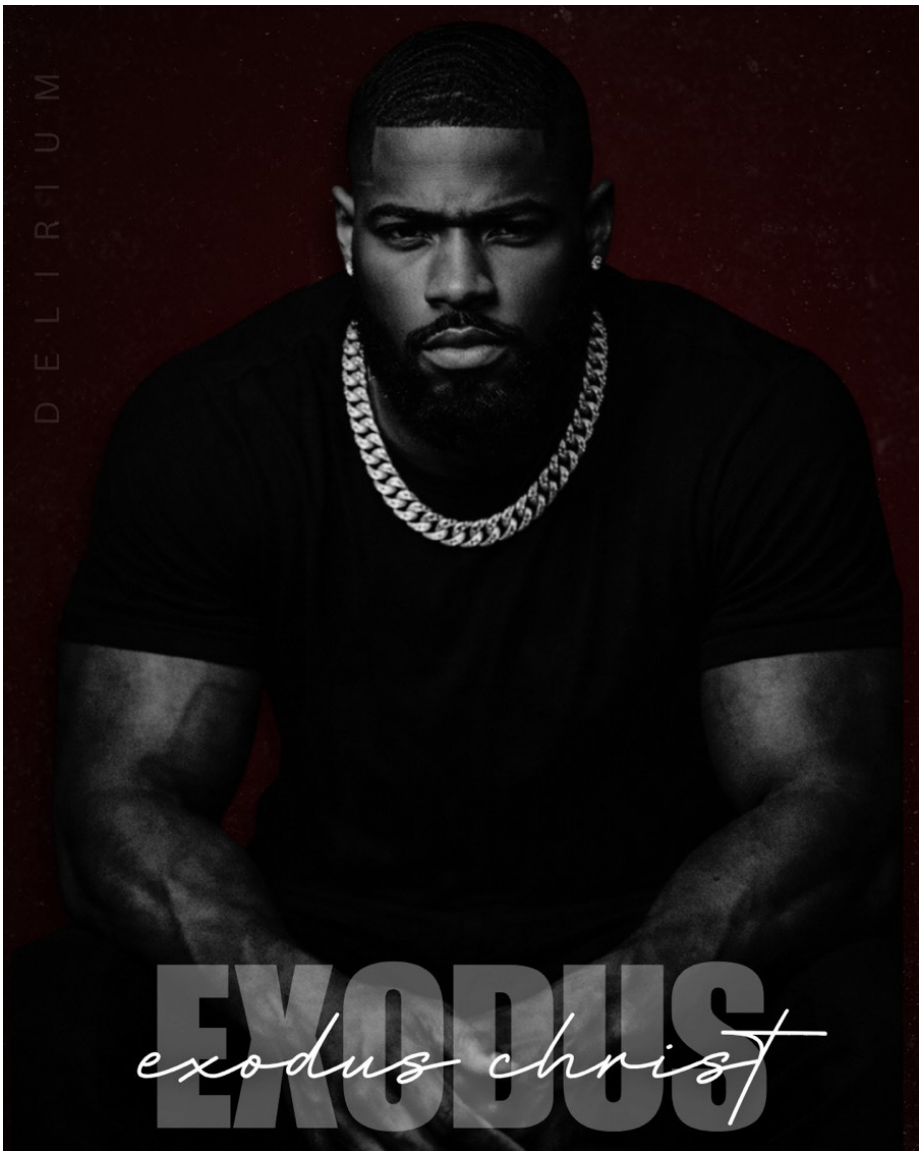
I appreciate you more than you'll ever know. Seriously. I hope you enjoy what I've written. I literally let this one come to me as I typed. No plans, just vibes. And I've gotta say… I love what's happening between these pages. And I hope that you will too.

Love forever and always.

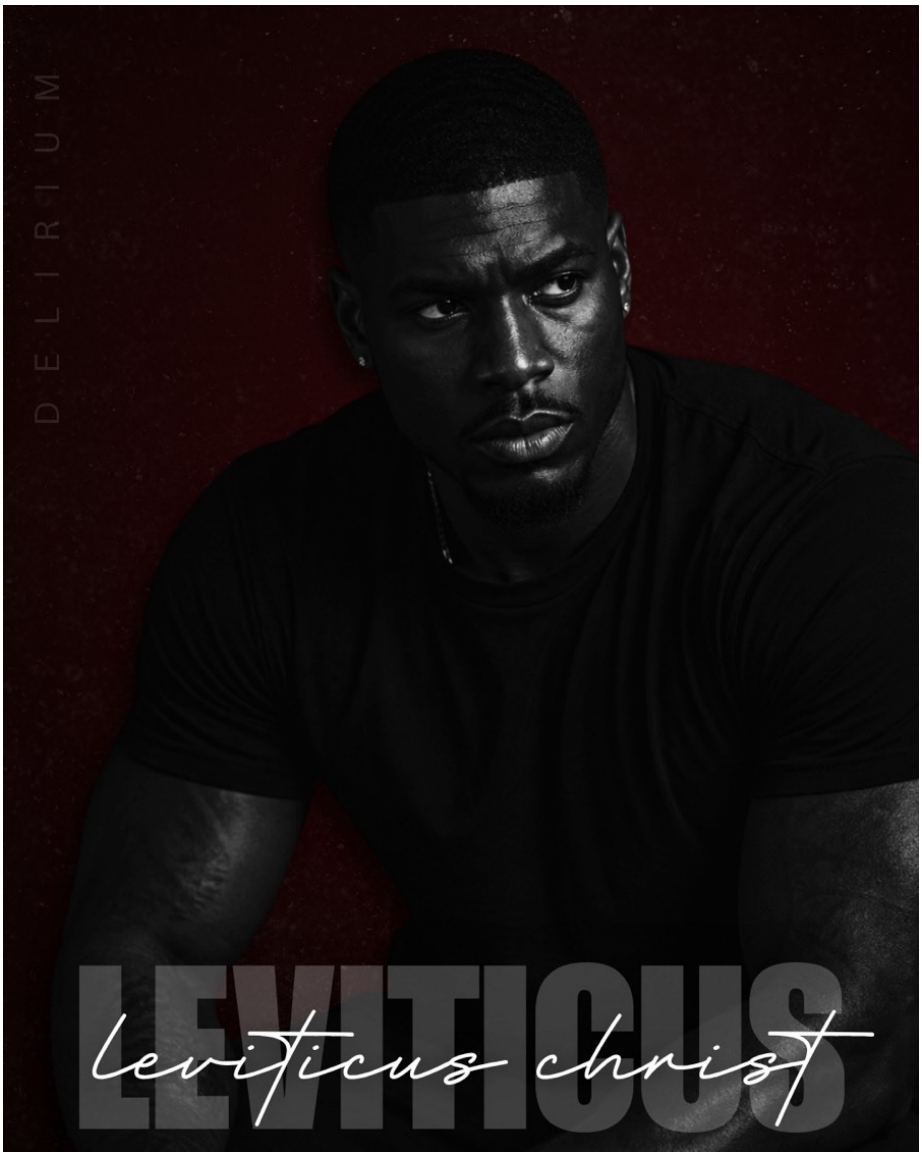
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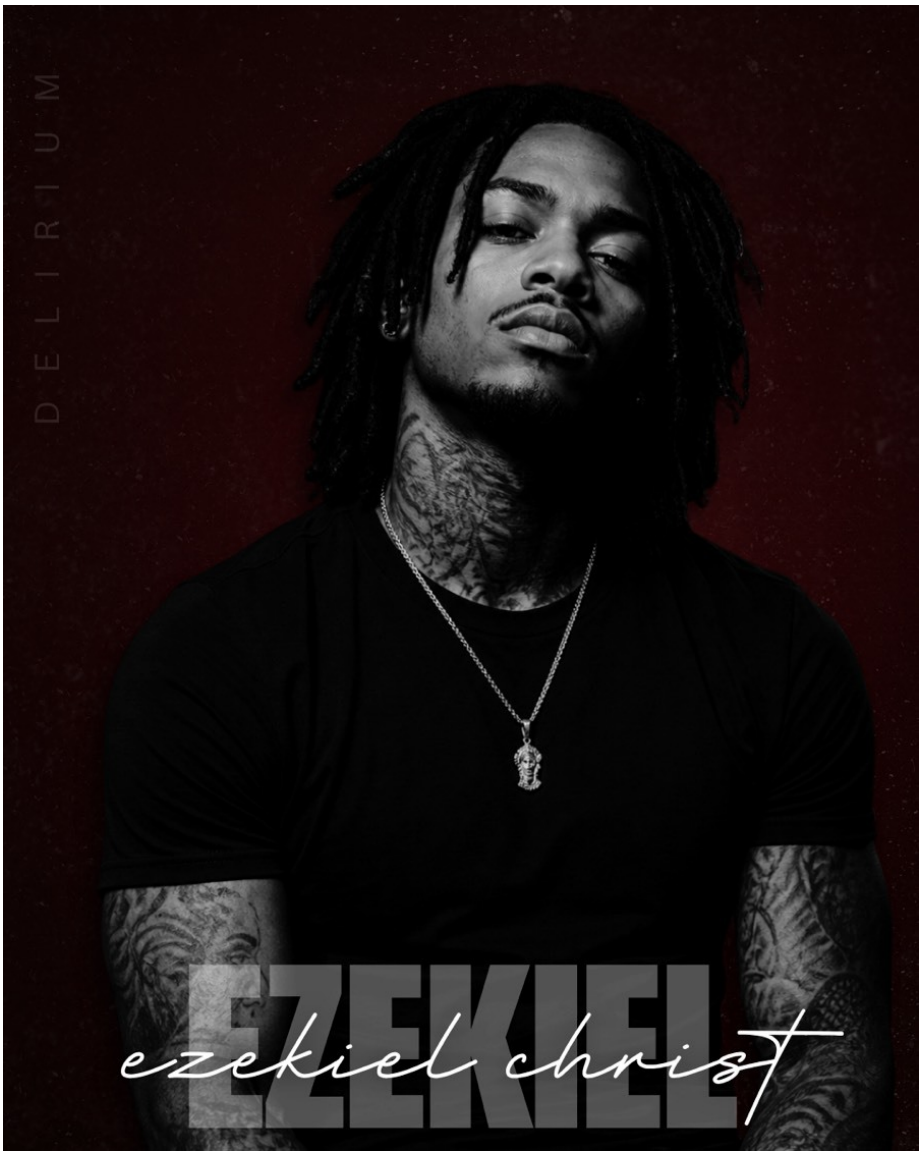
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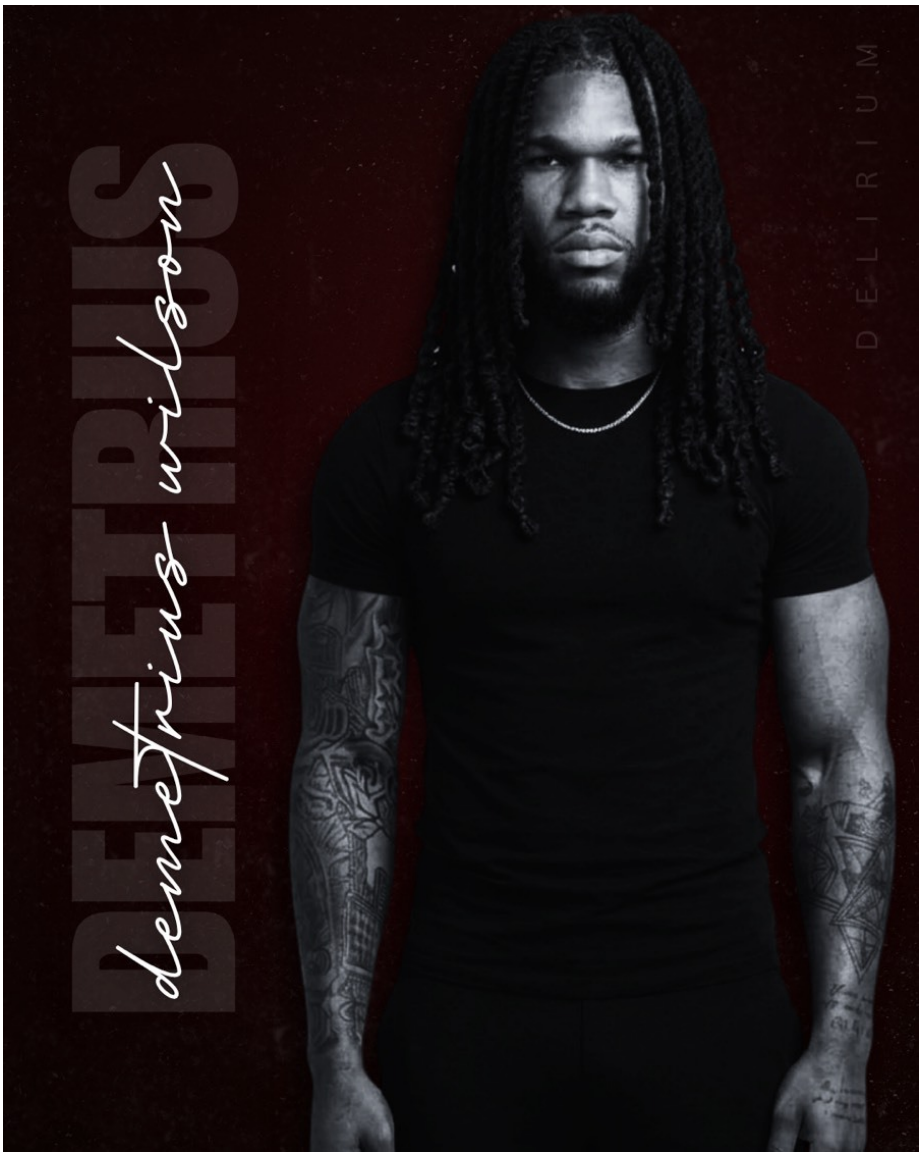
CHARACTER VISUALS


DELIRIUM
EXODUS
exodus christ


SERIA
seria wilson
DELIRIUM


DELIRIUM
LEVITICUS
leviticus christ


DELIRIUM
EZEKIEL
ezekiel christ



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CHAPTER 1

SEREIA



"WHAT TIME YOU COMIN' BACK?" I ASKED MY BROTHER MEECH, STANDING in the doorway of his bedroom, with my arms crossed over my chest, watching as he got ready to leave.

Meech looked down at his iPhone before looking over his shoulder at me. "You know how shit go. Don't wait up for me. I'll be here when you wake up in the morning fa sho. As usual."

"With breakfast?"

"Hell yeah. Cheese eggs, bacon and hash browns," he tossed over his shoulder as he pulled his black hoodie down over his head.

"Hash browns with what?" I asked, testing him.

"Squeeze cheese," he said, his voice muffled by the hoodie sliding down over his face. "I got you. I remember, Sereia."

I went quiet for a second, watching him closely. He had on plain black joggers, a black hoodie with a black tee underneath it, and black Air Force Ones. On his neck was his usual pendant chain. The one with momma in the middle. He wore his long locs dangling in his face. But the way he wore his hair wouldn't matter once he pulled his black shiesty down over his face. He was dressed the way he always dressed when he left the house at this time of night. Low key.

I looked down at my cracked iPhone 12 Pro Max, checking the time. It was going on eleven. He told me not to wait up for him, but I would. I always did. He just didn't know. Whenever he'd come home, I'd watch him from the couch, one eye cracked open, happy as hell. And then, that

morning, usually hours later, I'd ask him what time he got home, as we sat at the kitchen table, eating breakfast he picked up before he got here.

It was what we did.

At least three times a week.

Four if the week before that one was rough and we had a couple of shut off notices.

Demetrius and I were close. Very close. It was just the two of us. He was five years older than me and took the big brother role seriously. He took care of me and home. We didn't have parents. I mean, we had them, but momma died years ago and daddy was in prison.

"What?" Meech asked, questioning my silence.

I took a deep breath, pushed away from the wall and walked into the bedroom. With my hands out, I approached him. He extended his and we held hands. I didn't have to tell him to bow his head. He followed my lead.

"Dear God, you know what I need. You know what *Meech* needs. Protection. We don't just need *you* to protect him—we need help from the ancestors, too. Watch over him. Guide him. Help him keep his intuition sharp and his awareness on point. Amen."

"Amen," Meech mumbled before releasing my hands. He lifted the bottom of his hoodie, brandishing the handle of his gun. "This all the protection I need."

I turned the corners of my mouth up, frowning. "Now you *know* that's a lie."

"It and the bullets in this bitch," he joked.

"Yeah, okay, Demetrius," I chastised. "Stop playing with me."

"Aight, aight. I hear you sis. I appreciate you. I just don't think God listens to the prayers coming from The Woods."

We lived in Brickhaven, MI., in one of the largest housing projects on the east side. Ironwood Estates—The Woods. The only thing that came out of The Woods were drug dealers, dope fiends, scammers, thieves, hood rats, prostitutes, single moms (and dads), and the unlucky ones—like me—who were forced to live here because of financial circumstances. The Woods had been a part of my life for as long as I could remember.

I was born and raised here. Meech too. It was our life. The only time we moved was when we changed apartments because momma wanted to 'upgrade'. It wasn't much of an upgrade though. The only difference between this apartment and the one we moved from was the flooring and

the paint color. It still had the same small ass bedrooms, the same low water pressure, and the same loud ass rowdy ass, ghetto ass fucking neighbors. *Oh*. It had the same roaches and mice too. Luckily we didn't have rats. Not like our cousins, on the other side of the community. I was grateful for that. Could handle a couple of mice here and there. Well, shit, *I* didn't handle them—Meech did. He handled everything. I just lived here and went to work every now and then, pitching in on bills whenever I could.

I rolled my eyes and shook my head. "Here you go with that."

"Not just from The Woods. Shit, from me. From *us*." He paused and gestured towards himself. "Look at me. Look at us. Look at where we at. How long you been prayin'? Before you… how long was ma prayin'?"

Meech and I were different. In many ways. Being the girl, I was sheltered mostly. I didn't hang out much and I kept my head in the books for the most part. Growing up, I was accustomed to my living environment, but I hated it. I wanted out. Because I knew money wouldn't get me out, I focused heavily on education. As if the education system in Brickhaven was worth a damn. Still, I kept my head in the books. I was determined to use my intelligence to get me up out of the hood. I graduated high school three years ago. You see how far that got me?

Aside from being sheltered and heavy in the books, Meech and I had two completely different views when it came to how we looked at life. I felt like the way we were brought up played a major role in that. Like I said, he was outside. He'd seen more than I had. It was hard for him to be positive because there was so much negativity around him. I mean, that same negativity surrounded me too. But if there was one thing my mother instilled in me before she died, it was the importance of gratitude, prayer and positivity.

"How many nights we eat?" I asked him. "How many mornings you come home? Stop talking crazy. Don't leave with that negative ass spirit. You want me to sage your ass down?"

I kept hope. I knew in my spirit that I wouldn't die in The Woods. Neither of us would. I was determined to get Meech out too. There was a lot more to the world than just The Woods. Hell, Brickhaven period. I didn't know where I wanted to go exactly but I knew I wanted to leave. Anywhere in the world would be better than here. I was sure of it.

I might've hated my circumstances, but I was grateful for a roof. Sure, it leaked sometimes, but at least I had one. At least *we* had one. After momma

died and daddy went to prison, I didn't know where we would wind up. I was fourteen—Meech was nineteen. He was a corner boy, selling weed for one of the niggas in the hood, barely making ends meet. That didn't last long though. After everything changed, Meech did too. He went from selling weed for Khaos to making money with the Christ brothers.

He laughed and mushed me in the forehead. "Nah, don't bring that stankin' shit out."

"Shut up, then," I said with a smile, pushing him in the chest. "Don't forget to get cheese on my hashbrowns, nigga. I want extra this time, too."

"I got you. Shoot me a text and remind me. You know my head fucked up."

Meech's head was fucked up.

When we were kids, he got into a fight in the yard with this big nigga named Erick. Erick used to run around The Woods tormenting everybody, bullying them, talking shit, just being an overall asshole. He used to fuck with Meech a lot. For the most part, my brother ignored him, paying him dust. But Erick went from talking shit to trying to push him around since Meech was little and scrawny. That didn't last long. Erick caught Meech on a bad day and despite Erick being taller and bigger, Meech beat the shit out of him. However, at the end of the fight, when Meech was walking away, Erick got up, grabbed him from behind, picked him up and slammed him on the concrete, knocking him out. Everybody thought he was dead. My brother lost so much blood. The paramedics took forever to come, as usual. When they did, they got him on the stretcher and rushed him to Brickhaven Medical Center where he was diagnosed with a massive concussion that could've killed him. After that, his memory was never the same. So, I didn't fault him when he forgot my cheese the last time. It was a blessing that he remembered breakfast at all. Every single time, too.

"Okay. I'll text you," I said as Meech slid through the doorway, past me.

I eyed him, fiddling with the black onyx crystal dangling from my neck, my anxiety starting to rise. I should've been okay. The prayer? It should have been enough. But my nerves were starting to get the best of me. Meech was big on protecting me in the physical—I was big on protecting him in the spiritual.

"Meech," I called out as I reached back to unclasp the necklace from my neck. "Wait."

He stopped walking and looked over his shoulder at me. “What up?”

“Here,” I said, pushing the crystal towards him.

He looked down at it, his thick eyebrows furrowed, unmoving. With the corners of his mouth turned up in a slight frown, he locked eyes with me. I raised my brows at him and eyed him up and down, silently telling him to take it.

Meech took a deep breath, grabbed the crystal from me and stuffed it into the pocket of his joggers, shaking his head. Once the crystal was tucked safely in his pocket, I extended my hand to him, and we did our usual handshake. *Clap, clap, grip.*

We said our I love you’s, he walked out and I made sure to lock up when he did.

* * *

AT SOME POINT, I must’ve fallen asleep because before I knew it, I was being jarred awake by a loud banging sound. With a racing heart, I felt around my bed, looking for my phone. Finally grabbing it from underneath my pillow, I hit the unlock button and squinted up at the time. It was three in the morning. Twelve after. Turning over on my back, I dragged my hand over my forehead until I knocked my bonnet off. With my eyes on the ceiling, I listened to Sean and Sabrina upstairs arguing. Shaking my head, I flinched at the sound of another big bang. He was beating her ass again. On cue, one of the six kids they had started to cry.

Taking a deep breath, I turned over on my side and went through my phone, hitting the message icon. I scrolled to Meech’s messages and opened them, tempted to text him, asking where he was. It was twelve after…no, thirteen after three and he should have been home by now. My thumb hovered over the keypad, hesitating. I was supposed to be sleep. I wasn’t supposed to be up worried about him. If I texted him now he’d know I was worried and I wasn’t supposed to be the one who worried. I was the one who prayed and gave it to God whenever he left the house.

“Fuck it,” I mumbled, as my fingers got to moving.

‘???’ was all I sent before I dropped my phone next to me. My eyes went back to the ceiling, listening to Sean call Sabrina all kinds of bitches and ho’s. She cried. She always cried and begged him to stop. But it was as

if all of her crying just fueled him to do the opposite because her cries got louder and his voice, scarier. Later, when I saw her in passing, she'd have on a headscarf and a pair of dark tinted shades, hiding bruises and shit everybody in The Woods heard her get.

With a deep breath, I tore my eyes away from the popcorn ceiling and shifted them over to the phone, tempted to call him this time. Not even three minutes had passed since I texted him but so what? I was on edge a little. Usually, he'd be home by now. If not laid out on the couch, at least at the door, unlocking it, getting ready to walk in.

I—

Before a could complete my thought, there was banging on the front door. I shook my head, knowing it had to be Sabrina. She did that sometimes too. If things got too bad between her and Sean, she'd run downstairs to the apartment, looking for shelter. She chose us because Meech had whooped on Sean a few times for putting hands on her, and I always kept what happened to myself. I wasn't like the majority of the bitches in The Woods. I kept to myself for the most part, only fucking with my cousins. You wouldn't catch me posted up, gossiping about how Sabrina came to the crib, beat the fuck up, in fear for her life.

I didn't pass judgement.

Wasn't my place to. I just hoped for the best where Sabrina was concerned.

I tossed my thin sheet from my body, and sat on side of the bed, getting up. The banging grew louder. More impatient. I shook my head, slid into my thong sandals and headed out of the room. I adjusted my titties in my tank, stood at the door and got on my tiptoes a little to look out of the peephole. When I did, my eyebrows snapped together and I backed away from it. It wasn't Sabrina. It was the Christ brothers. And the oldest, Exodus, stood in front, eyes centered on the peephole like he knew I was checking it.

What the fuck were they doing here? More specifically… what the fuck was *he* doing here? At three in the morning? At my door? *Our* door?

I sucked in a gust of air that I held onto as I wringed my fingers, staring at the big black metal door. I flinched at the sound of another big thud coming from upstairs. With closed eyes, I tilted my head back and finally released the breath I was holding onto.

"Yeah?" I breathed out, with a shaky voice.

There was silence on the other side of the door for what felt like minutes but couldn't be no more than a couple of seconds.

"Open the door for me real quick," said one of them.

I sucked my teeth, shaking my head. "Hell naw. What the fuck y'all niggas want?"

I scanned my mind, trying to remember who I saw standing out there when I looked through the peephole. Was Zeke with them? *Shit*. I needed to look again, but I was cemented with fear. The Christ boys on my doorstep at three in the morning, after Meech had gone out on a lick didn't sit well with me. And *Exodus* was with them. Standing front line, with a deep furrow in his brows, like he was pissed about something. What the hell had Meech gotten himself into? I went from being cemented with fear, to pacing back and forth in front of the door.

"We can't talk with a door between us, baby girl," one of them said.

I chewed on my bottom lip. "Where Zeke?"

"Right here," he said before I heard him move closer to the door. "It's cool, Rei. Open the door real quick."

I wasn't supposed to open the door.

If it weren't for Meech, I was to keep the door locked. Especially at this time of night. I didn't know what the hell the Christ brothers could have wanted. What if they were here to snatch me up because of something Meech did? What if I opened the door and one of them blew my head off?

I chewed on my bottom lip again, looked at the door and sighed. "Where my brother at, Zeke?"

Silence.

No one said anything and that raised a red flag for me. What the fuck was Zeke doing here without Meech? He was who Meech was with. Whenever my brother went out on a run, it was with Ezekiel fucking Christ. Why was it that he was here but Meech wasn't?

I swallowed, stopped pacing, and stared at the door with wide eyes. "Zeke."

His voice softened. "Sereia… open up for me, sis."

I stepped back away from the door, shaking my head. "Uh uh. Nope. I'm not—"

"Look," said another one of them. "We need you to open the door."

"For what, nigga?" I shouted, as tears sat at the rim of my eyes. "Just… just tell me where the fuck my brother at, Zeke!"

Silence. Once again.

Something was wrong.

Something was horribly wrong.

Again, I swallowed. This time, with a trembling bottom lip. Neither of them said anything but then again… did they really have to? Something happened.

I hurried away from the door, back down the hallway to my room to grab my phone. I snatched it off the bed and quickly hit the phone icon to call my brother. With a heavy heart, I pressed the phone against my ear, listening to it ring.

At the sound of his ringtone sounding nearby, my eyebrows snapped together. Slowly, I followed the sound of the ringing phone until it landed me right back in front of the door. After a couple of seconds, the ringing stopped and someone answered his phone.

“Hello?” I questioned with furrowed brows as I stood on my tiptoes, peering out of the peephole, looking for Meech.

Except, when I looked out, it wasn’t Meech with his phone to his ear. It was Exodus and like before, he was staring at the peephole. This time with a softened expression. This time with less of a furrow in his brow.

My mouth turned down and I stepped away from the door.

“Why do you have my brother’s phone? Where—where is my—”

“Could you please open the door so I can talk to you?”

I hung up on him and wrapped my trembling hand around my phone. They had Meech’s phone. The wheels in my mind started to turn.

Meech left with Zeke.

Zeke was here. With his brothers at three in the morning. Without Meech. With his phone. This wasn’t about something Meech did. This visit was about something else. My brother… he was gone. Either he was locked up or he was dead. Something happened. Something earthshattering. Something that would force Exodus to come to The Woods. This… it was huge. And instead of opening the door to get answers, I was planted, with tears running down my face, trying to figure out what they wanted.

All I had to do was open the door.

All I had to do was let them in. But letting them in… it would change the trajectory of my life. If Meech was dead or in jail, everything about life as I knew it would change. And well… I wasn’t really ready to face the

reality of what it meant to have the Christ brothers on my doorstep at three in the morning.

“Sereia,” said Zeke with a sigh.

Swallowing, I finally stepped forward and undid the chain lock and then untwisted the other locks. It took me a few seconds, but eventually, I opened the door. Not too wide. Just enough to peek my head through, to size them up.

Exodus, standing at over six feet, stepped forward and looked down at me. “Can we come in?”

I shifted my eyes away from his browns and put them on Zeke. “Where my brother?”

“You let us in, we will tell you,” said Exodus.

I watched as Zeke dragged his hand down over his face, visibly stressed. The other brother, Kiss, stood resting against the wall behind them with his hands clasped in front of him, staring at me with dipped brows. There was something behind his eyes that would sit with me for a long time.

Swallowing, I stepped aside, opening the door fully so they could walk inside. I wrapped my arms around myself and stood against the back wall, watching, waiting for them to pile in. There were four Christ brothers, but tonight only three of them stood in my living room. What were they doing here? Things felt weirdly out of place. Although Meech and Zeke were close, they never kicked it here. Zeke only came through in passing and didn't spend no more than five minutes here. The other two? I barely ever saw them. They were widely known in Brickhaven, but they were rarely ever seen.

“What?” I asked, shifting my eyes between them. “*Ezekiel*,” I stressed, centering my eyes on him.

Zeke ran his hand over the top of his head before stepping forward. “Meech—”

Before he could say anything, Exodus put his arm in front of him, stopping him. “Sit down.”

Shaking my head, I tightened my arms around my body. “Just say what you gotta say.”

Exodus nodded and stuffed his hands into the pockets of the black hoodie he wore. “Meech got shot.”

My stomach dropped and I bit down on the side of my lip. With so much force that I drew blood. “Okay… so… my brother dead. You couldn’t just say that?”

I wasn’t surprised.

Why else would they be here? Earlier, I was overthinking, maybe they were here to do some harm to me but that was just overthinking and a bit of denial. I knew what it was the first time I looked out of that peephole and saw them.

Kiss took a deep breath and shook his head. Exodus glanced over at him, before putting his eyes back on me. He shook his head. “Nah baby girl. He’s—they—”

“*Just say it*,” I snapped, giving him a nasty look. “Just say my brother dead.”

I noticed Exodus’s jaw clenched before he said, “We don’t know if he’s dead.”

I pulled my lips into my mouth, nodded and started to pace, tightening my arms around my body.

“Where is he?” I asked.

“Wildermere. They had to take him to Hope General.”

The wheels in my mind got to turning as I thought about where he was. Across the bridge. In Wildermere. While I stood here, all the way in Brickhaven, without a whip.

The questions running through my mind must’ve been clear on my face because not even two minutes later, Exodus said, “Get dressed—I’ll take you.”

* * *

ABOUT TEN MINUTES LATER, I was riding in the backseat of Exodus’s Wagoneer, sitting next to Zeke, biting on my thumbnail, a nervous mess.

Meech was shot.

The chances of him being okay were slim to none. Something in my spirit told me he was dead and that I would never see my brother alive again. It was an uneasy feeling. One that made me nauseous.

I stopped biting on my nail, leaned my head back against the seat and stared out of the window as we sped down the freeway. From where we

were, I could see the bridge. It was some ways away. My vision from here, hazy, but I saw it. The lights illuminating it, drew me in. I hadn't crossed the bridge over into Wildermere since I was a kid. It was a rare occasion. Momma had just gotten her taxes back, so she had a little money to spend. We went to the mall, Battleground Play Den, and out to eat. It was a great day. That was a core memory for me. Whenever I thought about Wildermere, I thought about that day. Now when I thought about it, I'd think of Meech.

I closed my eyes, took in a deep breath and tried to let the sound of Tupac playing at a low-level ease my thoughts.

About twenty, thirty minutes later, we were pulling up in front of Hope General. My chest tightened as the truck came to a halt in front of the emergency room doors. I swallowed, looked over at the building, noticing the hustle and bustle going in inside and I wondered if all of the commotion was about Meech.

"You good?" Zeke asked.

I shook my head, said nothing, but opened the car door anyway. I wasn't good. But that didn't matter.

As soon as my feet touched the pavement, my legs wobbled. Before taking a step, I paused, stuffed my hands into the pockets of my favorite pink hoodie and took a deep breath. A cool breeze swept across my face as I looked up at the building, with a racing heart. I shouldn't have had to do this alone. My momma was supposed to be here. She was supposed to grip my hand, lead me inside and tell me everything would be okay.

A couple of seconds later, the truck sped off and I started inside. Walking through the revolving doors felt like a dream. I was greeted by subtle elevator music, smiling faces, and bright lights. The hospital's entry way was luxurious, with windows that touched the high celling. Hope General was nothing like Brickhaven Medical Center. As soon as you walked into BMC, you were greeted by angry security guards, metal detectors, arguing, and staff that paid you no attention. I hoped like hell that the atmosphere matched the care. Maybe Meech would stand a chance.

"Hi! How can I help you?" asked the woman behind the reception desk, wearing a soft smile.

A white lady wearing too much blush and bright pink lipstick pasted on her unlined, thin lips. I felt like I was in a completely different world. Ninety percent of the staff at BMC were black. And if they were white, they

were unpolished and disgruntle with shitty attitudes. They for sure didn't work the reception desk. There was always a loud, obnoxious ghetto bitch with an attitude working when I went in.

"Hi. I think my brother was brought in. He was shot."

She squinted, and tapped around on her computer, most likely checking the admission list. "We did have a John Doe brought in about an hour and a half ago that matches that description."

What description? I didn't tell her shit about him. But then again, how many black men are brought into Hope General with a gunshot wound? Instead of making it a race thing, I brushed it off and chalked it up to common sense.

"Okay. His name is Demetrius Wilson," I said, feeling a little antsy. Wrapping my arm around my body, I softly asked, "Where is he?"

My heart beat heavily against my chest as I waited for her to answer me. I just knew that the next words to come out of her mouth would be 'he died' or 'sorry, he didn't make it'. Heat radiated through my body, as I gulped, staring over at her with wide eyes as she took her sweet time telling me he was in surgery.

Before I thanked her and walked away to sit in the waiting area, she said she'd keep me updated on his progress. With a deep breath, I plopped down on one of the soft cushioned chairs and stuffed my hands into the pockets of my hoodie. My eyes shifted over to the big, black clock sitting on the wall in front of me. I watched the second hand tick past the number twelve, turning what was 4:03AM to 4:04AM.

I tapped the back of my iPhone, trying to decide if I was going to call his baby momma right now or not. I mean, I should've right? She needed to know. But the thought of Desiree coming down here on that ghetto shit made me uncomfortable. Hope General was quiet, with the exception of that elevator music. The minute she walked in, it would be a shit show. She was so fucking theatrical and extra.

Still.

Regardless of how I felt about the bitch, I needed to call her. Right before I could pull my phone from my pocket, I noticed the revolving doors to the entrance open and shortly after, the Christ brothers walked in. My stomach dropped. I thought they left me. It wouldn't have mattered if they did. I was fully prepared to go through this alone, but it did feel nice not to have to.

Zeke sat next to me. Leviticus and Exodus, across from me.

“What they say?” Zeke asked.

I pulled the phone from my pocket and sifted through my contact list. “He’s in surgery. She said she’ll keep me updated.” I glanced over at him and then back down at the phone. “How many times was he shot, Zeke?”

He stroked his short beard and shook his head with raised brows. “Shit, sis, I don’t know—”

“How many gunshots did you hear?” I cut in, my knee bouncing profusely as I stared down at Desiree’s name.

I felt like I was holding it together pretty good. I was handling shit. Letting things be. I hadn’t overreacted. Had only dropped a few tears. I’d been strong. But I didn’t know how I’d react when I called her. When she exploded in tears. Would I be able to hold it together then? While listening to someone break the way I should have?

“I didn’t keep count,” Zeke flatly said. “That bitch was ringin’ off though.”

“And you left him,” I mumbled. “You got in the car and—”

“I did what I had to do,” Zeke said. “What was I supposed to do, Rei? Run back for him? Catch a couple slugs my damn self? I was—"

I jumped up from my seat and walked away; phone pressed against my ear. I didn’t want to hear shit else Zeke had to say. What he said was pointless and wouldn’t change the situation. Meech was shot. He left him. And as hard as it was to digest, he did do what he could. I cut my eyes over at Exodus and Leviticus and he was watching me. Exodus. Leviticus had his phone to his ear, talking at a low level. Slightly, I frowned, and looked away, listening to the sound of Desiree’s phone go to voicemail.

With another sigh, I called again. This time, she answered with an attitude.

“He ain’t here, Sereia. Call that dirty bitch Tata. I’m sure she know where the fuck he at.”

I bit down on my bottom lip, rolled my eyes, and said, “Meech got shot. We at Hope General.”

“Wha—what?”

“Meech got—”

“*Noooo*!” she cried.

I took the phone from my ear and looked up at the high ceiling, my eyes centered on the beautiful silver chandelier. With my phone away from my

ear, I could still hear her screaming and crying. She didn't even know his condition… didn't even ask questions… just went right to being negative. But shit, didn't I? When they knocked on my door, I just knew my brother was dead. I couldn't fault her, I guess. Still, the shit irritated me. So bad, that I didn't even return to the phone. I just hung up.

After about an hour, Desiree and her sister walked into the hospital. I watched as she walked over to the reception desk. She had on a bonnet, little ass pajama shorts, a bralette, and knock off UGGs. A hot ass mess. Meech was Desiree's third baby daddy. I hated that my brother fucked with so many hood rats. But then again, he didn't really have much to choose from. Brickhaven was flooded with rats. Especially The Woods.

The receptionist pointed over to us and Desiree looked over her shoulder. A second later, she hurried over to where I was sitting, greeting me with a hug I didn't want. I didn't like to be touched. So, when she wrapped her arms around me, I cringed. Still, she held me tighter, ignoring how uncomfortable I was. When her sister tried to hug me, I crossed my arms over my chest and deepened the frown in my brow. She got the picture, because right after, she sat next to Exodus, speaking to them with a big smile on her face. Typical hood rat. The bitches in The Woods loved the Christ brothers. Especially Exodus's mean, standoffish ass. Zeke was a regular in the hood, so people rarely paid him any mind. Leviticus held just as much weight as Exodus. They were rarely seen so anytime a bitch saw them they were overly going.

"What y'all doing here?" Desiree asked, shifting her eyes between the brothers. Nobody said anything. She sucked her teeth and sat on the other side of me. "What did she tell you, Sereia?"

"That they would update me when there was a change. He's in surgery," I said, staring across the room at the TV on the wall, playing a game show I'd never seen before.

She sighed. "How long you been up here?"

"'Bout two hours," I flatly replied.

"They should know something by now! What the fuck?" She started to get up and I stopped her.

"Relax. You think I want to sit here waiting? Just wait. The longer they take, the better."

That's how I saw it.

If Meech was in surgery for a long time, then he had a fighting chance. Things were progressing in a good way. I might've been wrong, but that was how I saw it. I wanted my brother to be taken care of real good. And if that meant waiting hours for that to happen then so be it. I was on pins and needles, but I didn't want to rush them. Des' needed to chill the fuck out. She didn't have any pull here. Shit, she didn't have pull *anywhere*. She was just Meech's baby momma. Nothing more, nothing less. They weren't even together the two times he got her pregnant.

She sucked her teeth, sat up, and looked over at the reception desk. "Fuck out of here. Ain't no muthafuckin way she ain't got an update yet. They probably takin they slow ass time 'cause we black. I don't put shit past these bitches."

She was loud. The other people in the waiting area looked over at us with their noses turned up. We were in fucking Wildermere—that ghetto, loud, hood rat shit did not fly out here. She needed to calm down because the security guard would for sure throw her raggedy ass out if she didn't.

"Chill," said Exodus, in a low tone, his eyes centered on Des.

She sucked her teeth again, turned the corners of her mouth up and 'chilled'. Of course she did. I had told her to relax but what did she do? The opposite of that. One word from Exodus and she was sitting back against her seat with her arms crossed over her chest.

Another two hours passed.

Zeke had his head tossed back against the chair, eyes closed, snoring. Leviticus was off his phone, arms crossed over his chest, struggling to stay awake. Desiree and her sister were asleep. Exodus was up with his face in his phone and had been for the past hour. I hadn't dosed off once. The game show had switched to the morning news, which was on cue with the sun rising.

Yep.

Sun was up. Shift had changed, too. The receptionist had been swapped out for another white chick. A younger blonde who kept looking over at the black people in the middle of the room.

There still hadn't been an update and I was growing impatient. With a deep breath, I pulled my hands out of my pockets and stood up to walk over to the receptions desk.

Before I could get there, someone yelled, "The family of Demetrius uh… Wilson?"

Quickly, I looked over my shoulder with pinched brows. Pivoting, I turned around and headed over to the older white man in scrubs, holding a tablet. At the sound of Demetrius's name, Desiree and them woke up, Exodus put his phone into his pocket, and Leviticus's attention steadied.

"Yes?" I asked, with a racing heart.

He paused, looked down at his tablet, and then back up at me again. When his eyes softened and he pursed his lips, I knew what would come next. Knowing didn't soften the blow that came next though.

"I'm sorry—we did all we could. There was an immense amount of internal bleeding we couldn't stop. We worked on him for hours and—"

"Thank you," I interrupted, turning on my toes, feeling like the world was crashing down on me.

My feet were heavy. My shoulders too. My entire body, really. Nothing felt real. And when the room began to spin, I lost my footing, damn near falling onto the floor. But before I could, I was caught by Exodus. Instead of pulling away like I wanted to, I buried my face into his chest and finally broke down.

I don't know how long I stood there crying into his chest before I was led out of the hospital, through the parking lot, to his car. Time felt funny. Life felt funny. It was as if something shifted the moment the words 'I'm sorry' left that doctors lips.

Meech was dead.

My brother.

The only person I truly had left, was gone.

It was just me now. No mother. No father. No brother. Just me. I always said I didn't want to lose Meech. Always said since one of us had to eventually live without the other, that I wanted it to be me that left first. The pain that came with losing was too much for me to bare. I couldn't do another funeral. Momma's for me, was one and done. But look at what happened. Look at me now. I'd have to do another one. And this time, I wouldn't have anyone to swap reminiscent stories with. This time, I wouldn't have my brother there to hold me up. I'd have to suffer through it alone.

How could a family of four be reduced to just a family of one like that?

The ride back to The Woods was quiet. A blur, really. Spent with my head resting against the window, with my eyes closed. Thought of Meech and the last words I spoke to him. I swallowed and tears seeped through my

closed lids as I thought about our handshake and those final I love you's. We were supposed to have breakfast in a couple of hours. We were supposed to have more time…

When the car came to a halt in front of my building, I didn't bulge. I was in no rush to go back to that apartment. I just… I needed a minute. They gave me that too. Sat there, quiet, idling in front of the building in silence for I don't know how long before Zeke got out to open my door. He stood back, held his hand out for me to grab and I ignored it. With heavy shoulders and a pounding headache, I stepped out of the car without his help.

I walked towards the building, climbing the dirty, rickety staircase, the sound of birds chirping and my feet pattering against the metal stairs filling my ears. My bottom lip quivered the closer I got to the top of them. Heart raced too. My life was about to change. Majorly. Meech was all I had left. Yes, I had family in The Woods but that didn't matter. The family I came from? It'd been reduced to just me. And I wasn't sure if I would survive out here alone.

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CHAPTER 2

EXODUS



"SHIT WASN'T SUPPOSED TO GO DOWN LIKE THAT, BRO," ZEKE SAID, repeating the same thing he said when he called me hours ago. "It was supposed to be easy. We were supposed to be in and out. Simple. Fuck was that nigga even doin' there? Shorty said he was working. Said he wouldn't be off until five. The house was supposed to be empty."

"That's not the point," Kiss said, pulling from the blunt before attempting to pass it to me. I declined, gripped the steering wheel, and sped out of the parking lot at The Woods.

I'd just dropped Zeke's boy Meech little sister off. He was killed. Murked because my fucking brother didn't know how to follow direct orders. If it weren't for him going behind my back, making plays he wasn't supposed to make, Meech would still be breathing.

"You niggas weren't supposed to be there at all."

Zeke sucked his teeth. I watched him in the rearview mirror as he slouched into the seat, arms crossed over his heaving chest, his top lip curled up like he was ready to kill some shit. "It was an easy lick—"

"An *unnecessary* lick," Kiss cut in. "Fuck what we said, huh?"

I didn't say anything. I let Leviticus do all of the talking. Talking he shouldn't have been doing. Talking he wouldn't have had to do if Zeke had listened.

I was too pissed off to say anything, so I drove in silence. I tried to at least. Every five minutes or so, Zeke opened his mouth with the same sorry ass excuse and Leviticus played into it, giving him conversation I wouldn't. When I was mad, I was quiet. I'd said enough. I didn't repeat myself.

Didn’t have a need to. If I said something, I said it with finality. Rather a nigga took heed or not wasn’t up to me.

Subtly, I shook my head and bit down on my teeth, clenching my jaw. I twisted the steering wheel, took my eyes off the road, and put them back on the rearview mirror.

“Run it back,” I said, finally speaking up, my eyes locked on Zeke when they should have been on what was in front of me.

He uncomfortably shifted around in his seat, tore his eyes away from me and looked out of the window. “I don’t want to keep replayin’—”

“You think I give a fuck?” I said through gritted teeth. “*Run it back, nigga*.”

He sighed and ran his hands down over the front of his black jeans. Shaking his head, he turned the corners of his mouth up and ran the story back. “We got to the spot. Put the code in. Walked in and—”

“Oh, so *that’s* how the night started, huh?”

He didn’t say anything and I continued to stare at him through the rearview until Kiss roughly tapped me on the arm to pull my attention away from him and back on the road. Again, I bit down on my teeth, clenching my jaw as I pressed down on the brakes, a few inches away from colliding with the car in front of me, idling at a red light. Once I was stopped, I put my eyes back on my baby brother, waiting for him to start the story where I wanted him to start it.

“I left ma’s house—”

“On your way out of the crib, what Genny say?”

I watched as his Adam’s apple rose and fell. “Told me to be careful because she had a bad feeling.”

I tugged on my beard, with my mouth turned down. “Mmh. And then what?”

Again, he shook his head and looked away, out of the window.

“Eyes on me, nigga,” I gritted.

“You pulled me to the side, asked what that was about and I told you nothing.”

I nodded. “You lied.”

“*Maaaan*,” he pouted. “Like I said—”

“Fuck what you said,” I cut in. “She have a bad feeling, fuck you supposed to do? Shit, fuck the bad feeling… fuck were you *not* supposed to do, Zeke?”

Shifting my eyes to the road, then back to the rearview, they met his. His nostrils flared and he looked off, running his hand over his wild locs. “Bro.”

“Simple question,” Kiss said, his voice slightly muffled by weed smoke.

“Hit licks.”

“Exactly. Why is that baby bro?” Kiss continued, as I pulled off from the green light, listening. Quiet again. I didn’t want to hear him bitch and moan about how shit wasn’t supposed to go ‘that way’. I wanted to hear him talk about why he wasn’t supposed to be out there in the first place, making petty runs, hitting stupid ass licks.

We’d evolved from that shit. Years ago, when we were down on our knuckles, figuring shit out, we were in Wildermere, hitting licks regularly. Breaking in houses was our go to. It kept us fed but about three years ago, we stopped. However, Ezekiel was addicted to the rush running in cribs gave him. He was an adrenaline junky who didn’t like the pace we were moving at now. He needed action. He *always* needed action. Since he was a little nigga, the thrill of everything excited him. That was where shit got complicated and we butted heads.

“Because we—”

“Fuck is we?” Kiss interrupted.

Zeke shifted around in his seat again, let out a sigh and shook his head. “*I*. I don’t need to do that shit no more.”

“Exactly. So why the fuck you out there on nut shit for, bro? Look at what happened. We gotta clean that shit up—not you.”

“Finish,” I said, eyes on the road, nostrils flaring.

I didn’t give too much of a fuck about the story. Him reciting it, replaying it… reliving it wasn’t for me. I didn’t want to keep listening to it because I was looking for loopholes or a spot where they could have gone wrong. I wanted him to keep reciting it because I wanted him to feel it. I wanted it to sink in. I wanted him to hurt behind it. Was it fucked up? Possibly. Did I give a fuck? Nah. It was psychological. I felt like if he talked about it enough… if he saw the bullets his man’s took, he would sit with it. He would rethink his decisions, and it would really sink in. The mistake he made. Not the mistake he made by trusting a bitch, but the mistake he made by going out there in the first place when he wasn’t supposed to.

He'd been doing it for a minute now. He thought he was getting away with something. Thought he was doing something behind my back. Thought I didn't know about it. But I knew. I knew every single time him, Meech and Cash took them trips to Wildermere Falls. Usually, when they took them, I had someone looking after them. I did my due diligences and looked into the lick myself. I didn't do that this time. Not because I didn't give a fuck about my brothers wellbeing but because I was tired. Tired of him blatantly lying in my face. Tired of using resources to make sure he was straight when he shouldn't have been out there in the first place. Didn't matter how tired I was though. The fall out behind the lick going wrong would have to be handled by me, anyway. There was no winning in this situation for real. The only thing I hoped came out of it would be him finally deciding to listen and sit his bitch ass the fuck down.

Ezekiel was the youngest boy out of the bunch. It was five of us. Moms had us back-to-back. Me—I was the oldest. Leviticus was under me, Solomon after him, then Ezekiel with our baby sister, Genesis, following behind him. As a given, I was the ring leader. I didn't have a problem with that. I took pride in being the oldest. It was just when shit like this happened, because a muthafucka veered off the plan, that it got to me. I might've been pissed at Zeke but ultimately, I was the blame for what happened tonight. I let this go on for too long without bringing it to him. Instead of sitting him down, letting him know I knew what was going on months ago, I decided to play a game. I decided to let him fall on his ass. That was because despite knowing things would eventually go south, I didn't expect Meech to lose his life behind it.

The rest of the ride back to our side of town was quiet. I didn't play any music, neither. Kiss would usually go for the AUX, but because he knew I was in a fucked-up mood, he didn't touch it. When I was upset, people knew to tread lightly. I was known to have a short fuse when I was taken to a certain point. It was usually best to stay out of my way, keep quiet, and let me cool off. Which was what my brothers did until I dropped them off.

I pulled into my driveway and hit the garage opener on my phone. When I pulled in, I closed the garage and killed the engine. Closing my eyes, I rested my head against the headrest and thought of Meech's little sister. I didn't know her. Not for real. I just knew her as Meech's little sister. He didn't talk about her much, but I knew they were all they had. She was young. Stuck in the jungle without her brother. For the most part, I minded

my business, looking at peoples circumstances as their own to deal with but because Zeke pulled the nigga in on a job he shouldn't have been on, I felt for her. Yeah, Meech made a choice. He decided to hit that lick but the only reason he made moves with Zeke was because he thought I okayed it. Zeke hadn't only lied to me—he lied to his niggas too.

"Dumb ass nigga," I muttered before I grabbed my phone and got out of the whip.

* * *

"WHERE YOU GO LAST NIGHT?"

I lifted my eyes from the bowl of cereal I was digging into and put them on Jada, my girl. "What?"

She tied the belt to her black Versace robe tighter around her waist. "Last night. You left. Where did you go?"

"Out to handle business."

She squinted. "Out to handle business at—"

"Yeah," I quickly replied, dismissing her.

Me and Jada had been together for a few years. I'd known her since we were little though. She used to come to the church my family owned with her granny and we kind of grew based off that. We were just close. Used to talk and play around but that was about it. Were kids. There was no attraction. It wasn't until after my pops passed away that we grew closer. Her granny came around a lot during that time, dropping food off and shit and she was always there. From that point, we were kind of inseparable and when I needed her, she was there. Which was what landed us where we were today—together. It would be nice to say we had an unbreakable bond and that I loved her with all of me, but we didn't and I didn't. Jada was loyal and in exchange for her loyalty, I took care of her. We took care of each other.

She took a deep breath and sat on the barstool beside me. "Something happened?"

I nodded. "It's under control now."

Jada brushed her hand over the top of her head, fingering through her curly coils. "Good. I wanted to go across the bridge—"

"For what?" I interrupted.

She shrugged. “I miss my daddy.”

I stabbed at the cereal, looked over at her, and stabbed at it again before getting a spoonful and putting it in my mouth. I didn’t want her across the bridge. There was nothing across the bridge but bullshit, drama, and murder. The main reason she was here in the first place.

We stayed in Wildermere Falls. However, I spent the majority of my time in Brickhaven. It was home for me. Shit, it was home for her too. But the difference between she and I was that I could walk around that bitch freely, without an escort because I was who I was. She should have been held to that same regard, being that she was attached to me, but I was wise enough to know that niggas, respectful or not, looked at Jada as a target to get to me. However, she wouldn’t look at it like that. She’d get on the block with her peoples and drop awareness. Her head was never on a swivel. She was never on her P’s and Q’s. Lanchester—the street she grew up on—was home to her. She thought she had love there. And while she might’ve at one point, all of that shit flipped when she got involved with me.

I was widely known and heavily respected all over Brickhaven, MI. I was the eldest Christ. Of course I was. The name held weight and respect. Not because of me but because of my father, Isaiah. The church Jada and I grew up in was owned and ran by him. He was the pastor. Known, loved, and honored throughout the community. And because we came from him, that same love, honor and respect was extended to his children. His wife, my mother, too. But after he passed away, and we grew up, things shifted. We went from just being loved, honored, and respected to being feared too. And with fear came a lot of mistakes. None made by me and mine—a ton made by niggas who didn’t know how to navigate around that fear.

“Exodus…”

I looked over at her and with a mouth full of corn flakes, asked, “What?”

“I want to go see my daddy.”

“In other words, you want to run around the hood all day, trying to find that nigga.”

She went quiet for a minute, putting her hands between her legs. From the corner of my eye, I noticed her shoulders rise and fall with a deep sigh.

“He’s always one of three places. It won’t be hard.”

I looked up from the bowl to the microwave at the digital numbers, before looking back at her. “Aight. I’ll get up with Rocc in a minute. Redd

tied up.”

She smiled and threw her arm over my neck before showering my cheek with kisses. “Okay. Thank you bae. I promise it won’t take long. After I see him, do you want to go to dinner? I been craving Steak 52.”

I finished my bowl of cereal and slid it across the island, away from me. “Depends on how long I’m held up at ma’s.”

“How was she yesterday?”

“How she always is,” I said with a shrug. “Hopefully shit goes smooth with ol’ girl.”

“I hope so too. You’ve been over there a lot lately. You sure she’s not getting worse?”

“I don’t know,” I said, crossing my arms over my chest, staring off into the distance, thinking about my OG. “Hopefully I’ll know somethin soon tho’.”

She wasn’t okay. Hadn’t been okay for years. It wasn’t that she was sick. Not with an illness or anything like that. It was mental. Pops was murdered and she flipped. Went from mothering us, with a smile, handling business to a shell of that. All she did was stare off, humming. Sometimes she’d stare off, humming, with tears rolling down her face. These days though, the tears and the humming had flipped to smiles and giggling. I would say that was a nice change, but it wasn’t. It was alarming.

I took a deep breath, uncrossed my arms, and rested my elbows on the island, picking my phone up. I texted Rocc, telling him I needed him at the house by three. He responded almost instantly, letting me know he couldn’t be here until after five. His BM had a doctor’s appointment, and they had to handle house shit afterward.

I brushed my hand down over my head and shifted my eyes over at Jada who was setting her phone up to record herself opening the door to the pantry. She was on that social media, influencer shit. Social media was all she did. Jada hadn’t worked since we made things official and she moved in with me. She loved that shit too. Keeping her face in a camera, telling people her business. I didn’t fuck with it. She kept me off her page, so I didn’t really give a fuck about her being on it. For a while, I was iffy about her filming in the crib but after a lot of convincing and promising to keep the address and street name off that shit, I let her do her. It kept her busy enough to keep her out of my business.

“How much longer that shit gon’ take?” I asked.

She closed the pantry, sat her coffee shit down and looked over at me. “About thirty minutes, X,” she said, annoyed. “If you don’t want your arm in it like last time, you might want to leave the kitchen.”

That was all I showed. Pieces of me. Not purposely, but because she was always in the way with that shit. She loved it though. To a point where I felt like she got little pieces of me in videos on purpose, just so her comments would blow up. The first time it happened, her views skyrocketed and people were calling me Mr. Incognito. She thought it was cute. I didn’t feel anything towards it. I thought social media was filled with a lot of fuckin’ weirdos.

“You need to hurry up and get ready. Rocc ain’t takin’ you. I am.”

She paused in the middle of loading coffee beans in her espresso maker and looked up at me with a hiked brow. “*You’re* taking me?”

It wasn’t that she was surprised. She didn’t want me to take her. Any other time, Jada would love to be a passenger princess but only if I wasn’t going to her hood. Only if I wasn’t taking her to see her pops.

“You want to see your daddy, right?”

Her bottom lip extended a little before she shrugged. “Yeah…”

“So, relax,” I told her, my eyes locked on hers.

She nodded, exhaled, and pressed record on her phone.

* * *

A FEW HOURS LATER, I was riding through Jada’s hood. She was antsy. Fidgeting with all of the unnecessary shit dangling from her Chanel. Damn near the whole ride out here, she was quiet. Either scrolling on her phone or looking out of the window. I didn’t address it. Faced a blunt, with my music up to the max. She wanted to see her fuckin’ daddy, she was going to see her fuckin’ daddy. By the way she was acting, I thought about bringing her out here every time she wanted to see him, since it was such a fuckin’ problem.

When I turned the corner, onto Lanchester heads turned. The basketball game in the middle of the street, seized. The little nigga dribbling a ball I provided, chucked his chin as I did about five miles per hour my way through the crowd. In return, I chucked mine. Pulling from my blunt one

last time, I put it out in the ashtray and hit the volume button on my steering wheel, lowering the music.

“Fix your face,” I told Jada. “I ain’t on shit.”

She was worried because the last time I was on Lanchester, I damn near killed a nigga. Well, not the last time. The time before that. I didn’t start it. I was provoked. If I did something like that, it usually was because someone had taken me to that level. I didn’t walk around starting shit with niggas. For what? I had too much going on. Too much to lose. I didn’t partake in low level nigga shit anymore. Back in the day, I ran around, terrorizing shit. These days, as a twenty-seven-year-old man with war wounds, a short prison stay under his belt, and a lot of shit to do, I played it cool. I might’ve been chill these days but that didn’t mean niggas could say whatever and get away with it. Had Q kept his mouth shut with the funny shit, what happened to him wouldn’t have happened.

Stopping in front of her childhood home, I shifted the car in park and killed the engine.

“Yeah, you weren’t on shit then neither. You just—”

“I just what?”

She pulled her shoulders up to her ears, and gripped the handle to her purse, clearly uncomfortable. “Can’t take a joke. You know how niggas out here play.”

I ran my tongue over my bottom lip and stared off at the crowd of niggas shooting dice on the sidewalk a couple of houses down. Instead of paying attention to what they had going on, their eyes were on me. Q stood in the crowd with them, eyes on me, blunt dangling from his crooked bottom lip, eyebrows furrowed, mean mugging. I snorted, pinched the bridge of my nose and turned my attention to Jada.

“Nah. Something tells me that funny shit over with,” I said, sitting up. “Come on. I got shit to do. Ain’t trying to be out here all fuckin day on a dummy mission.”

“How you know it’s a dummy mission, Exodus? If you didn’t want to bring me, you didn’t have to. Flat out—”

“Man, shut yo ass up and get out,” I Interrupted, stepping out of the car.

I looked up and down the block, before my eyes landed on Q’s ugly ass mug again. His shit was twisted. Hadn’t always been that way though. Before he decided to be a comedian around this bitch, cracking jokes, he was an aight lookin’ nigga. Could pull bitches, easy. His face wasn’t

contorted to what it was contorted to after I went across it with the butt of my blick damn near a dozen times.

Q shook his head, looked away, passed the blunt, and put his attention back on the dice game. I smirked and walked off, heading up to the house with Jada on side of me. She threw her hand up at the neighbors on the porch. Old bitches that couldn't stand the sight of me. Shit, I was most hated around this bitch, for real. Before I did Q dirty, they had love for me. Every time I came through, they asked about my OG and the family. Greeted me with sweet smiles and offered me food too. These days, they didn't greet me at all. Just turned their noses up and whispered under their breath. I didn't give a fuck. Like I said before, what happened to Q only happened to him because he provoked me.

How? What'd he say? Made a couple of jokes about how I used to be called Church Boy. Talked about how me and my brothers used to walk around the community with flyers, asking niggas to join the youth choir and volunteer. Said we used to be corny, rocking suits in the middle of the summer, looking about as hot as the hell we tried to keep them out of. Nobody laughed. He kept going though. That was who he was. A clown. A nigga that got off on making muthafuckas laugh. He thought he was hilarious. And had he been talking about another family, maybe niggas would have cracked a smile. None of them did. They kept looking back and forth between Q and I, probably confused by the light smile I wore while he told stories everybody had been around to witness.

I let him get off. Let him crack a couple jokes. But I kept count. Three was my limit. And before he could get the full sentence of the third joke out, I went off in his shit. Knocked him right on his ass. Didn't give the nigga time to recover before I went across his face with my gun. People from the neighborhood swarmed around us. Niggas tried to pull me off him. Jada did too. But I didn't let up. Not until I was covered in blood, he was unconscious and I was satisfied with the way his mouth was chewed up.

I wasn't ashamed of who I was and where I came from. I took honor in it. Even then, I was aight with walking around the neighborhood, spreading the gospel. I did that shit with a smile. I never gave a fuck about fitting in or wanting to be the toughest nigga in the crowd. I didn't have to do any of that. Because despite running around the hood with my brothers, with pamphlets and shit, niggas knew what it was. I was Church Boy. We were Isaiah's boys. Pastor's kids. We might've been in church faithfully any time

the doors were open, but that didn’t mean we were bitches. Back then, we fucked niggas up with crosses dangling from our necks, in the same suits niggas talked shit about. We were religious—not bitches. You’d think Q would have watched his mouth, considering my reputation, but he thought we were cool because I chopped it up with him and helped his momma out with a couple bills. His jokes might’ve been innocent, but I saw beneath the shit. He was trying to little boy me. Bitch me. And that would never sit well with me.

Jada and I walked up on the porch and dug around her purse for the key to the house. While she looked, I stood behind her, hands stuffed into my pockets, surveying the block. After a couple of seconds, she unlocked the door, opened it, and a stench hit me as soon as she did.

I pinched my nostrils, shook my head, and crossed the threshold to walk inside. The house was a mess. There were bottles, trash, and shit all over the place. The coffee table was littered with beer bottles, drug paraphernalia, unfinished food and a bunch of other shit. There were bottles of piss scattered around the living room, as if there wasn’t a working bathroom in this bitch.

“I can’t believe this shit,” mumbled Jada, stepping over a mountain of trash.

I could.

She paid professional cleaners to declutter and clean the house a couple of weeks ago. When she facetimed me, showing me the house after it was finished, I knew she was excited for nothing. I knew it would only be a matter of time before Johnny came back and fucked the house up like he always did. Jada didn’t want to admit it, but her childhood home had turned into one of the many crack spots around the hood.

“Daddy!” She yelled, calling out for a nigga that wasn’t around.

The house was too still.

Before she could walk around, I put my arm out, blocking her and stepped in front of her.

“Wait by the door. I’ll look for ‘em,” I told her, before walking away.

With a deep breath, shaking my head, I stepped over a few pieces of trash, walking around the small house. It was murky as hell around this bitch. Dust particles filled the air, needles, and crack baggies were scattered about too.

Glancing over my shoulder, I spotted her pacing with tears running down her face. She was looking down at her phone, probably getting ready to call the cleaners again. I couldn't understand her fixation with this shit. She should have let it go. The house, the hope, and her piece of shit daddy too. But Jada wasn't like that. She clung to things. I didn't just know that because she had me buy her childhood home and constantly wanted to come out here and look for her father. I knew because she clung on to me. Not in a clingy, I always want to be around you way. But in a way that kept her in this relationship or whatever the fuck you want to call it, for longer than she should have.

I took care of her.

Made sure she was fed, her bank account stayed laced, and her ass stayed in the latest, flyest shit, but I wasn't a good nigga. I kept Jada around for convenience and because I felt like looking out for her was an obligation. Like I said, she was loyal. Held a nigga down. Was there for me when I was at my lowest. Did a short bid with me too. But there wasn't any love attached there. Not on my end.

Anyway.

After going through every room in the house, I made it back to the front door where she had her phone pressed against her ear.

"Yeah. The house on Lanchester. You cleaned it a couple of weeks ago. When can you—huh? *You don't want to*? I'll triple—okay, fuck it then. Unprofessional ass bitch!" She hung up and looked up at me with dipped brows, tears staining her makeup covered face.

"He ain't here," I flatly told her, unmoved by her emotions.

"Can we—"

"Yeah, come on."

"The bitch don't want to clean the house. I was ready to give her triple what I paid her before. You think you can get a company from Wildermere to come down—"

As we walked out of the door, I shot her a look over my shoulder. Fuck no. I couldn't get anybody from Wildermere to come down here.

"Hell naw. You know them muthafuckas ain't coming across the bridge for shit. They don't give a fuck about money. They laced. You need to just let this shit go."

She looked up at me with pleading eyes, sighed, and looked away, scratching at the back of her head. "I can't let it go, Exodus."

Of course she couldn’t.

Despite growing up in the trenches, with crackhead parents, Jada was hopeful. That clinging… it kept her delusional, low key. Clinging, and wanting to live a certain lifestyle was why she got into that social media shit in the first place. When we were younger, before Instagram and TikTok were a thing, she stayed with her face in magazines like Vogue, Home and Design, and Autotrader, talking about the life she was going to live. She didn’t strive for it though. Not academically, anyway.

Jada talked about getting with a white man from Wildermere who would fund her entire life and put her parents in good rehabs. I sat back and listened to her, barely saying shit, thinking like… this bitch out her mind. Them white muthafuckas in Wildermere wouldn’t look in her direction. They didn’t have to though, apparently. Because as soon as I came up, most of her dreams came true. *I* put her in a crib in Wildermere. *I* put her in a Benz. The only thing I hadn’t done and wouldn’t do is put her people in rehab. Well… her pops. Her momma, Justine, died from an overdose when we were little. I wasn’t one for clinging. Johnny didn’t want help. Fuck was I supposed to do with that?

When we made it back outside, Jada asked the neighbors if they had seen her daddy. Ms. Ethel told her she saw him at the gas station a couple of hours ago with Buddy and Brenda, up to no good. Hussein, the gas station owner, put them out for panhandling and trying to steal.

We walked around the hood, heading to the next destination in silence. Every now and then, I’d glance over at her and she’d be crying.

“I’m sorry,” Jada mumbled, as we climbed the creaky, wobbly steps to the crack house Johnny was usually at.

“Ain’t got shit to be sorry about,” I said, looking over my shoulder at her.

I wasn’t into what she had going on where Johnny was concerned. I hated the shit, for real. But despite how I felt about it, her tears started to fuck with me a little. If she wanted to go to four, five more houses, I’d take her if it meant satisfying her in whatever way.

I stood at the door, twisted the doorknob and gave the door a push. When I pushed it, it didn’t open. There was some resistance, like there was something behind it, so I pushed it again with my shoulder. Once the door was a little wider, I looked down at the pair of boney legs, and dirty Adidas blocking the path.

“Hold up, muthafucka,” said the fiend laid out on the floor.

I sucked my teeth and gave the door another hard push, making my way in.

“Wait,” I tossed over my shoulder at Jada who stood there with her arms crossed over a chest and a frown on her face.

Stepping over the pair of legs, I crossed the threshold over into the crib. Like the crib before, there was a stench. Except this one was heavier. It littered the air, damn near suffocating me.

I stood at the front of the room, scanning it, looking for Johnny’s skinny, cracked out ass. The house was packed. Crowded with fiends laid out on the couch and on the floor, some moaning and groaning, others passed out. I shook my head, with a deep breath after spotting him sitting at a card table in the dining room, head tossed back, eyes closed.

I walked further into the crib, stepping over a couple of bodies and trash. When I made it to the dining area, I snatched him up by the collar of his dingy, holey, white tee. His body was limp. He didn’t respond at all to me yoking him up. When I got him on his wobbly legs, I went across his face with my hand.

“Johnny!” I yelled.

His yellow-tinted eyes lazily opened. “Huh?” He slurred.

I went across his face with my hand again. “Tighten up, bitch ass nigga. Jada here.”

“J-Jada?” he stuttered, coming to a bit more.

“Yeah, *Jada*.”

He cleared his throat and tightened up like I told him to. He dragged his boney, ashy hands down over his frail face. His jaundiced eyes bounced around the room before they landed on me.

“Exodus. What up, nigga?” He spoke, staggering a bit.

“Jada,” I said, standing in front of him as he began to nod off. I went across his face again and adjusted the stretched-out collar to his dingy shirt. I stepped back, giving him a once over. When he started to nod off again, I shook my head and again, went across his face.

“Ay nigga!” I yelled.

He flinched and dragged his hand over his mouth. “Alright, alright.”

Shaking my head, I eyed him up and down, as he tugged at the waistband of jeans that were two, three sizes too big, and just as dingy as the shirt he wore. I wanted to do something to make the nigga look a little

more presentable before she seen him but there was nothing I could do. Johnny was done for. His long locs were matted, up in a bun that was barely hanging on by rubberbands I was sure he'd put in years ago. He smelled bad. So got damn bad that I couldn't put a finger on the stench. The nigga smelled like ass. His teeth were just as yellow as his eyes, caked up with built up plaque that needed to be scraped off years ago.

Seeing him like this, as if it were any different than the time before, was going to fuck her up even more. I didn't have time for that. Any time she left from seeing Johnny, she was down, and at the same time, hopeful. Instead of really accepting what the fuck was going on, she'd cry, looking up ways to get her father admitted into rehab without his consent. She'd come at me with outlandish ass requests and shit. I didn't feel like dealing with Jada's shit. At the same time, I didn't want her to keep hurting behind this nigga neither. She really needed to let the nigga go.

"Ay," I smacked him again. Through gritted teeth, I gripped the top of his shirt, hemming him up. "*Tighten the fuck up*. Your daughter on the porch. Act like yo give a fuck."

He drew back with wide eyes. "I do give a fuck." I released him and he ran his hands down his pants, trying to smooth the wrinkles over. "I give a fuck," he mumbled.

I took a deep breath and watched as he continued to stagger. Looking towards the door, I had half a mind to tell her he wasn't here. How would seeing him like this help at all? I shook my head, gritted my teeth and flicked the tip of my nose, turning around to head out.

He followed. Staggered and walked slower than I liked, but he followed. Before we could get to the door, he tripped over one of the crackhead bitches sprawled out on the floor. I gripped his shirt and snatched him up, telling him to watch where he was going. He didn't say shit. He might've been following behind me, but the nigga was on cloud ninety.

When we made it to the door, I looked over my shoulder at him, nodding off behind me, and shook my head. She wanted to see him—she'd see him. Fuck it. I turned the doorknob, opening the door. As soon as I did, I stepped out and Jada looked past me, looking for him. Noticing him, the corners of her mouth turned up in disappointment.

"Hey daddy," she spoke, eyeing him up and down before she dug into her Chanel. A second later, she pulled her phone out, tapped around it and started to record dawg like she was out of her mind.

“Fuck is you doin?” I asked with dipped brows, frowning at her.

She walked around him, steady recording. Briefly, she glanced up at me. “Getting content. Move if you don’t want to be—

“*Content*? Man what?” I stepped forward and snatched the phone from her hand. “What the fuck is wrong with you?”

She reached for her phone, but I held it up, over my head. I was 6’3. Jada, around 5’2. She couldn’t reach shit.

“Give me my phone, X!” She yelled.

Johnny nodded again, bending over, bumping into her. She sucked her teeth and pushed him. “X! Give me my fucking phone.”

I frowned at her, squinting. “This the type of shit you be on when you come out here?”

“No! I haven’t… mind your business! Give me—”

“Man, I ain’t givin you shit,” I interrupted, glancing over at Johnny who was bent over, nodding, so far that his head damn near touched the porch. I looked at her in disbelief. She was steady trying to reach for the phone.

“Out here on bird brain shit. Fuck is wrong with you?”

“Bird brain shit? Exodus… You don’t know what the fuck you talkin’ about!”

With that, I walked away. You think she stayed on the porch, helping her pops? Hell naw. She ran after me, steady trying to justify recording her father at his lowest. How would this benefit her at all? Oh yeah… the views. Jada wasn’t just into social media—she made money off of it. Is that what that social media shit was about? Recording fucked up shit for views?

“It’s not like that,” she continued, power walking behind me, her short legs having a hard time keeping up. “I—Exodus! Wait! Damn! British found my TikTok a couple months ago. She was in the comments talking about how I didn’t give a fuck about my daddy. Said it was crazy how I was gettin’ so much money while he was a crack head, suckin’ dick and begging for money, living in the hood. She was talking so much shit about me, X. I had to do something. You think I want to put my daddy on social media like this? The people asking to see him! So, I decided to finally give in. They want me to—can you please wait? You just don’t understand because you’re not on social media. You don’t get it.”

I didn’t say anything. I didn’t have an interest in arguing with her over an excuse that didn’t make any sense. Nothing she said could justify that lame ass shit. Nothing. I said Jada was on bird brain bitch shit but see…

she'd always been a bird brain broad. She wasn't the smartest. She was a crack baby. Grew up poor, barely went to school. Because she didn't get love from her parents, she was constantly seeking validation. Which was why she begged me to pay for surgery she didn't need. Which was why she didn't leave the house unless she had on a face full of makeup and her hair done up right.

Jada spent many years as the dirty girl on the block. So now that she was with me, she stayed on her shit. Not because she wanted to feel good about herself or none of that shit but because she'd always wanted to… as my momma used to say… keep up with the Joneses. She was superficial as fuck. Of course she was recording her pops for muthafuckas on the internet. What she did had me questioning everything about her. Were the tears fake? Was this why she didn't want me to bring her goofy ass out here? Why in the fuck hadn't Rocc told me what the fuck she be on when she come out here?

I didn't fuck with Johnny—looked at him and anyone else using as worthless ass souls—but that didn't mean that exploiting shit would ever be cool with me. Jada was tweakin'. She gave too much of a fuck about appearances, bro. Sometimes I found myself questioning why I even put up with her ass for this long. As soon as the thought came to mind, I was reminded of the jail visits, late night calls, and her opening her doors for me when I needed somewhere to run to after a lick. Loyalty. That was why I put up with her. Loyalty and sometimes, pity. Jada would be lost as hell out here without me. I was all she had.

When we made it back around the corner to the whip, I got in, and she got in right after, steady talking the same shit. She was wasting her words. Explaining for nothing because I didn't have shit for her. Not conversation. Not understand. Nothing. The only thing I had for her was her phone, which I tossed into her lap.

She looked down at it, went to the photo gallery and tapped on the short ass video she got of him. Sucking her teeth, she mumbled under her breath about how she promised them a video today.

I sped off, in the direction of home.

"We still going to Steak 52?" She asked.

I glanced over at her, huffed, and turned Sada Baby's Activated up to the max.

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CHAPTER 3

SEREIA



"YOU SURE?" ASKED MY FAVORITE COUSIN, LAKELAND, LOOKING OVER HER shoulder at me with raised brows.

"Yeah, *I'm sure*," I said with a frown, looking her up and down. "Why you say it like that?"

She shrugged, turned around, and went back to adjusting her shirt. "You know why I said it like that. Meech—"

"I need my lace fixed. Walk over to Zariah's with me," I interrupted, pushing up from the chair I was sitting in to walk over to the mirror she was at. Leaning forward, I touched the lace. "Yeah, my shit lifting."

Lakeland looked over at me and shook her head. "After I make RJ something to eat."

From the corner of my eye, I could see her staring at me. I ignored it. She was worried about me and had every right to be. But I didn't want her to. Meech died three days ago, and I hadn't sat down and sat with it since. I didn't want to. Didn't feel like I needed to. He was dead—what more was there to sit with? The day after he died, I was at work. And as soon as I got off, I was outside with my cousins. I hadn't been home. Not for real. I went there to shower and sometimes to sleep. Hadn't sat at the kitchen table to eat since dinner the night he passed away.

Being in that fucking apartment depressed me. Before Meech died he was barely there, yeah. But he always came home at some point. I missed hearing his keys rattling at the door. Shit was weird. And very fucking unsettling. Not to mention, since everybody knew Meech was dead, I had to sleep with a fucking weapon. Last night, I slept with the biggest knife from

the kitchen. I didn't have the protection of my big brother or his gun anymore. For the most part, I'd been good and I felt like I would be. But things had changed and I just didn't know anymore.

After Lakeland fed her son, we left. As soon as we stepped foot outside of the apartment, her baby daddy, Five, looked up from the dice game he was in the middle of. With his nose turned up and a cigarette sitting on his bottom lip, he sized us up. Here we go.

"Where the fuck you about to go?" He asked, the stench of cheap liquor on his breath overpowering the smell of cigarette smoke.

Lakeland sucked her teeth. "Around the corner. Cass is watching RJ so don't even say shit."

Lakeland and Reginald—Five—had been together since we were kids. They were fourteen when Lakeland got pregnant with RJ. Nobody in the hood was shocked when it came out that she was pregnant neither. Not even her mother. Teenaged pregnancy was a common thing in The Woods. Shit, a big chunk of the residents over here were teenaged mommas, living off welfare, low income, and section eight.

Lakeland was of no exception to that. She stayed in a two-bedroom apartment with Five, her momma Danielle, and her twin sisters, Cassidy and Caydence. They were ten and kept RJ more than his damn daddy. Five was the typical ain't shit nigga, but he was worst because he was the broke kind. He got the nickname Five from constantly asking muthafuckas for five dollars to get in on dice games he rarely ever won.

"The fuck is around the corner? I need you to wash my fit for tonight," Five said, before pulling from his cigarette that was damn near down to its filter. He gave fiend, very fucking bad. What the hell was my cousin doing with him?

Lake rolled her eyes. "I did wash them, nigga. I ain't yo damn maid neither. The fuck?"

She said she wasn't his maid but that's exactly what it gave. I hated that Lakeland got involved with him so young. He didn't deserve her. My cousin was beautiful with a bright ass spirit, and a big heart. She deserved beautiful, healthy love that poured into her. Meanwhile, she was constantly being mistreated by a bum ass nigga who barely had two nickels to rub together. If it weren't for my auntie and Lake, he would be homeless. Yep. Cuz paid the majority of the bills with the money she made as a cashier at Food Value grocery store, up the street.

“Yeah, okay! I said what the fuck is around the corner, Lake?” He asked, averting his eyes between me and Lakeland.

I sighed, rolled my eyes and zoned out, ignoring them as they started to argue. While they were going at it, Hood, this cool ass nigga that stayed a couple of doors down from me, chucked his chin at me, speaking.

“What up doe, Rei-Rei? How you holdin’ up?” He asked.

My chest tightened and I stuffed my hands into the back pockets of my light rinsed skinny jeans. I hated that question. Mainly because hearing it always made me think about reality, and losing Meech. On the other end, I hated it because I didn’t know *how* I was holding up. I was just existing. On auto pilot, cruising through this fucked up life.

“I been straight,” I lied.

He twisted his lips up as to say, ‘yeah right’. “You ever need to kick it, you know where to find me, sis,” he offered up, gripping the wheels of his wheelchair to roll closer to the dice game. With his blunt pinched between his lips, he reached down, grabbed the dice and tossed them on top of the pile of money sitting by his wheels.

Hood was cool. Like me, he’d been in The Woods since pampers. Before he was shot and put in that wheelchair, he used to run around The Woods terrorizing shit like most of the niggas over here. The wheels didn’t do anything but slow him down a little. He was in a gang, and got active like the rest of them, still.

“You ready?” Lakeland asked with a frown, her right brow cocked.

“Me? Bitch is you?” I asked, with raised brows of my own.

Five was steady talking shit, but Lakeland paid him dust as we walked away, heading for the crowded stairwell.

After stepping over trash and what felt like twenty kids, we were finally on our way to the other side of the community where Zariah lived in building twelve.

Lakeland talked shit about Five the whole way there. I said nothing. Not because I didn’t have anything to add but because adding my two cents would be pointless. I wasn’t in the business of telling people what they should and shouldn’t do so I just kept my mouth shut.

* * *

HOURS LATER, we were at this girl named Mookie's spot for her brother, Junior's welcome home party. He was just released from prison two days ago and damn near the whole hood was at her shit. The apartments at The Woods were small as hell but that didn't stop people from packing it like a sardine can. People stood outside of the apartment too, blocking the hallway and the stairwell.

I didn't fuck with half of the people here, but I knew them. They knew me too. As Meech's put up little sister. I wasn't Meech's put up little sister tonight though. I was outside. After Zariah fixed my lace, I got dressed in a pair of baggy jeans, a black tank, and a pair of black thong sandals. It was simple, but accessorizing with gold jewelry and a black crossbody bag with gold hardware made it look like I put more effort into my look than I actually did.

"You feelin that shit now ain't you, cuz?" Asked my cousin Alani, nudging me.

Lazily, I blinked and licked my dry lips in what felt like slow motion. Everything moved at a slow pace. Well… not everything. Just me. The music blasting from the speaker sitting on the floor next to me played at its usual pace. As King Von rapped about a stripper bitch, the niggas in the middle of the small room threw their hands up, rapping along with him, spilling liquor onto the stained carpeted floor at a normal pace too. It was just me moving in slow motion and my God it felt amazing.

"Rei Rei," Alani called out, nudging me again.

"Please don't tell me you gave her the whole thing, bitch," My other cousin, Dom, fussed.

Alani sucked her teeth. "You think I'm dumb? I gave her ass half."

"You shouldn't have given her shit. She already hit Hood's blunt," Lakeland said, kneeling in front of me, offering me a sip of her water.

Because my mouth was dry, I took the bottle from her, twisted the cap off, and chugged it.

"Rei—"

"What?" I finally answered. "I'm good."

"Ho, you ain't good. You been sitting here stuck for a minute now," Lake said. "We about to go. You doin' too fuckin' much."

She was right. I was doing too much. When Hood passed me his blunt, I should have declined like I did every time a blunt was passed my way. I took it though. Pulled from it four times like I knew what I was doing. I

hadn’t hit a blunt since Meech forced me to last year on my twenty-first birthday.

I was really tripping when I asked Alani for half of her Perc. I was doing anything. Felt like I needed to. The only reason I came to Junior’s welcome home party was because I needed something to do to keep my mind from staying on Meech. But the minute I walked in, I thought about him and how he would’ve gotten on my ass for even thinking about showing up to some shit like this.

To add insult to injury, damn near everybody I crossed paths with offered condolences. Everybody knew Meech and to know him was to love him. My brother was a real ass nigga who showed love to everybody that showed love to him. While the condolences were nice, I hated them. My chest tightened every time I heard ‘sorry for your loss, my baby’.

So no, when Hood passed me the blunt, I didn’t decline. And yes, when Alani pulled her cute ass pill case out, I asked for one. I didn’t want to feel shit. And I didn’t. Not even my face.

“She ain’t doing too much. We got her,” Alani said, plopping down on the couch, beside me. She smoothed my hair over. “She needed that shit.”

“But you know Rei is a lightweight. Her ass can barely handle a shot of Don, and you give her a fuckin’ pill?”

“Sereia is a grown ass woman. She don’t need you babysitting her, bitch. Damn,” Alani snapped.

I sat there quiet, while they talked about me as if I wasn’t sitting there. Eyes barely opened, watching the nigga across the room. *My* old nigga. Chevelle. He looked nice. Better than he did when I saw him two weeks ago. Through his dark tinted Cartier glasses, I could tell his eyes were on me too. Shit, any time I was in the same room with him, Vellz was fixed on me. It was me who usually paid him dust. Vellz and I hadn’t been together for almost two years. We were on and off since I was fourteen. At twenty, I decided enough was enough and when I broke up with him that time, I was done.

He didn’t cheat.

Didn’t mistreat me.

Didn’t disrespect me.

I was just tired. Tired of him being in and out of jail. Tired of his low ambition. Tired of the block. Tired of the same ol’ shit. Things with Vellz didn’t progress. We were at a standstill because *he* was at a standstill. He

was trapped. Planted in a hood that didn't truly give a fuck about him. Loyal to a game that had never been loyal to him. He was a true product of his environment. The typical ass drug dealing, weed smoking, Don Julio drinking hood nigga with low ambition and only a couple of dollars to show for after years of hustling.

It didn't and wouldn't work because I'd always wanted more. Anytime I would talk about him getting a real job and moving out of Brickhaven, he would tense up. He'd start stroking his thick beard. His eyes would widen, and he'd look off, talking about '*shiiiit*, ain't shit else out here baby. We home.' And that shit use to irk the hell out of me. While most young couples argued about bitches, we argued about ambition.

Vellz wasn't a bum ass nigga. He was just hella low vibrational and me, as a high vibe ass bitch, couldn't take things too serious with him. He always brought me down. I wasn't content with sitting on my ass, getting drunk and high. I wanted more out of life. And while my current situation didn't reflect that, it was true.

With a deep breath, I looked away from him and tossed my head back against the couch I was sitting on. Couldn't believe I was as comfortable as I was. If I weren't high, I would have never sat down. I wasn't a bougie bitch, but Mookie threw hella parties and the very couch I was sitting on had definitely been fucked on my multiple people—probably at the same time.

I was too out of it to give a fuck about that though. I was cruising. Cruising on cloud nine. But when G Herbo's Went Legit came on, I sat up, waving my hands in the air. Meech loved this shit.

I bobbed my head and yelled, "Every day some new shit! Beefin' with my bitch right now but life still lit!"

"See? She good," Alani said, waving her hands in the air too, rapping along with me.

The party went crazy. Everybody started rapping with G Herbo. Seemed like Mookie turned the volume up louder too.

I pushed up from the couch and danced around in place, bobbing from side to side, rapping along with the music with tears rolling down my face, spitting that shit with my whole chest like I wrote it.

While I was in my zone, crying tears I didn't want to cry in an apartment full of people, I felt a pair of hands slide across my waist. I opened my eyes just as Vellz leaned in to whisper in my ear.

“You lit,” he whispered, his thick beard tickling the side of my face.

Lazily, I smiled. “Something like that.”

I surveyed his face, eyes landing on his full bottom lip. After swiping tears from my face, I threw my arms around his neck and leaned in. “You smell good.”

“You look good,” he shot back. “Fuck you doin’ here, Rei?” He swiped his thumb underneath my eye, catching a tear I missed. “Crying and shit.”

Vellz and I were together for years and he’d only seen me cry three times. Once after my momma died, again after my daddy was sentenced to life in prison for killing her, and now… over Meech, at a party full of people I didn’t care for.

I moved away from his touch with a light laugh. “I’m cool. Would be better if we left, though.”

His eyebrows shot up, surprised and as I expected, he bit down on his bottom lip, moving his hands over my waist, caressing me. I swallowed and let him. I didn’t fuck with Vellz like that. Hadn’t fucked him since I broke up with him. When I was done with someone, I was done with them. Him and I might’ve had a little back and forth back in the day, but when I was finished, I was finished. Vellz tried to spin the block a couple of times, but I shut his ass down every time. Eventually, he stopped.

That was months ago and I was relieved. The fact that I was approaching him on some fuck shit, letting him touch on me in a provocative way attested to just how fucked up my head was. Well… My head wasn’t fucked up. I was sad. I was very fucking sad. And I hated to admit it but being in Vellz’s arms felt good. The familiarity of it all felt like… home? Comfortable. Familiar. Safe. Good. I knew that if I left with him, he’d make me feel good. He’d do for me what the pill and the blunt hadn’t *really* done. I would be in ecstasy. Feeling something other than pain and sorrow. That’s what I needed. The numbness? It was nice. Refreshing a little but I wanted to feel good. Hadn’t felt good in days.

“Shit, come on then,” Vellz said, wearing a smirk, pressing his body against me. His dick was on brick.

“Cuz,” said Lakeland. “What you doin?”

I looked over at her and shook my head with a giggle. “About to go.”

She squinted with her mouth turned up in a frown. “You sure about that?”

“Uh huh.”

“I could’ve sworn you was done with this nigga. Don’t be out here makin bad decisions, cousin,” Alani said, frowning.

“Shut yo’ ass up, Lani,” Vellz said after sucking his teeth. “She smooth, cuz, I got her,” he continued, talking to Lakeland.

My eyes met Lakeland’s as I licked my lips, in need of another water. “What? You said I was doing too much. Now I’m about to do a little less.”

Lakeland shook her head, frowning. “A lil’ less? Bitch, the absolute most.” She stepped in between Vellz and I. “You really about to leave with this nigga?” She whispered.

We locked eyes for a second before I shrugged. I was leaving with Vellz. The party was cool. It was a nice little change of scenery. I mean, it did what I needed it to do. Kept me out of the apartment. But my mind… it still wandered off to Meech. Being with Vellz, regardless of our history and me cutting him off, would give me the type of comfort a blunt and a pill couldn’t give me. If I had to sleep at that apartment tonight, I wanted it to be in a pair of familiar arms after a couple of orgasms. Might’ve been a bad decision but in the moment, I didn’t give a fuck.

“Okay cuz,” Lakeland said with a sigh.

I snatched my purse from the couch and slid it over my head, across my chest. Vellz went from gripping my arm to interlocking his fingers with mine, locking our hands. As we maneuvered through the thick crowd, he said a few muffled words to people, gesturing towards me. Through hazy vision, I noticed the looks on their faces. Looks of ‘aww Sereia and Vellz back together’. A couple of niggas eyed me up and down with disappointment, mad they hadn’t gotten their chances yet. Tuh. Vellz had to be painting some type of narrative. Acting like we were back on like we were before, gloating, purposely talking too long, gesturing toward me, probably telling muthafuckas he needed to get me home, playing the role of a caring boyfriend. Fuck out of here.

When we got outside of the apartment, the stench of weed smoke grew stronger. Would’ve been nice to be hit with a calming gust of refreshing, calming nighttime air. The kind that made you close your eyes, smile, and bask in it. But that was something we never got here. The air at The Woods was polluted with either the smell of heavy weed smoke, crack, shit, old exhaust pipes, or that pungent stench of piss.

“I see you nigga,” said one of the niggas sitting at the stairs we had to walk down.

“You already know,” he gloated. I didn’t need to see his face to know he was wearing that cocky smirk I hated. The one he put on anytime I retracted and got back with him after a couple of weeks.

He held my hand the short walk to his old school Monte where he opened the car door for me. Something Vellz had never done. Only reason he opened it tonight had to be because I was buzzing hard as hell and he didn’t want me to fall on my ass. After he got in, we took the short ride to the other side of the complex where I stayed. He talked the whole way there, talking about Meech and how he wanted to reach out but didn’t know how I would take it. He had a guilty conscious. The crazy part about him not calling was that I didn’t expect a call from him. I hadn’t sat up thinking like oh, Vellz fake as hell for not checking up on me after my brother died. I didn’t think of him at all. So, the apologies and the guilty conscious meant nothing to me. Vellz could have saved that shit.

When we pulled up to the building, we got out and headed up. As I stood at the door unlocking it, he went to talking about Meech again. Joking this time, reminiscing about the times I snuck him in when Meech was gone. Years ago, when I was too damn young to be having a boy over. I didn’t laugh. I didn’t respond. I just opened the door. I hadn’t said a damn word to Vellz since the party, but he just kept going and going. I wanted him to shut the fuck up about Demetrius.

After Vellz closed and locked the door behind us, I turned the light on. He turned around and said, “You been cool? How you holding up, Rei? For real?”

Instead of answering him, I threw my arms around his neck, stood on my tiptoes and kissed him. He didn’t really care about how I was holding up. He was being polite, trying to be considerate because that guilty conscious was eating him up.

His kiss was unrushed and hesitant. He was caught off guard, but it didn’t take him long at all to match my energy. His hands found my waist again, as he parted my lips with his tart tongue. I went for the waistband of his designer jeans, undoing his fake Hermes belt. Once it was undone, I unbuttoned and unzipped his pants, immediately pulling them down.

“Damn bae. You hungry for daddy dick. You missed this mafucka, didn’t you?”

I didn’t say anything. Just helped him get my tank over my head.

“Tell me you miss this dick,” he pressed.

I gripped his thick, hard dick and bit down on my bottom lip. “Shut up,” I said before kissing him again.

Vellz backed me up against the wall behind us and deepened the kiss. Aggressively, he went for my pants. I leaned my head back against the wall as he attacked my neck with his lips, steady undoing my pants, his hard dick poking at me.

When he got my bottoms off, he picked me up and instantly slid my pussy down over his dick.

“Ahh,” I cooed, once his dick hit the bottom of my pussy. Vellz was merciless in the way he handled my pussy. He dug deep in my pussy, his short nails digging into my ass cheeks.

“Damn I missed this good ass pussy. Why you keep this pussy from me? Hm?” Vellz grunted into my ear.

I didn’t say anything. Closed my eyes and tried to escape reality instead. Vellz felt good He always felt good. He was my one and only sex partner. He knew my pussy very well. Knew exactly how I liked to be fucked. Knew when I needed it slow and steady. Knew when I needed to be fucked like a slut too. Hair pulling. Biting. Smacking. He just knew. Tonight was no different. He might not have been in between my legs in almost two years, but you’d never be able to tell by the way he handled me. I wanted to be fucked like a slut and that’s exactly what he gave me. Slammed me up and down on his dick, handling me like a rag doll. One with the best pussy he’d ever been in.

* * *

“*Fuck is that*? The police? Rei,” said Vellz, nudging me in the side.

I grunted and pushed him. “Stop.”

He shoved me again, forcing me to open my eyes. I sucked my teeth at the sight of him standing at the bed, leaning over me. “Sereia. Somebody bangin on the fuckin’ door. Get up. Probably five. E said this bitch been flooded with them boys since Meech, askin’ questions and shit. Get up, bro.”

I sighed and propped myself up on my elbow. I scratched at my hair and rolled my eyes, realizing I didn’t put my bonnet on before I laid down last night. As if wearing a bonnet would have mattered. Vellz fucked my shit up.

Things got rough last night, and he got to yanking on my shit. I let him like a dumb ass. Dick was too good to stop him. Zariah had done a really good job on my hair too. Fuck.

"You think it's the police? They gon' try to walk through this bitch ain't they? Fuck! Ay, where can I put this at?" He asked, showing me his gun. "You still got that box under the bed? They probably gon search this bitch. Damn I should have left last night bro."

"Chevelle. Shut the fuck up," I groggily said, sitting on side of the bed.

The knocking on the door started again. And with dipped brows, I looked toward the door, confused. Maybe it was the police. They had been to the apartment a couple of times, asking questions, trying to get clarity about Meech and what he was involved with. I didn't understand the point. What the fuck were they investigating when he was dead? I didn't have shit for them and always hit them with the same line when asked if I had any information about the other two men he was with. Didn't know them. What my brother did when he left the house was his business. I didn't know what he was into. Simple.

"*Shut the fuck up*?" Vellz repeated, with a frown. "You know how many bodies on this bitch?"

I looked up at him, with a frown as to say I didn't give a fuck. Instead of speaking my mind, I pushed up from the bed, lifted one of the floorboards and pointed inside, where a stack of folded papers sat. He glanced from me back at it with raised brows, probably wondering what it was. I placed my hand on my hip. "What? Nigga you want to hide your gun—hide it."

He shook his head, sat the gun inside and started to pace. "Ay, don't tell them I'm in here."

I looked over my shoulder at him, sliding my fluffy robe over my naked body. "If they have a warrant to walk around, what I *tell* them won't matter."

Waking up to Chevelle in my face made me sick to my stomach. What the fuck had I gotten into last night? I was tripping for sure, inviting this nigga over. I couldn't blame it on the weed or the pill. I blamed it on grief.

I yelled, "Who is it?" before standing on my tip toes to check the peephole.

When I did, I stepped back from the door with pinched brows. What the fuck did he want? Exodus. Of course, he didn't answer when I asked who it

was. He just stood there, eyes on the peephole, hands stuffed into the pockets of his hoodie, with that infamous deep furrow in his thick brows.

He was alone. No Leviticus. No Zeke. Just him.

I wondered if he'd heard about the police snooping around too.

Shit.

"Rei," Whispered Vellz from the room. "Is it the boys? Fuck you just standin' there for?"

I looked over at him and sucked my teeth, waving him off. Turning back around, I approached the door and again looked out of the peephole. This time he was just standing there. Until he looked down at his phone and turned to walk off.

I quickly undid the locks and opened the door, tightening the strap to the robe around my waist. "Yeah?"

He looked over his shoulder at me, put his phone into his pocket and turned to walk back over to the door. He eyed me up and down. "This a bad time?"

I looked over at Vellz at my bedroom door, and then back at him. "No. Not really. Wassup?" I chewed on my bottom lip and asked, "You heard about them detectives? I ain't said—"

"What detectives?" He interrupted, thick brows furrowed.

Hesitating, I said, "I think their names are Givens and Shields. They been—never mind. What did you want?"

"Nah," he walked closer to the door. "Back up."

I took a deep breath. Should have just kept my fucking mouth closed. I wasn't even thinking about them fucking detectives until Vellz brought them up. "They been coming around. Asking questions."

"Questions about what?"

I shrugged my right shoulder. "About what happened. They want to know who the other two men are. I just told them I didn't know. What my brother did when he left the house is what he did."

He turned his mouth down and nodded, steady staring at me. "Mmh."

"Yeah…"

He didn't say anything for a couple of seconds before he dug into his pocket, retrieving a white envelope, handing it to me. With pinched brows, I looked down at it.

"What's that?" I asked, hesitating to take it.

He pushed it forward and I took it from him. Tearing into the flap, my eyes grew as big as saucers caught off guard by the fat stack of money. What the hell?

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CHAPTER 4

EXODUS



"*WHAT IS THIS*?" REPEATED SEREIA, GLANCING FROM THE ENVELOPE OF money I handed her, back up at me.

"Funeral expenses," I told her, eyeing her up and down.

She smelled like a distillery. Like she'd been up, drinking all night. Her hair was a mess and she was wrapped in a robe. Took her a minute to answer the door too. Yeah, she got lit last night. Probably too lit.

She squinted. "Umm—

"You can hold the service at the church," I interrupted, pulling my phone from my pocket. "You got your phone? What's your number? I'm going to send you Solo's number. Get with him ASAP."

She was stuck. Quiet. Eyes centered on the stack, running her fingers along it.

"Yo."

She looked up at me. "I—I can't—

"You can. How else you gon' fund it? Hold a fundraiser in the 'jects? Where everybody strugglin'? I'm sure brodie didn't have life insurance. Now ain't the time to be proud." I glanced down at my phone and handed it to her. "Here. Put your number in. I'll have him hit you."

I was at The Woods, handling something that had been weighing heavy on my spirit since late last night. Meech needed a proper burial. So, as soon as I got up, I got dressed and headed straight to the bank to pull a cool ten thousand out for it. Ten was generous, but ten was necessary. I threw in extra to take the stress of other shit off his sisters back. I was sure Meech handled a lot around the crib. Without him, she would be down on her

knuckles. Struggling in the middle of grief would send the sanest muthafucka spiraling. I didn't want that for her.

"I… Um… thank you. I don't… um… I've never made arrangements before so…"

"Solo will help you with whatever you need," I told her as she handed me my phone back, with her contact info on the screen.

"Okay. You know… you… you didn't have to—"

"Don't mention it. He gon' hit you in about an hour or something."

"Okay," she softly said, the moisture in her eyes building.

From inside, I heard someone whisper, calling her name. It was a dude. She sighed, shook her head and thanked me again. I nodded, told her to listen out for the call and walked off. A couple of seconds later, I heard the door close and right after that, her yelling.

As I jogged down the creaky stairs, my phone went off. I fished it from my pocket and frowned at yet another text message from Jada. It'd been two days since she pulled that goofy shit with her pops and she'd been trying to explain her actions since. She was tiptoeing around the crib too, not recording as much as she used to. That shit threw me off so bad, I hadn't looked at her the same way since.

Instead of checking the message, I put the phone back into my pocket and continued towards the whip, head on a swivel. On my way there, I got looks. Heard whispers. Sent a couple of head nods. Exodus Christ in The Woods was a rare sighting.

I didn't fuck with The Woods. It was full of hood rats, and a bunch of broke ass niggas looking for either a lick to hit or a handout. Because niggas knew to tread lightly around me, they were never dumb enough to even think about trying me on that lick shit. They didn't try me at all—on any level. Niggas knew that if they needed a handout their best bet was to hit Solo at the church. Not fuckin around in The Woods was more about the environment than it was about the people. It was dirty. A sad ass sight to take in. There was a baby in a shitty diaper, crackheads smoking or shooting up, fights and rats at damn near every turn. The only time I actually fucked around out here was when I was on some community building shit. Something Solo dragged me into to settle a lifelong debt. Other than that, you would never catch me posted up out this bitch.

"What up Big Dawg" Spoke one of the fiends.

I chucked my chin. "What up, baby? You smooth?"

She scratched at her arm. “Hell naw. Tryin to get a lil somethin’ from Hood but,” she paused and waved me off. “I ain’t got enough and my credit ain’t good wit ‘em.”

In other words, Hood didn’t want head from her disgusting ass. Which shit, I didn’t blame him. She had for sure seen better days. Her light skin was dry and blotchy as hell, covered in dark spots and track marks. Her eyes was jaundiced, lips crusty, and she was skinny as hell. She was a mess. Exactly what you would expect a fiend to look like.

“Straight? Must mean you don’t need shit,” I said, getting ready to get into the car.

She approached me. “You ain’t got ten I can hold?”

“Ten you can *hold* huh?” I snorted. “Hell naw.”

“Come on—

I shot her a look that sent her crackhead ass the other way.

I did a lot of shit but supplying the funds for a mafuckas drug habit was where I drew the line.

When I got into the car, my phone rang. I wasn’t surprised to see that it was Jada. With a deep breath, I dragged my hand down my waves and answered.

“Yo?”

“Now you ignoring me?”

I pressed the start button on the car. “Busy as hell. What up?”

She sucked her teeth. “Too busy to read my messages?”

I didn’t say anything. Sparked fire to the blunt waiting in my ashtray and pulled off.

‘Exodus!”

“Say what you need to say, J,” I said, pulling from the blunt.

“I was just sayin,” she paused, how nervous she was heavy in her tone. “You haven’t let me explain and—

“You’ve explained. Too many damn times.”

“You ain’t hearin’ me tho’, X. I—

“You want me to condone and understand good, bird shit—

“Can you stop callin me a bird?”

“Ain’t that what bird brain bitches do? Post wild shit on social media, seeking attention and validations from mafuckas they don’t know?”

“Now you callin’ me a bitch—”

“Never called you a bitch. Yo… you need something other than understanding and approval?”

“You know what? Forget it. Like I said, you just don’t get it because you don’t be on there.”

I didn’t say anything. The line went quiet. Jada was a fucking glutton for attention and approval. The way I hadn’t been in agreeance with the goofy shit she been on was eating her ass alive. Sometimes I felt like she desired that shit more than she did her next breath. I wasn’t one for validating or pacifying dumb shit so she for sure was barking up the wrong tree if it was for that. Especially regarding recording her pops.

“X,” she mumbled. “I need to go back—

“Aight.”

“Can Rocc—

“Fuck no,” pausing, I pulled from the blunt again. “You wanna go out there and record yo cracked out daddy for views, take yo’ self. I ain’t supportin that shit.”

Again, she went quiet before lowly saying, “Okay.”

With that, I hung up, continuing out of the parking lot.

As I cruised down Shady Lane, on my way back across the bridge, I shook my head. Jada, my Jada. I didn’t know what I was going to do with her ass. I would say I couldn’t believe she fell victim to that weird ass internet shit, but I could believe it. She was one of them, and I hated that for her.

Once I got off the phone with her, I hit Kiss and told him about what shorty said about detectives snooping around The Woods. Yeah, she said some detectives had come through, asking questions. Detectives I was expecting, honestly. I knew there would be some sort of fallout behind the hit. I was just waiting for names.

Givens and Shields.

I told Kiss what was what and he jumped off the phone damn near immediately to put a couple calls in. When I said I’d have to clean Zeke’s mess up, this was what I meant.

* * *

“SHE SAID WHAT?” I asked, phone pressed against my ear. “Hol’ up. I’m about to come in.”

I hung up with my little sister Genesis as I pulled into the massive driveway in front of my ma’s crib. I left The Woods and headed straight for my ma’s. Pulling up on her was a daily occurrence. Usually, my first stop of the day but since Meech’s lil’ sister was on my mind, I went there first. After pulling next to Genesis’s Tesla, I killed the engine and got out. Walking up to the house, I took notice to the flowerbed that needed tending to. I made a mental note to get in touch with the landscaping company ASAP. If it was one thing moms didn’t play about it was her yard. And while she wasn’t in the right headspace to notice it, I still wanted to make sure it stayed straight.

After unlocking the door, I stood in the foyer swapping my twelves out for the Balenciaga slides waiting for me by the door. She didn’t play about shoes in the crib neither. Never had. She’d been that way since I was a lil’ nigga and we stayed in the crib on the westside of Brickhaven, on Courtland Ave.

Once my feet were in the slides, I walked further into the house, passing by what should’ve been ma’s office. Except it held a lot of unpacked shit from the old house that hadn’t been touched.

I followed the sound of The Bernie Mac show into the living room, right off the kitchen where Genny sat.

“Hey bro,” said Genesis before getting up from the stool, phone in hand. “Here. Just listen to it.”

“Hol up,” I told her, before stepping down into the living room where moms sat in her usual spot on the couch, big ball of yarn and crochet needle in hand, eyes on the TV. She might not have been all there conscious wise, but she still loved to knit. It had to be like muscle memory. And Bernie Mac? She loved that black ass nigga and wouldn’t watch anything but him. Walking over to her, I dropped a kiss on the top of her short afro. “Sweet lady, sweet lady What’s goin’ on?” I spoke.

She looked up at me, her eyes shining with love. Her lips curled up into a smile, but she didn’t say anything. Made an ‘mhm’ noise, giggled, and went back to watching the TV. I sat next to her, and glanced over towards the TV, my eyes landing on the mantle. It was full of pictures. Pictures of people I was sure she didn’t even recognize. Well, shit… she always recognized one. Her Isaiah. Anytime she saw a picture of pops, she said his

name, smiled and immediately broke down right after. She didn't react the same to any of us.

She hadn't always been that way though. Back before pops was murdered, Marietta had a larger-than-life personality. When he died, a big chunk of her died with him. That was years ago. You'd think she would have shook back by now. But nah. It'd been a long, tedious, strenuous journey.

"Let me see," I said to Genesis, holding my hand out for her phone.

Genesis gave me the phone, and I pressed play on the voicemail. "Good morning, Ms. Christ. I'm calling about the aide that was scheduled to come out to your home this week. Unfortunately, she had an um… a family emergency. I'm in the process of going through the rest of the staff to see if I can find a good fit. Please give me until the end of the week to secure a new aide. I sincerely apologize for any inconvenience this may cause. I appreciate your patience and understanding…"

I handed Genesis the phone and rested against the back of the couch, tugging on my beard, staring off at the T.V.

"I don't know why you won't just go with a company out here. Them bitches in Brickhaven ain't trying to work for real. They too worried about going over that income threshold for welfare."

"You know why I ain't fuckin with nobody out here," I said, glancing at her. "She'll be straight. They gon' get her together. In the meantime," I paused and shrugged. "Fuck it… call me Nurse X."

"What?" Genesis asked, with raised brows.

I just looked at her.

"Bro," she stressed. "I can do it. I—"

"You *been* doin it. Take yo lil trip and shit. I got it."

She crossed her arms over her chest. "You sure?"

I nodded, pulling my phone from my pocket. "Have I ever made a decision I wasn't sure about?"

Until Guiding Light Nursing Services could find moms a suitable home health aide, I was going to take care of her.

Before Genesis could question me any further, a call from Solomon came through.

"Yo," I answered. "What's the word, dumb ass?"

Genesis shook her head.

"Fuck you want, nigga? You know I was in prayer."

I took the phone from my ear to check the time. “Shit, my bad. Ay, listen. I need you to get up with somebody for me.”

He sighed. “Bro…”

I shook my head, as if he could see me. “Nah. Completely different tip, brodie.” I paused, stretching with a yawn. When I said the Meech shit weighed heavy on my spirit last night, I meant it. I spent a good hour and a half in my secret place, chopping it up with Big G. “Chick at The Woods… she need a place to hold service for her brother. Lil nigga used to run with Zeke. Get up with her. Help her with whatever she needs help with. She ain’t never been in position to handle funeral arrangements so she don’t know shit. Educate her. Show her the way.”

“Say less,” Solo said. “Shoot me her number.”

“Bet. She’s expecting your call.”

Once I texted him her number, I got off with him and left the house to head for mine.

* * *

WHEN I WALKED into the crib, I went straight to the bedroom. Walked in on Jada modeling in front of that fuck ass camera, showing off the ass I paid for. As soon as she noticed me, she flinched and immediately rushed over to the phone to stop recording.

I didn’t say shit—walked right by her to my closet. I was sure her camera caught me walking into the room. I didn’t and wouldn’t address it although the whole social media personality shit was really starting to annoy the fuck out of me.

“Um, hi!” Jada said, standing outside of the closet. “What you doin?”

I glanced over at her before grabbing my Gucci duffle from the top of the closet. “Stay at ma’s for a minute—

“Seriously? All of this because I tried to get content of *my* daddy?” She cut in, sounding disgusted.

“Everything ain’t about you, J.”

She crossed her arms over her chest. “What then? You barely been talking to me. Making me go across the bridge by myself. Now you telling me you about to stay over your momma house. Make it make sense. Cause—

“The agency can’t send anybody out her. Genny been doin enough. She got other shit to do. So, I’m handling it.”

She turned her nose up. “You know you gon’ have to bathe her. You gon’ wash yo momma’s pussy?”

I shot her a look that said shut the fuck up, telling her to chill.

Her arched eyebrows raised. “I—I didn’t mean it… mean it like that, babe. I’m just sayin. Do you know what you’re getting yourself into? If you would have gone with an agency out here like me and Genny said, she would’ve been had an aide.”

“Watch yo fuckin’ mouth,” I said before biting down on my teeth, clenching my jaw. “I’m not fuckin’ with shit out here.”

I tossed a couple of essentials into the duffle bag, white tee’s… joggers and shit… turning my back on her. Genny and Jada thought it would be best for me to go with an agency stationed in Wildermere. I wasn’t with it. Fuck would I do that for when there were perfectly fine agencies in Brickhaven? There was something about moms having a white aide that didn’t sit right with me. Having white doctors and shit at the hospital was one thing. Having them stationed, living in the crib was another. I wasn’t comfortable with it. If it meant dealing with some ghetto shit every now and then, to get what I needed, then so be it.

“So how long are you going to be over there?” Jada asked.

I shrugged. “’Bout a week.”

“A week?” she pouted. “X… what am I going to do?”

“I don’t know. Talk to yo’ lil internet friends.”

“You trying to be funny,” she said.

I didn’t say anything. Grabbed the handle to the duffle, picking it up. Turning, I went to head out of the closet, but Jada blocked my path. With sad eyes, she stared up at me. Bottom lip slightly poked out. Arms crossed over her chest. Looking like the brat that she was. The brat that I created. She hadn’t always been this way. I created this shit. An entitled, superficial, materialistic broad. I missed who she used to be. Back in the day, she had personality. Was silly. Ran around the hood in clothes that came from donations and shit like that. The money changed her. Or did it just bring who she was all along to the surface?

“How long are you going to be mad at me, X?”

With my eyes locked on hers, I said, “I’m not mad. I’m disappointed. But that’s on me.”

“Disappointed?”

“Yeah, disappointed.”

Instead of asking her to move out of my way, I grabbed her waist and moved her out of my way. She was, as expected, on my heels. Talking. Steady trying to justify the unjust.

Jada knew me. And to know me is to know how I operated. She knew that constantly talking to me about the situation wouldn’t go the way she wanted it to. I had patience. A ton of it for Jada because of how she was. That bratty shit. But she was wearing thin on it. I was about ten seconds away from snapping on her ass.

“He don’t even care. He would—

“Shut up,” I interrupted, standing at the dresser tossing underwear and socks into the duffle.

“Huh?”

“Shut up. I don’t want to hear shit else about the goofy shit you be on.”

“Exodus—”

I took a deep breath, cutting her off. With my head hanging, I turned to face her. I didn’t like to talk much. Didn’t like to explain what I saw coming off a mafucka. Bringing shit to the light, telling mafuckas I could see straight through them was something I’d rather not do. But shit… Jada was begging me to cut into her ass. So I did just that.

“You lookin for justification and approval to make you feel better about yourself. Constantly repeating why you did what you did don’t have shit to do with me for real, Jada. You feel like shit about it. You know you on bird shit. My disapproval is just confirmation. You probably go back and forth about your morals all the time. Shit eatin you alive, low key.”

She started to twirl her curly hair around her finger. “So… do you want to break up? Cause you don’t like me as a person, clearly. And…” she paused. “I just don’t know what to say or do.”

That was Jada’s go to. Anytime I disagreed with something or she didn’t like the way I spoke to her, she pulled the whole ‘do you want to break up’ card. She was severely afraid of us ending. Not because she loved the fuck out of me. But because she knew if we ended it was back to Brickhaven and subpar living. Should I feel some type of way about that? Hell naw. What Jada and I had was transactional as fuck. Because I was a nigga who was particular about how I shared my energy, having on demand clean, loyal pussy to call my own was important to me. She cooked, cleaned, and kept

my balls drained. In exchanged, I funded the beautiful, carefree, lavish lifestyle she lived. I didn't ask her to love me—I asked her to be loyal and that she had been.

Love was feeble. I didn't have it to extend to anybody outside of my family, so I didn't expect it. I wouldn't say she didn't love me, but I was smart enough to know she loved what I could do for her more than anything else. I wasn't a knight in shining armor. I wasn't a gentleman. I didn't have the qualities of a nigga who truly deserved love. I was aight with that. I owned who I was. A nigga who needed pussy every now and then and didn't want to sleep around for it. Fuck it.

"Exodus," Jada mumbled, my silence clearly making her uncomfortable.

"You don't have to worry, doll," I paused, zipping the duffle bag. "I'm not sending you back to the Bricks."

She started to say something, but I cut her off, asking if I could trust her to take the dogs out. I had two of them. Queen and King. Dobermann Pinscher's that I'd had for about three years. With a sad expression on her face, she told me yeah.

About thirty minutes later, I was back at my ma's. Genesis was running key information down to me. Showing me which medications needed to be administered and when. Mainly heart medication and something for sleep. Because ma's condition didn't have a diagnosis, there was nothing prescribed for that. Medically, she was fine. Mentally too. Doctors and psychiatrists called it deep emotional turmoil and shock. Essentially, she was suffering for a broken heart. The heart meds helped with the stress.

"You sure you don't want me to stay? I can push my trip back," Genesis said, just as she was about to go over the morning routine.

"Push a birthday trip back?" I asked, arms crossed over my chest. "Go ahead and tell me what I have to do, G."

She sighed. "Well… I get her up around nine. Help her to the bathroom, undress her, and put her straight in the shower. That's if she wasn't feeling it the night before—

"You wash her up? That's why you tiptoeing around shit?"

She made a face at me. "It depends. You know she has good days and she has bad days. On the good, she's more independent. More… lucid. Still quiet, but you know… better. Because I never really know what type of day we'll have, I ask her if she wants me to wash her up. When she reaches for

the rag, I know it's a good day. You know… lately, she's been having more bad days than good. So…"

"I'm not trippin about washin' no ass."

I wasn't. She was my ma. And while other niggas would look at the situation and go hell naw, I didn't. Life and circumstances put her in the position she was in. Shit… put us in this position. Genesis had been the only one looking after moms since she went from bad to worse a couple of years ago. She needed a break. Regardless of if she had a birthday trip or not.

"Okay bro. I'm just trying to make you aware. She'll need her brief changed too."

I ran my hand over the top of my waves. "Just show me everything I need to do."

Mentally, I was fully prepared to take care of her. Changing diapers, bathing her… that kind of shit didn't phase me. Didn't move me at all. She was my OG. The queen. First lady. I would go to the end of the earth for her. I had never bathed an ass that wasn't mine. Had never changed a diaper neither. I was willing to learn though. My focus was doing a good job. Fuck the uncomfortable shit.

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CHAPTER 5

SEREIA



"YOU READY?" ASKED LAKELAND, PEEKING HER HEAD THROUGH MY bedrooms door.

I smoothed my hands down the front of the wide legged pants I had on and looked over my shoulder at her. "Yeah… they here?"

"Yep. Just pulled up."

Today was Meech's funeral. And while I was dressed, I wasn't actually ready. My heart broke a little more every time I thought about what I was getting ready to do. See my brother for the last time. Put him in the fucking dirt. What? What was life? I… wow. I was in utter disbelief. So much that every couple of minutes or so, the realization of reality hit me right in the middle of my chest. Disassociating and evading had been my go-to since he was murdered. However, there was no running from it today. I had to face reality head on. And my God was that an uncomfortable feeling.

After finger-combing the big barrel curls Zariah did last night, I took a deep breath and turned to leave the bedroom. The weight of my ballerina slides felt heavy on my feet with every step I took. My anxiety was rising. But the sound of my family in the living room drowned out the sound of my racing, heavy beating heart.

"Ready niece?" asked Auntie Danielle.

"Hold up," said another one of my aunties, Charlene. "Who doin' the livestream for D?"

The apartment went silent. D—otherwise known as Demetrius Sr.—was my daddy. And Charlene was his older sister. Every set of eyes in the room landed on her.

I tilted my head to the side a bit and said, “Nobody. The fuck. I said I wasn’t doing no livestream for him. So… I don’t know why he wasted them peoples time with that request.”

For the most part, I respected my elders. But Charlene was really starting to get on my nerves. As soon as I called her about the funeral, she got to talking about ways our daddy could be a part of it. Because he was constantly in trouble, at a level five prison, him getting out to attend it was next to impossible, so she got to talkin about livestream options. I let her know off rip that I didn’t want my daddy to be a part of it. Why would I? I hadn’t talked to or seen him since he killed my mama. Yes. He killed my mother. Murdered her for no reason. The fuck did she think he deserved to be at the funeral for? Virtually… in person… he had no right to be there. Meech would have felt the same way. Fuck him. It was because of him that Meech was dead in the first place. If he wouldn’t have killed my momma, he wouldn’t be in jail, and Meech wouldn’t have felt obligated to hit licks. I could be wrong but that’s the way I saw it. It was a domino effect.

“Sereia—”

“Uh, uh. She said no. She said no. Leave it alone, Charlene,” Auntie Danielle said, speaking up.

Auntie Danielle was quick to say something because she’d been itching for a reason to lay hands on somebody from my daddy’s side of the family. Not because they did something to her… not personally anyway. She just wanted to do damage to one of them because of what Demetrius Sr. did to her sister.

But see, Auntie Danielle didn’t need to say anything. Charlene only had one more time to say something else to me about that nigga and her ass wouldn’t be allowed at the funeral neither. But she didn’t utter another word about it. Good.

The walk downstairs to the family car doubled as awkward and heartbreaking. It was as if everybody in The Woods was out. Eyes were on me. A couple of people offered condolences for what felt like the millionth time. Others just watched, whispering about how Meech’s funeral was today. I passed Hood and a couple of other niggas dressed in all black. They yelled for me to hold my head up and said they would see me in a little bit. All I did was nod at everyone.

Just as I was getting ready to get into the car, I heard Desiree yell for us to wait. I looked over my shoulder in her direction and took a deep breath at

the sight of her and the kids running towards the cars. There were two. Exodus gave me ten thousand dollars to help towards the funeral. I paid for the casket, Meech's burial clothes, the obituaries, and the work the funeral home did. The service was being held at Greater Faith Baptist, Solomon, Exodus's brothers church. So, because I had more than enough, I got two family cars instead of one. Mainly because I knew Desiree would need a ride. She didn't have a damn car. I wasn't judging—I didn't have a car neither. But she had three kids so…

"What the hell is this bitch wearing?" Mumbled Lake.

"She doin' the absolute fuckin' most," Commented Alani.

"Fuck she think this is?" My other cousin, Kiera said.

She was doing the most. Desiree was dressed in a black mid-length dress and a pair of platformed heeled sandals. That was fine. But the bitch had on a black veil, too. Not only was that an issue, but she had the kids dressed down in a pair of terry cloth shorts and black RIP Daddy shirts that had my brothers face on them. I was immediately irritated. More irritated by the t-shirts than I was by the veil. I specifically told everybody I didn't want my brother on a fucking shirt. It didn't sit well with me. There was something about the energy attached to that that made me uncomfortable. I didn't give a fuck about homage. There were other ways to show respect. I really just did not want to see my brother on a shirt. You know how many faces are on shirts out this bitch? I did not want my brother to be one of them.

When they got to the car, I started to mention it, but I was too emotionally exhausted to. Instead, I stared at them, Not them per se—those shirts. At my brothers smiling face. A rare sighting. Demetria and D3 were the only souls on earth who could get a genuine smile out of him. Meech was a lot of things, but a deadbeat father wasn't one of them.

About twenty minutes later, we were pulling into the parking lot at the church. It was crowded. Very crowded. Auntie Danielle made a comment about it, but I didn't say anything although I wondered why they were here so early too. The service didn't start for another thirty minutes. Now was family hour. In addition to the plethora of cars in the lot, there were two cop cars. Of course it was. I hadn't been to a funeral since my mama died, but something told me that the majority of funerals held in Brickhaven had police presence. Especially if the person died by murder.

When we pulled up in front of the doors, I looked over at the building with a deep breath and tears behind my eyes. My fucking brother. He was in there. At the front of the church, on display. No blood in his veins. No life in his body. Just… dead. I swallowed, crossed my arms and ran my hands over my goosebump covered skin.

"You ready, boo?" Lake asked.

I wished she would stop asking if I was ready for shit. No, no I was not ready. I didn't want to see him like that again. You know… dead. The last time I saw him was in the hospitals morgue, when I had to identify him. That shit tore me up. The air in the room was cold and still, with the stench of death heavy in it. Standing at the table, looking down at my brother… shit tore me up. I cried the whole Uber ride back to The Woods. It was so hard for me that I didn't even go to the wake yesterday. I couldn't skip out on this one though.

I grabbed the black onyx crystal dangling from my neck and stroked it to calm my nerves. I didn't need protection here. I only wore it because it was the crystal Meech had on him when he died. I didn't think I'd wear anything but it going forward.

"Come on, boo," said Alani, grabbing my hand.

I swallowed and looked at her, then to my other three cousins. The car we were in was a limo, so it fit me, my cousins, and both of my aunties. Desiree and the kids rode in the Lincoln behind us. In that moment, I was happy to have gone for the limo. At first, I was going to get two Lincoln's, but in the middle of selecting, Lake told me to get something for all of us. Sometimes I felt very alone but then I'd look around and see them.

I took a deep breath and followed the family out of the car. Once my feet hit the pavement, a cool breeze swept across my face, forcing me to place a piece of hair behind my ear. I looked up to the sky. It was clear. Clear and sunny. Above me flew a family of birds. I didn't know how long I was standing there, looking at the sky before Lake and Alani interlocked their arms with mine and started towards the church. There were people around me. Outside of the church. As we made our way through the crowds, like the people back home, they sent head nods, spoke, offered condolences and stuff. Again, I said nothing.

I could barely hear them anyway. Their voices sounded muffled. My mind was lightyears away from what was in front of me. My thoughts were on what I was getting ready to take in. The lump in my throat grew bigger

the closer we got to the church doors. My face was drenched with tears by the time we got there.

Auntie Charlene reached forward and opened the door. Upon opening it, we were greeted by two men who handed us funeral programs. The sound of the church organ greeted us too. Once we made it pass the entry point of the church, we took a turn and headed up a grand, carpeted staircase. Each step I took felt harder than the last one. So much so that when we got to the double doors at the top of the stairs, I paused. Hanging my head, I let out a deep sigh, watching the floor as tears fell onto it.

“Take your time, baby,” said Auntie Danielle, rubbing me on the back.

I glanced up at the doors, tempted to stand on my tiptoes to get a glimpse of what was inside through the small window. I wasn’t prepared for this. I wasn’t prepared at all.

Again, I stroked the crystal. This time, closing my eyes, asking God to give me strength. In addition to my family being by my side, I needed Him, my angels, and the ancestors too. I needed the whole damn squad. I asked Him to guide my feet, to ease my aching, racing heart, and to settle my spirit. I let out a deep breath and said a silent Amen.

Domonique opened the door and I gasped at the sight of the black casket sitting in the front of the church in the middle of two massive floral arrangements. At the head of the church stood two men too. Because I didn’t go to church, I wasn’t sure who they were. Maybe ushers?

“You don’t have to go up to the casket if you don’t want to, cuz,” whispered Alani, gripping my arm tighter, noticing how hesitant I was.

“I have to,” I mumbled.

I did have to. I had to see my brother one last time. I had to see him for the first time ever, in a suit. I huffed, smiling to myself a little. If it were up to him, he’d wear street clothes and a fucking shiesty to his funeral. My brother didn’t even wear a suit to mama’s funeral. He was in all black, with his locs in his face instead of the shiesty. Only because they weren’t a thing back then.

With a deep breath, I continued towards the casket. From where I was, I could only make out his side profile and from what I could see, they did good with him. Put me in the mind-frame of seeing him on the couch, knocked out.

“Take your time, baby. Take your time,” whispered Auntie Danielle again.

Like before, my hand went to my crystal. The church organs grew louder. Screamed at me. Practically begging me to break down. Which I did. As soon as I made it to the casket and looked down at what I could easily call my heart in human form, I broke. My brother. My one and only. It was just the two of us… now look. I never told him but losing him was one of my biggest fears. I put on a tough, positive face every time he left the house because that's what I felt like he needed. But shit… that didn't matter. I lost my nigga anyway.

"Hold her up," said Auntie Charlene to Lake and Alani when my legs grew weak and started to wobble.

"We are," yelled Alani. She sniffled, tears falling from her eyes too. "This is hard for us too, shit. My fuckin cousin bro…"

My face was drenched with tears. The little bit of makeup I put on this morning was pointless. I didn't know why I'd gone through the trouble anyway. Somehow I convinced myself that if I looked good, I would feel good.

I don't know how long I stood there before I finally sat down. On the first pew, a couple of feet away from his casket. I stared at him. Wishing he'd get up. Wishing it all was a dream. I didn't know what I was going to do without my brother. He was more than my heart in human form. He was my confidant. Someone I always turned to. The realest nigga I'd ever known. Sitting in reality, looking at him just… lay there, motionless… lifeless… it really fucked me up.

After about twenty minutes, people started to pile into the church. I was in a daze. Quiet. So many people walked up to me, offering condolences, giving hugs I didn't return. My attention was fixed on my big brother. When people walked up to the casket to view him, or up to me, I got antsy and tried to look around them. I just… I didn't want to take my eyes off of him. Felt like it was because I knew that after today I'd never see him again.

"Oh my fuckin' God," mumbled Alani, sitting next to me, looking over her shoulder, getting Lake's attention.

She instantly jumped up. I didn't react. I kept my eyes on my brother. That was until he blocked my view and glanced over at me. My mother's killer. Demetrius Sr.

An unhealthy amount of anger hit me, as I watched him lean over Meech's casket, looking down at him. Behind him stood two police officers,

close but far enough to give him respect. He was bigger than I remembered. In height and in build. Cockier, like he hadn't missed a day of lifting. His locs were a lot longer than it was when he went in. Unkept, pulled back in a thick ponytail. Changes that happened due to the years passing.

I felt a hand glide across my back. Could have been either one of my cousins. Might've been one of my aunties. Probably Charlene. I didn't know. I was frozen. Too frozen to look over my shoulder. Too frozen to move. The only thing I did do was cry. The tears, they fell on they own, my bodies response to not only grief but shock and that seething anger too.

What the fuck was he doing here? I thought… Auntie Danielle was talking about a virtual viewing. What the fuck was this? Why did they let him come? How did he even know where the funeral was? She ran her fucking mouth. He… he didn't deserve to be here. I was crushed. Meech hated our daddy. More than I did. He wouldn't want him here. I looked away from Demetrius Sr. And looked up. I'm so sorry brother. I'm so sorry.

Sucking in a gust of air, my shoulders shook as I started to break down. The hand on my back went to my shoulders, where they massaged me. I jerked away from their touch and jumped up from the pew. Before I could walk over to him, the police officers blocked my path.

"Get the fuck out of here!" I yelled at the top of my lungs, my body shaking with each word. "Get him the fuck out of heeeere!"

Before I knew it, I was surrounded by people. Demetrius Sr. wore a sad expression. His thick, dark, brows furrowed, his bottom lip quivering.

"Sere—

"Get out!" I yelled cutting him off. "Get him out of here!"

All of my cousins, plus the ushers had to hold me back. I tried to get at him. Wanted to pound his face with both my fists, I hated him so got damn much! Why was he here!? He didn't belong here! I wanted him gone!

And after a couple of seconds, the police removed him. They escorted him out and I stood there, in the middle of the walkway, watching until he was out of the door.

* * *

AFTER THE FUNERAL AND BURIAL, it was back to The Woods for the repast I didn't want to have. Because it was a really nice day, in the high seventies,

we were in the courtyard. My family had three barbecue grills going and had rented tables and chairs. There were blunts in heavy rotation, a table full of liquor, and my cousin Sharlita had a big storage tote filled damn near to the rim with jungle juice—a concoction of fruit, different liquors, and hella juice.

My uncle, Andre, had music playing from a big speaker sitting on the ground, blasting Blade Icewood's, Boy Would You. While they did the Boss Up dance, I sat off on the side, arms crossed over my chest, hair pulled back into a ponytail, funeral clothes off, face free of makeup.

When we made it back this way, I went up to the apartment and changed into a pair of black leggings, a black tank, and a pair of pink crocs. Because my makeup was ruined, I washed my face, deciding not to do anything else to it. I was numb, really. Coasting through the day on auto pilot. My cousins were right by my side, trying to keep me uplifted by making jokes about some of the people who were at the funeral. They kept talking about Desiree and Meech's bitch, Tata, too. They talked about everything but Demetrius Sr. showing up. While I appreciated what they were trying to do, it didn't help.

I kept thinking about the man who killed my mother. Couldn't get the smell of whatever he used as cologne out of my nose. Couldn't escape the images of his face, as he stared down at me with eyes that used to comfort me when I was growing up. He wasn't always a bad man. My daddy was top tier. Back when I referred to him as daddy. Something happened. Something horrible happened. I didn't know what. *We* didn't know what. He just… he snapped. Some people in The Woods said he was laced. There were rumors about it. Said he got ahold of some bad weed that sent him into psychosis. I didn't know what it was. All I knew was that one day, I woke up to screaming that sent me into the living room where my mother was dead, lying in a pool of her own blood. My daddy… well… Demetrius… he stood over her, bloody knife in hand. He glanced from me to my momma's motionless body, and dropped down to his knees by her side, cradling her head.

I was frozen.

Paralyzed by both fear and shock. I don't know what happened after that. Don't know who called the police. Couldn't remember when Meech made it home. I just knew that the next time I came to… consciously… we were in a police station waiting for my Auntie Danielle to pick us up.

Seeing him brought all of those old feelings to surface. That, on top of dealing with seeing Meech for the last time was heavy. So heavy that as soon as I made it to the courtyard, I grabbed a cup and scooped a big ass cup of jungle juice up.

I'd been sipping on it since I sat down. People left me alone. They stopped offering condolences. And I was happy about it. Was honestly tired of hearing that shit, high key. Lakeland was busy chasing RJ around. Alani had drove off with one of the niggas from around the way. Dom was on one of the grills, helping with the food. Kiera helped too. Everybody had something going on and I was so grateful because despite appreciating their help, I didn't want to be crowded. If it weren't for the lonely, unsettling feeling being in the apartment gave me, I would have been up there. But… I couldn't handle it. So I sat, quietly sipping from my cup, bobbing my head to one of Meech's favorite songs.

"What up doe, sis?" Said Hood, rolling up beside me.

I took a sip of my drink. "Hey."

"What you sippin on?" He asked, cocking his brow. "Hopefully not that shit Rita mixed up. Yo ass gon' be threw!"

Lightly, I giggled. Forcing it. "Good."

He parked his chair next to me. "You tryna smoke?"

"Nah. This gone get me right."

"Naw, *that's* gone get you fucked up," he said with a laugh. Reaching into his pocket, retrieving his weed, he started to roll up.

I didn't say anything.

I stared off into the distance, eyes landing on Vellz's black ass. He was across the field, talking to a broad named Kenya. By the way she was moving her hands, I could tell she was cursing him out. I wondered if it was about me. I wondered if he was fucking Kenya, or if she was his girlfriend. Hopefully she wasn't his girl because he had his entire tongue in my ass not even a week ago.

I shook my head and looked away, my eyes falling on the black Wagoneer pulling up in the parking lot. A couple of seconds later, Zeke got out the back, and then Kiss and Exodus got out right after. Were they at the funeral? I couldn't remember. They had on all black like they were though. Zeke even had on a buttoned-up top. They had to be there.

I watched as they made their way across the field, heading for the courtyard. Exodus and Kiss looked so out of place. They kept their heads on

a swivel, watching every which way, while Zeke maneuvered around, with ease, slapping hands with niggas, speaking to bitches. The Woods was like a second home to him. To his brothers? Foreign land. I hadn't seen them in The Woods this much in forever. They usually only came around when the church did donation work or held little back-to-school gatherings.

A couple of minutes later, they were under the canopy. Individually, they spoke to Hood before addressing me. Zeke was first to speak. He leaned in for a hug that I didn't return. Despite him not being responsible for Meech's death for real, I still had ill feelings toward him, holding him somewhat accountable. I felt like he felt it too.

"You need anything?" He asked.

I shook my head.

I did need something. I needed my fucking brother.

Exodus chucked his chin, speaking, glanced at my cup and then back at me again. I threw my hand up to wave. Kiss offered his condolences. And then they just stood there. Next to me, hands stuffed into their pockets, looking around, bobbing their heads to the music. Every now and then I would catch Exodus looking at me. Well, not me per se… my cup. I frowned and took another sip.

"Them detectives still been comin' around?" He asked.

I shook my head. "Nope."

He nodded. "Good."

Is that why they were crowding me? Because they thought I'd been talking to them fucking detectives? Instantly, I was annoyed.

"Is that why y'all here?"

Unlike the majority of the people in The Woods, I wasn't threatened by them. I mean, they were a little intimidating, but I didn't bitch up when they came around. I wasn't one of those. I spoke my mind, regardless of what kind of trouble it might end up getting me into. I stepped around this bitch like I was invincible, knowing that wherever I went I had a team of thorough ass ancestors and angels walking with me. It was them who kept me positive when Meech would leave the house. Yeah, I'd be a little nervous because he'd be going out to do reckless shit, but still… I found comfort, knowing he had them with him. Didn't matter though, apparently. Maybe I needed to pipe the fuck down then, huh?

Zeke frowned. "Man what? Hell naw. Support, my baby."

“That problem been handled,” said Kiss, adjusting his white Cartier buffs.

I shifted around in my seat and took another sip of my drink. Zeke asked what I was drinking. I pointed over at the tub and Exodus snorted, shaking his head.

“That bullshit,” he scoffed.

I shrugged my right shoulder. “*Good* bullshit.”

“Ain’t shit good about no jungle juice. Tub full of cheap ass liquor,” he retorted.

“Gon have yo ass tore down, sis,” Zeke said.

“I tried to tell her,” said Hood before passing Zeke the blunt he finished rolling, although Zeke was already smoking on his own. Like a weed head, Zeke took it, pulled from his own, and passed it to Kiss before pulling from Hood’s.

I didn’t say anything to either of them. Exodus again, eyed my cup and looked off. I knew what the jungle juice was and what it would do. I was okay with that. I wanted to forget today. I wanted to forget the pain.

A couple of minutes later, I noticed Kenya and Vellz marching over to the courtyard. He grabbed at her, and she snatched away, steady marching in my direction. I sighed, took a sip of my drink and sat it on the table next to me. As if her spidey senses went off, Lakeland walked over, her eyes on them too.

“Fuck they got going on?” She asked, arched eyebrow hiked.

“I don’t know. But I got a feeling that bitch about to try some shit with me and,” I paused and took a deep breath. “I’m with whatever.”

I was quiet for the most part. Stayed to myself unless I was with my cousins. I didn’t get into a lot of fights. Mainly because I stayed out of the way, partially because bitches knew I threw them, threw them. When Meech and I would get into it, he didn’t play with me. He manhandled my ass, for real. Probably not manhandle… but he for sure handled me. He never left marks on me or fought me like he would a nigga on the streets, but he didn’t play with me. Fighting him taught me how to fight. I wasn’t with the hair pulling and wild arm flailing shit. I threw them bitches. Last fight I had was five years ago with some girl named Charity. Lake had to pull me off her. And by the looks of things, she probably would have to do the same today. The type of time I was on, Lake probably wouldn’t be able to stop me, low key.

“Shut the fuck up, Chevelle!” yelled Kenya, now in earshot.

“Man—”

“Anyway!” She yelled, stepping onto the concrete area of the courtyard. As expected, she walked up to me. “So… you been fucking with Vellz?”

Instead of responding to her, I stood up and instantly hit her in the face. If she was asking me if I’d been with the nigga she knew. There was no need for questions… arguing or none of that. Somebody told her something. One of the niggas or bitches at the party. I wasn’t surprised. Rumors and gossip spread around The Woods like wildfire. Crazy thing about that was, I had no idea he was fucking with Kenya. Had I known he had a little situation, I would have never messed with him. I wasn’t one of those neither. Didn’t play side chick games whatsoever.

“Aw shit!” Yelled Hood. From the corner of my eyes, I saw him grip the wheels on his chair and quickly maneuver around.

“Kenya and Sereia fighting!” yelled somebody in the distance.

The music came to a halt, and we got to tussling. She tried to reach for my hair, but I yanked away, dodging her flailing arms, backing up. I jabbed and caught her in the face again. When it connected, I heard ‘ohhh’s’ in the crowd. She stumbled a bit and before she could catch her footing, I was on her ass. Hitting her with everything I had in me, dodging the wild punches she was throwing whenever she threw them. I caught her real good against the side of her head, forcing her to fall on the pavement. I couldn’t tell you what was going on around me because all I saw was red.

This bitch couldn’t wait? She decided to come up to me on bullshit on the day of my brothers funeral? I mean… did she want me to beat the fuck out of her? Had to. Because anybody in their right mind would know not to fuck with anybody after they buried a loved one. Especially not when it concerned a piece of dick!

I was on her. On top of her, feeding her fists, going to work on her dumb ass. Somebody grabbed me. I yanked away, grabbed a handful of her Fulani braids and went to bang her head on the pavement. I got her good once before I was lifted off the ground, with a pair of strong arms wrapped around me. Kicking and squirming, I tried to get out of their grip, but it was to no avail. Looking over my shoulder, I grunted at the sight of Exodus’s big ass, deciding to stop. He was a big nigga. Over six feet, more than two hundred and thirty pounds, all muscle. There was no getting away from his ass.

He carried me away from the crowd, across the grass, all the way over to building one. When he put me down, I looked up at him with a frown, like he'd lost his mind.

"Ssss," I hissed, shaking my hand, at the feeling of stinging.

Sucking my teeth, I looked at my scraped-up knuckles. Shit. Her teeth must've rubbed up against them.

"You need to chill," Exodus said as I started to pace.

I was out of breath. My ribs hurt from him carrying me. And my knuckles. My fuckin' knuckles. They stung like a bitch. Again, I shook it off, continuing to pace. Glancing over at him, I huffed. "What you mean *I need to chill*? Did you not see her walk up to me? Was I supposed to just sit there and let her get off on me? Yeah okay."

I was pissed. Not because she approached me but because he stopped me. Kenya deserved more. She deserved worst. What type of… Who the fuck approaches someone after their brothers funeral? She… bro.

With a heaving chest, I looked up at the blue sky, tears wetting my eyes. Today was a horrible day. Today was… it was more than horrible. I couldn't find the right word but… whatever was worse than horrible, that's what today was. She was lucky I didn't kill her.

"Let me see," Exodus said, grabbing my hand, stopping me from pacing. "Her shit ate through for sure."

There was blood. How hard had I hit her?

"You got Band-Aids and shit?" he asked, locking eyes with me.

I sucked my teeth. "No." I snatched away and wrapped my shirt around my hand. Walking away, I headed for my building.

My emotions were all over the place. If Meech was here and he knew I was out fighting in the courtyard over Vellz's ass he would go off on me. But see… what happened… it wasn't about Vellz. It was about respect. Any other day, I would have walked away. Would have just left Kenya's dumb ass standing there. But today was a day and what she did was super disrespectful.

I snatched the door to my building open and started up the stairs, ignoring crackhead Esha when she asked me if I had any change. When I heard her ask someone else for money, I stopped and looked over my shoulder. Exodus. He'd followed me. Instantly, I frowned because… what the hell did he want? Before Meech passed away, I only saw Exodus Christ

a handful of times a year. He pitied me. That's what this was about. He thought I was some hopeless little girl who needed support.

We locked eyes.

His glossed over with something I had never seen in them before.

It wasn't that pity I thought about earlier. It was something else. Something that would be hard to believe if I told someone else. Compassion. Softness. Because I could've just been reading into shit, I looked away. Exodus Christ? With softness in his cold dark eyes? Never. I continued up the stairs and he followed me.

"You following me," I pointed out.

"Trying to chop it up with you," he said.

"I don't want to talk."

"You don't need to. Actually, I would prefer if you listened."

I glanced over my shoulder at him and continued up the stairs. By the second flight, I was out of breath. I couldn't remember the last time the elevator worked. Considering I'd been climbing these dusty ass stairs for years, I should've been used to it. But I wasn't. It was a struggle every time. Especially when I had groceries to carry up.

I stopped. Took a deep breath and put my hand on my hip, hissing at the stinging from my knuckles. Again, I shook my hand and looked up at the peeling paint on the ceiling, catching my breath. A second later, I felt his presence behind me. Not too close. Not far away. But close enough for me to smell whatever cologne he wore. Would have noticed it earlier when he picked me up if I weren't so pissed off. He smelled good. It was smoky. But sweet too. He smelled exactly how I thought Exodus would smell.

Like a man.

Like a man with money.

"What do you want?" I asked, starting my trek up the last set of stairs. My apartment was on the third floor.

"I just told you."

"Say what you need to say."

He didn't say anything. Went quiet and continued to follow me down to my apartment. It was weird. Having him follow me. I didn't know him like that. Like I said, we hadn't exchanged words. Not before Meech. So having him on my heels, giving me money, wanting to talk to me… it was a little odd.

I stood at the door, unlocked it and glanced over at him. “You can’t come in.”

“Why not?”

“Because… I don’t know you,” I said with a frown, as if he hadn’t stepped into the apartment that night Meech died.

Lightly, he chuckled, looked away and then back down at me.

“So, say what you need to say,” I said, standing with my back against the closed, unlocked door.

He couldn’t come in because the apartment was a mess. I hadn’t cleaned since before Meech. There were food trays all over the coffee table, clothes scattered around. Trash piling up. Dishes in the sink. The roaches were having a field day, honey. I hadn’t put down any boric acid or anything. *I* was a mess, for real.

He ran his tongue over his thick bottom lip, his expression softening more. Stepping forward, he held his hands out. With dipped brows, I looked down at them. He wanted to hold hands with me? Why? The way he held his hands out reminded me of the last time I held mine out for Meech. I swallowed and my shoulders raised a bit, tensed. Pulling my bottom lip into my mouth, I chewed on it before lifting my injured hand. Blood sat in the creases of my fingers.

“Remember?”

He dropped his hands, nodded toward the door. “Oh yeah. Go handle that.”

I turned away, opened the door just enough for me to walk in, careful not to show too much of the apartment. With a deep breath, I hurried to the bathroom to clean my knuckles up. Snatching the junk drawer open, I rummaged through it, looking for band-aids and the little thing of Carmax since I didn’t have any wound ointment. After finding what I needed, I turned the faucet on and ran my knuckles under the warm water, hissing a bit. Delicately, I dabbed at them with tissue, put a nice amount of Carmax on top of them, and slid the Band-Aid on, covering the scrapes.

When I made it back to the door, he was pacing, with his phone pressed against his ear. He looked over at me, put his finger up, and kept talking. I crossed my arms over my chest and leaned against the doorframe. Down the hall, I noticed Dom and Lakeland heading our way. Lakeland tilted her head to the side, looked over at Exodus and then back at me.

I shrugged my left shoulder.

They made it to the apartment and gave Exodus the side eye, eyebrows dipped the same way mine were.

“You good?” asked Dominique.

I nodded and showed her my hand. “I’m good.”

“What’s going—”

“I’ll be in in a minute,” I said, cutting Lake off, widening my eyes at her, stepping aside so they could go in the apartment.

Lakeland walked by first. Looked over at Exodus and then at me again. They were going to have all types of questions. The same way they did when I told them he gave me money for the funeral. I didn’t tell them how much, but they knew he gave me a lot of money. Vellz’s bitch ass knew too.

When I went back into the bedroom that day, with the envelope and told him it was Exodus at the door he got to talking so much shit. Swore up and down I was fucking him too. Said niggas didn’t give bitches they weren’t fucking money. He kept asking how much it was. Kept making sly comments, saying Exodus was the reason I hadn’t fucked with him. I let him talk, eventually putting him out.

Once Lake and Dom were in the apartment, I closed the door and looked over at Exodus with a sigh. We made eye contact and shortly after, he ended his call, stuffing his phone into the pocket of his dark jeans.

“My bad,” he apologized, holding his hands out again.

I hesitated but I gave him my hands eventually. He lifted the injured one, examining the work I put in on bandaging it up. After a couple of seconds, he lowered it, locked eyes with me and asked, “Can I pray for you?”

“W—what?”

“Prayer. Can I pray for you?”

I drew back with a frown. Not one that said I was disgusted or judging him. I was genuinely surprised. Yes, the Christ family were religious. Growing up, they owned what would be considered a mega church. I mean, it wasn’t the biggest but it was mega in reputation, community, and congregation. They did a lot for the city of Brickhaven, taking care of many families, spreading love and the gospel regularly. But that kind of died with Pastor Isaiah. After he died, things took a turn.

The church was boarded up and the boys… they changed. Before they were always outside but mainly in suits, passing out flyers and stuff like that. They did get into fights often, but they weren’t the way they were

today. After Pastor Isaiah passed, they got off in the streets heavy. It was through them that Meech even got into hitting licks. They used to stay out in Wildermere like crazy, hitting mansions, bringing stupid bags home. But… that calmed down a while ago and I think they got into drugs. Whatever the case… thee Exodus Christ asking me if he could pray for me was very, very unexpected. Regardless of his background.

"Y-yeah. I guess. If you want to."

He shifted his weight and took a deep breath. I watched as he closed his eyes, tightening his grip on my hands a little. Not too much on the injured one, though.

He cleared his throat and I closed my eyes.

"Big G. You know who it is. Today I'm out here with…" he paused and I said my name. "Yeah, *Sereia*. You know I ain't never been too good with names. Sereia… she suffered a major loss. Her brother. Her provider. The person who took care of her. Right now, her spirit is heavy. Her heart… the same. You know they go hand in hand, for real. I come to you, humble, asking you to lighten the weight of her pain. Give her comfort in ways that only you can. Soften her emotions. Fill her spirit with love, light, patience, acceptance and grace. Strengthen her, Lord. When she feels weary, guide her toward you rather than further away from you. Help her understand that this is just a part of her journey—not the journey itself. It's cloudy as fuck right now, but eventually… shit will ease up and she'll smile again. Genuinely. From the soul."

When he cursed, I cracked my eye open a little and looked over at him with furrowed brows. Who the hell cursed during prayer? He didn't miss a beat though. Kept going like cursing during prayer was second nature to him. Like it was nothing. Got damn heathen.

He ended the prayer shortly after, asking God once again to guide me closer to him, rather than a part. I was shocked. So shocked that when he said Amen, I didn't say anything for about a second and a half.

"A—amen."

He released my hand and his eyes met mine.

They weren't as soft as they were before. They were a little piercing.

"That drinkin' shit… don't get used to it. It don't help anyway. I know you want to crash out but nah… now's not the time for that." With raised brows he stared harder. "You hear me?"

I shrugged and looked away.

“I been there. It’s heavy as hell right now but…” he paused. “Doin’ wild shit, drinking and all that.. It won’t help. It’ll only make matters worse. Can’t be out here sloppy, drunk, fighting and shit. I’m sure big bro wouldn’t even want you on that type of time.”

I didn’t say anything. Wrapped my arms around my body and just nodded.

“Keep yo head up, Sarah.”

I squinted. “Sereia.”

“Oh shit, my bad. *Sereia*.”

He walked off and I watched him until he was about three doors down. As soon as I walked back into the apartment, Dom and Lake were on my head.

“What the hell was that about?” Dom asked. “And why is it so damn dirty in here? It stank!” They were all in the apartment earlier. Guess they were too riddled with grief to notice how dirty it was.

Lakeland turned her nose up. “It’s definitely reakin’ in this bitch. Is that why you had him in the hallway? What did he say? Girl, I liked to fucking lose it when he swooped your ass up. You know that bitch still down there talking like you didn’t just drag her rat ass?”

Lakeland talked fast. A hundred and fifty words per minute for real. As she talked, she picked up around the living room, grabbing food containers and junk mail. Dom snatched the trash bag out of the bin. I stood off by the door, still a little caught off guard by Exodus’s prayer. Not because he cursed but because he prayed. I mean, they prayed at the funeral… people said they were praying for me. But nobody had ever actually prayed for me, with me. Nobody but my mama, at least. That was… wow.

“He prayed for me,” I blurted out, cutting Lake off.

They stopped in their tracks. “Wait—what?” asked Dom. “Exodus’s big, mean ass did not pray for you.”

I nodded. “Grabbed my hand, bowed his head and spoke to the man upstairs,” I said, referring to God as the man upstairs like my momma used to.

“What the hell,” said Lake.

“Same thing I was thinking,” I mumbled, his words still heavy on my mind.

It wasn’t like the prayer was profound. It was simple. Generic, really. It was the fact that he did it at all. That was going to sit with me for a long

time. Probably for the rest of my life.

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CHAPTER 6

EXODUS



"She straight?" Asked Zeke when I made it back across the field over to the courtyard where Meech's repast was being held.

Shaking my head, I stood beside him, stuffing my hands into the pockets of my jeans. 'She' was Meech's little sister. Sereia. She wasn't okay. Had just gotten into a fight. Damn near beat the life out that bitch. If it weren't for me scooping her lil' ass up, she for sure would have. That wasn't why she wasn't okay and wouldn't be for a minute. It was Meech's death and some more shit. Pain weighed heavy on her. Very heavy. So heavy that when I grabbed her hands a minute ago, to pray for her, I felt the shit hit me.

There was a lot of pain inside of her. Sensed it before we grabbed hands. Sensing it was why I decided to pray for her in the first place. I didn't hold hands with people. Didn't really go to Big G about them neither. But today I felt compelled to. Was told to. I wasn't the cleanest nigga. I did dirt. Sinned like crazy. But I was connected. The holy spirit fucked with me heavy. So… I prayed for her. Talked to Big G about her. But the prayer didn't end there. When I walked away, on my way back to the yard, I kept praying. The pain I felt come up off her ran deeper than just the grief of losing her brother.

The fight was just the beginning, for real. She was going to get worse. Angrier. Colder. More vicious. Reckless too. She'd been hitting the bottle. Something told me she wasn't on that type of time before Meech. She didn't seem like the other bitches in The Woods. When we pulled up on her that night, she was in the crib. In pajamas. Literal pajamas. A set. Bitches

that drunk heavy, got high, and ran around the hood didn’t move like that. Shit, if she was one of them, she wouldn’t have been in the crib at all.

“Mannn,” Zeke said, shaking his head, looking in the same direction as me. “Shorty gon’ be fucked up out here. You know all they had was each other. Just imagine, bro.”

“She gon’ be straight,” I responded, eyes centered on the group of young niggas heading for the courtyard. Taking my hands out of my pocket, I crossed my arms across my chest.

I let what Zeke said digest a little. I had a soft spot in my heart for baby girl for some reason. I didn’t give too much of a fuck about a lot of people. If you didn’t have Christ blood flowing through your veins, or if you wasn’t my bitch, I didn't give a fuck about what you had going on for real. Felt like it might’ve been guilt a lil bit, low key. Had I stopped Zeke before it got to this point, her brother wouldn’t be dead. Low key, I felt a little responsible. Aside from that, whenever I was in her presence, I felt the sadness coming up off her. Being in the slums, around so much poverty and heartache, feeling what other people felt came easy. Theirs was easy to ignore. However, it was different with her. Couldn’t ignore it. Like I said though, could’ve been that guilt. Even that was odd. I didn’t have a heart when it came to shit for real. Guilt wasn’t something I felt. Not unless it pertained to my Sweet Lady. Honestly.

“Keep an eye on her,” I said, steady watching the group of young niggas.

“I’m already on it,” Zeke said, stepping forward a little, hands stuffed into his pocket, eyes laser focused on that group.

The closer they got to the courtyard, the easier it was for me to see their eyes. And as expected, their eyes were on us just as tough as ours were on them. One of them, little nigga with a long scar across his face, chucked his chin. Neither of us returned the gesture. He looked over at one of his niggas, pinched the bridge of his nose and looked back at us.

“Y’all ready?” Kiss asked.

“Fa sho,” Zeke mumbled.

I uncrossed my arms and walked off, ahead of them. Kiss walked on the right side of me, Zeke to the left.

“What up doe?” spoke the nigga with the scar.

“What’s good, nigga?” Zeke said before spitting the other way. “Y’all boys good?”

“Hell yeah,” Scarface said, eyeing me. “Crazy as hell I’m seein’ y’all here, low key. Shit, I been wanting to get up with Big Dawg for a min—”

“Hell naw,” Zeke interrupted. “We chillin.”

“Won’t take but a couple minutes,” he pressed, steady watching me.

Brushing my hand over the top of my head, I said, “Fuck you want nigga?”

He glanced over his shoulder at his boys, laughed a little, shook his head and said, “Can we chop it up in private?”

“Bout as private as it’s gon’ get,” Kiss said.

He shrugged his right shoulder. “Fuck it. I got a money proposition for you.”

I snorted. “You got a money proposition for… *me*?”

“Yeah,” he stuffed his hands into the pockets of his dusty gray joggers. “I got a cousin in Kingston. He tryin’ to get some shit moved but,” he paused and sucked his teeth. “He havin’ a lil’ issue. I heard you was the nigga to get up with if something needed to be moved from point A to point B. Feel me?”

“You heard, huh?” Zeke said with a snort.

Scarface looked from Zeke, to Kiss, and then finally at me. “I mean… I said I wanted to talk in private.”

I didn’t do business with niggas I didn’t know. I for damn sure didn’t fuck with niggas in The Woods when it came to making pape. I ran a tight ship. A very tight ship. The business relationships I had were relationships I’d had since I got into the transportation business. It was a line of work not a lot of people knew about. You had to be working with me directly to know anything about what I had going on. The fact that he knew a little something didn’t sit right with me. We’d been under the radar. Out of the way. Shit was and had always been smooth sailing when it came to moving shit.

That’s what we did.

Moved shit.

A lot of shit.

Drugs. Guns. Hell… *people*.

We were in the freight business. If you had the right amount of money, we had a method of transport that would get what you needed where it needed to be.

I wasn’t necessarily hearing what Scarface was talking about. Again, I didn’t just fuck with anybody. All money wasn’t good money. There were no shorts. I was eating good. Money didn’t excite or move me. Niggas needed to do more than that to get in with me.

“Not interested,” I said before walking off.

He followed. Walked alongside me, explaining why his cousin was legit and how we could make a lot of money together. I let him walk. I let him talk. Right up until I got across the field to the parking lot.

“You like your life, nigga?” Zeke asked. “We smooth. He said he ain’t interested. Move around.”

Scarface sucked his teeth. I locked eyes with him and smirked. Smiled, really. His eyebrows shot up and he drew back. “Aight, aight. No disrespect Big Dawg. I just… shit.. thought we could get money together. Feel me? Zeke, bro, you already know I don’t mean no disrespect. It’s all love this way.” He held his hands up. “On granny.”

“Niggas hungry though,” he continued. “Ribs touchin, for real. We just tryin’ to eat and—“

“This look like a soup kitchen, bruh?” Zeke asked. Sucking his teeth, he continued. “You got your answer. Move around. Last time.”

He held his hands up again. Averted his eyes between me, Kiss and Zeke. “Aight. I hear you bro. Look… I’m Tre’. My cousin… Jay—Jayceon… a real money getting nigga. Name hold a lil’ weight. Y’all might know about him. He bout his business. Just experiencing a couple hiccups. I’m right here, all day, every day. You have a change of heart, Big Dawg, get up with me.”

He walked away. We watched him for a couple of seconds and eventually got into the whip. As soon as we did, Kiss and I exchanged looked. Zeke, from the backseat, gripped the headrests and moved up, to be positioned in between us.

“Jayceon,” Zeke said. “Out in Kingston. That’s the third time, brodie.”

I nodded and shifted my eyes to the rearview mirror, watching Scarface and his boys as they walked off. “I’m hip.”

“How we movin’?” Kiss asked. A second later, the sound of a lighter flickering off told me he’d sparked fire to a blunt.

“We not,” I told him, steady watching dawg and his niggas as they made their way back over to the courtyard. “Not yet.”

Looking away from the rearview mirror, I pushed the start button, starting the engine.

“Dumb ass nigga just out here droppin’ names,” Zeke said, sitting back against the seat. “Don’t know what type of time we on.”

“‘Xactly,” Kiss added.

I didn’t say anything. Drove off with a lot to think about.

* * *

“I CAN’T LEAVE,” I said, talking to Jada. “Relax. You can chill for a couple of days, Jada.”

She pouted. “But, I miss you. I’m bored and—can I just come over there?”

I shook my head, resting against the back of the couch, arm crossed over my chest, watching The Bernie Mac show with moms. “You already know the answer to that question.”

Jada didn’t come around. Not because there was an issue or anything like that but because I was very intentional about the energy I allowed in my mom’s crib. Which was why I wasn’t fucking with no white ass nursing companies out here. Fuck that. Didn’t want no pasty ass white bitch moving around the crib, passing judgement and shit on us. I wanted someone from around the way. Someone with skin and roots that closely resembled ours. The home health companies out in Wildermere didn’t employ black people. All of that equal opportunity employer shit didn’t fly out here. They didn’t give a fuck.

When it came to Jada though, I kept her away because shit… her energy wasn’t always right. She came around one time and put on a façade. Got overly sweet. Started to overdo it, trying to impress OG. That was years ago. Before we moved moms out here. When I was fresh out from behind them walls. After that, I said nah… it’s a dub on shorty. I was big on authenticity and she lacked that. Which was crazy as fuck to me because she was trying to impress a woman who wasn’t even all the way there mentally. Fuck was she putting on for someone who didn’t even know she was there?

Jada sucked her teeth. “I wish you would let that go. I was nervous.”

“Nah,” I snorted. “You was fake as fuck.”

“What am I supposed to do?”

“Shid,” I paused, smirking at Bernie Mac’s dumb ass. God rest his soul. We lost a legend, for sure. “Don’t you got about five hundred k followers? Talk to them mafuckas.”

Again, she sucked her teeth. I hated that shit so fuckin’ bad, bro.

“Six hundred, thirty two k,” she corrected. “And I don’t want to talk to them. I don’t want to talk at all.”

I shifted my eyes from the TV, to the phone. As expected, she was biting her bottom lip, on freak shit. I slouched down a little into the couch cushion, smirking at her. “And you think you about to come over here and eat dick while my ma in the next room?”

She grunted, slammed her hand on the mattress, having a tantrum like a little ass girl. “You get on my nerves.”

“You love it though.”

Rolling her eyes, she shrugged. “I guess. Can we do lunch tomorrow? Something? I’m bored, X.”

“What you do today?” I asked, shifting the conversation.

She placed a piece of her honey blond hair behind her ear. “Um.”

I stared at her, waiting for her to tell me what she’d done all day. I knew. I just wanted to see if she would be honest. If Jada was smart—which sometimes I wasn’t too sure if she was—she’d keep it one hundred with me. Her nerves and hesitation told me she wouldn’t. I didn’t press though. I stared and waited. Watched as she pulled her lips into her mouth. Noticed when she looked off. And when she looked up at the ceiling, I noticed that too. She was nervous as fuck.

“I crossed the bridge.”

“What you do tho’?”

“You know what I did if I crossed the bridge, Exodus.”

I shook my head. “Nah, I don’t. Enlighten me, baby doll.”

“Exodus,” she pouted.

She went across the bridge. To see her pops. Without an escort. Without a *proper* escort at least. I had eyes on Jada. Kept eyes on her. Even when she didn’t think I did. I was a busy nigga. Couldn’t be everywhere at once. So, I had other people step in at places I couldn’t.

“I saw my daddy.”

“TikTok see him too?” I challenged.

She growled out of frustration. “I thought we weren’t talking about that anymore.”

“We’re not. I’m asking.”

TikTok saw pops for sure. She just uploaded the video from today a couple of hours ago and she’d already had over two hundred thousand views, comments out the ass, and likes too. I didn’t just keep tabs on her in real life—I kept tabs on her on that internet shit too. I wasn’t a creepy nigga. I didn’t like to invade her privacy or shit like that. But I had to. You think for one second that I’d allow my bitch to be on social media, in my crib, without doing my due diligences? Fuck no. I had too much to lose. Too much going on. I couldn’t just take Jada’s word for it when she said she was being careful.

“Yes, Exodus. I recorded him. But we went out. I didn’t just—I didn’t just get him like that. I picked him up. We went to Target, Milo’s, and I got him a phone too. It was a whole little day. I didn’t—“

“You took your crackhead daddy across the bridge, parading him around all them fuck ass white people in Target. Then took him to Milo’s to sit in them peoples restaurant, most likely smelling like ass. With a camera in his face. Then when you got enough footage for the day, you dropped him back off at the spot. Don’t dress it up like you did some charity work or some shit, J.”

By the time I was done talking, she had tears in her eyes. Crying was her go to. However, I wasn’t moved by it. Jada was just… man, she was misguided as hell. Despite the lame shit she’d been on, she was a sweetheart and really did miss her pops. That social media shit just had her head gone. Everything Jada was getting was what she always wanted. So of course, it had her moving the way she’d been moving. Attention becomes a dangerous drug when you let it get to you.

“It wasn’t even like that. You always—

“I’m always what?” I cut in. “Trying to get you to see pass the superficial, top layer shit? You don’t think about anybody but Jada for real. It ain’t even just about you takin’ yo pops across the bridge down like that. You know what them mafuckas think about us as a whole. Just wasn’t a good look for us as a community as a whole. You don’t give a fuck tho’. Care too much about collectin’ videos that you even went to the hood by yourself.”

“I’m good out there!” She yelled. “You be killin me with that man…”

“Yeah, aight. You good out there,” I said with a snort. Stretching, I shifted my eyes back over to the TV. “Fed my kids?” I asked, referring to the dogs.

“Yes, I fed them, Exodus,” she softly said.

At the sound of sniffling, I looked back at the phone. I took a deep breath, tossing my head back against the cream colored couch. A shade moms always wanted when I was little but wouldn’t get because she had five bad ass kids dirtying shit up. It was only right for me to get her together when we moved her here.

I stared at Jada for a good five minutes, ignoring her every time she would go ‘what X? Huh? What!?’ I just watched her. Hating that I would literally have to explain to her. Hating that, I was once again, having a conversation about what true respect and morals were. Jada… because of her upbringing wasn’t the brightest. Pretty as hell. Bout as dumb as a doorknob, high key. It took a ton of patience to deal with her. We’d lasted this long because Jada was Jada and I didn’t mind it. Not too much. Underneath it all was a sweet girl who just wanted to be accepted, taken care of, and loved. Sometimes I found the naivety cute. Other times… times like lately… I found it annoying as hell.

“J,” I called out when she dropped her head. “Regardless of where he at in life… he’s your pops—

“I know—

“Let me talk. Because this is my last time talkin’ about this,” With raised brows, I stared deeper into the camera. “You hear me?”

She nodded.

“Like I was saying… regardless of where he at in life, he’s your pops and you shouldn’t have him up on the internet bold. You say you got on that type of time because the bitch got to talkin’ reckless in the comments. Made you feel like you needed to prove some shit. To mafuckas that don’t know you. Aight, bet. Givin’ a fuck about what mafuckas think or say ain’t never been in me. But it’s in you. Shits embedded, for real. Always have been. I can’t wrap my mind around it but shit, it ain’t for me to understand. We individuals for a reason.

What I want for you Jada, is to never switch your pivot. Not for another mafucka. Especially if it’s in a direction you know ain’t morally right. In your spirit you had to know you were movin’ flaw. You gotta fix that, baby doll.”

By the time I finished my lil' speech, her face was wet with tears. Makeup smeared and shit.

Sitting against the back of the couch, I tugged on my beard, watching her, deciding I'd soften my approach a little. She didn't know any better but… I put her up on game. I put her up on a bunch of shit. But there were only so many conversations I'd have about morals and respect. I was big on that. Jada knew. Because she hadn't disrespected me in general, she probably thought it wasn't as bad. But it was. Because it was her pops, it was worse.

"Jada."

"Yes, Exodus? I heard you. You never let me explain anything so—

"You couldn't have heard me if you still comin' at me with your feelings on your skin. Sat that shit aside and actually eat what I served. I mean, for real."

She sighed, her slender shoulders rising and falling. Tossing her head back, she grunted and then put her eyes back on the screen. "Okay, babe. I—I'm listening. I hear you."

I nodded, hoping she was telling the truth. I fucked with Jada. Liked what little she did bring to the table, but I wouldn't hesitate to remove her from it if necessary.

* * *

THE NEXT MORNING, I woke up to the sound of my alarm. Dragging my hands down my face, I grunted and reached over to the nightstand to silence the alarm. Seven o'clock. Yawning, I sat up, closed my eyes and said my usual morning prayer: Thank you. It wasn't much, but it was good enough.

Stretching, I grabbed my phone and checked it. Nothing. Just the way I liked it. People knew not to hit me before or after certain times. I was serious as hell about my business hours. But at around twelve, the phone was going to be jumping.

I got out of bed and hit the connected bathroom to piss, wash my face and brush my teeth. After handling everything in the bathroom, I headed down to my ma's bedroom. I tapped on the door a couple of times before walking in. She was up. Hands resting on her chest, eyes to the ceiling, quiet. As usual. The last time I heard her voice, she was screaming at the

top of her lungs for my pops. It was a couple of days after he died. She'd have these screaming fits, almost as if she'd snapped out of a fog and back into reality where Isaiah no longer existed. She went from having screaming fits to complete silence. You'd think we would have preferred the quiet, but we didn't. Well shit, I knew for sure that I didn't. The screaming told me she was still here with us. Living, in reality, regardless of how irate it might've been. The silence was unsettling, for real.

"Good morning, Sweet Lady," I said, drawing the drapes to her balcony doors.

After I opened the drapes to the door, I moved over to the windows and drew those too. Since the sun was shining, I decided that we'd have breakfast in the backyard on the patio instead of at the kitchen island. Moms needed the sun on her.

I walked over to the bed and kissed her on the top of her salt and peppered fro. "After I get you together we gon' go outside and eat breakfast. Cool?"

As expected, she didn't say anything.

Before pops died, moms and I were close as hell. Damn near every morning, I'd wake up and go straight to my parents' room to hug and talk to my momma. We kicked it. I was able to keep it real with her. Talking to her came easier than talking to my pops. The both of them were heavily religious, but pops? Pops had the word of God literally embedded in him and clung on to every word. Moms, however, understood that we were human—young boys, growing up in the hood—so we would fall short. That didn't stop her from chastising me when I got a little too out of pocket though. I missed those days the most. I couldn't believe my OG was literally a shell of who she used to be.

After helping her out of bed, we headed for her bathroom. Despite wanting to take care of her, this was a part of the process that would take some getting used to.

It wasn't ideal.

Seeing my ma naked but shit, what else was I supposed to do? Leave her here to fend for herself because I was a little uncomfortable? Put it all on Genny when I knew for a fact sis needed a break and could use a vacation? I was a lot of things but selfish wasn't one of them. Plus, I loved the fuck out of my family and would go to the end of the world for them.

Wreck some shit and go through a little bit of discomfort for them too. It was all love.

Once she was in the shower, I did what Genny suggested. Added body wash to her rag and handed it to her. I exhaled when she took it from me. First time she did that since I've been out here. Stepping back, I closed the shower door and told her I would be back in a little bit to check on her.

Walking out of the bathroom, I closed the door behind me and leaned against it. Tossing my head back against it, I closed my eyes and prayed for the second time today. Asking God for strength and of course healing over my moms. I'd been praying for that shit since the start of it. You'd think I would have given up by now, but nah. I knew in my spirit that there was only a matter of time before the real Marietta came back. Shit just took a little—or a lot—of patience.

Hours later, ma was dressed, breakfast was done and we were out on the patio eating. I threw some shit together real quick. Scrambled eggs with cheese, grits, and sausage links. Nothing too crazy. I wasn't the best at cooking, but I did a little something. I thought about getting a cook to come to the house but again… I was selective as fuck about who I allowed in the crib. The home health thing was different. That was necessary. Anything extra and unnecessary usually stayed on the other side of the door.

"You done?" I asked moms, noticing when she pushed her plate aside.

She looked off into the distance, slight smile on her face. Often, I wondered what could be going through her mind. When she smiled, had she slipped into time? To a better place? Where pops was here and we were complete? Did she see herself at the church, doing what she did best: work the room? I thought about that a lot, low key. Wondered if she wasn't here because she was someplace else.

I grabbed her plate and asked her if she wanted to go back into the crib. Communicating with her when she was nonverbal was hard, but I was good at reading body language. Knowing what she wanted wasn't the easiest but if I paid close enough attention, I would get it. I stood there a minute, studying her, watching as she looked around the backyard, possibly admiring the blossoming flowers, and the bushes that were starting to sprout. A couple of feet away, on the fence sat a red cardinal. I followed her eyes and realized then, that she was staring at it. She wasn't ready to go inside. Cool.

I took our plates into the crib and rejoined her at the patio table. Crossing one arm over my chest, I grabbed my phone and scrolled my homepage until I got to the Kindle app. Tapping it, I sat back and read picked up where I left off at in ‘Hoodlum’ by K’Wan.

I was a reader. Wouldn’t say I was heavy into it. I did it when I could. When life slowed down enough for me to. If I wasn’t tired as fuck by the end of the night, I usually laid up reading until I fell asleep. Jada hated that shit. Couldn’t understand how me—as the nigga that I was—read books. If she would have paid attention back in the day when we were coming up, she would've seen then that I was into it.

I got into it for an escape. First got into it in middle school. Eighth grade, I think. Peeped this one chick reading ‘True To The Game’. Asked her what it was and she put me on. That was the first book I read. Shit had me hooked. It was like looking in the mirror, for real. I wasn’t off in the streets of course, but it was all around me. So, yeah. I was immediately hooked. As the son of a preacher, I probably shouldn’t have been reading it, but I never gave a fuck. Snuck to the library to read hood books every day. Pops thought I was on some studying shit. Nah, I was reading about murder, drugs, guns, and fucking.

After sitting out there with her for a good hour or so, I closed the book, took moms in the crib, and got on the jack with Kiss. Because I was out here with moms, him and Zeke were handling the bulk of the logistics.

“What up doe?” Kiss answered before coughing. Nigga was for sure smoking his morning wood.

“Checkin in,” I said, sitting on the couch, eyes peeled, watching The Bernie Mac Show. That was what moms did. Sit on the couch all day, eyes glued to old ass episodes of Bernie Mac until it was time for her to do something else. That was changing today though. I was going to give her a couple hours on it and then we were going to go for a walk. She had the use of her limbs—it was her mind that wasn’t right. Genesis did what she could. Appeased moms. Kept her calm and shit like that but to me, in order to see real improvement we had to keep her outside and mobile. Coming here, being here for a couple of days showed me just how flawed her everyday routine was.

“‘Bout to go to the church right now,” he said. “What moms doin?”

“Same shit,” I said. “I’m about to take her out for a walk though. Up the block for now. When shorty come I’m going to have her gradually increase

it. Probably see about getting her on the trail."

"You think she up for that?"

"Not really. That's why we ain't goin far for real. Just a couple houses down. Weather breakin'… gotta get her up off this couch."

"Good shit," he said. "You think about what happened yesterday?"

I stroked my beard. "Hell naw. You know me."

He was talking about Scarface and the name he'd brought up. His cousin. Jayceon. A name I'd heard three times this year now and we were only in the fourth month. Might not have been much to you but for me it was plenty. I was anal about numbers. They spoke to me. And for as long as I could remember, the number three was substantial to me. If I was the type of person that had shit like favorites, three would be my favorite number. But I didn't cling to things. Understood that everything was temporary. But the number three? The number three was a part of me. Followed me despite how often I tried to ignore it. Threes were what made me anal about numbers in the first place. If I saw one too often, I paid attention to it and listened to what it was trying to tell me.

Although it'd been my third time hearing the name Jayceon, I didn't think about it too much. I never thought too long about shit. I was a person that moved off intuition and guidance. Sitting up, trying to figure out how to move on something because it'd come to me three times did me no good. When it was time for me to do something about it, I would. I hadn't been given the urge to move, so… I didn't move. I let the spirit guide me.

My brothers knew what the number three meant to me too and had been around all three times the name Jayceon came up. I wasn't hasty though. It could be a warning. Could be a sign to move forward. I was in no rush to find out which.

He coughed. "Heard from shorty them yet?"

"Nope," I said with a sigh. "I'm giving it a few days. If nothing happens, nothing happens and I move on."

"How we gon' handle ma? You can't stay out—"

"I know. I'll know what to do when I know what to do."

After a couple more minutes of chopping it up, we got off. The clock struck twelve and I was almost immediately hit with a plethora of calls, messages and emails. I might've been out here with OG but that didn't *really* stop shit. I pushed up off the couch, grabbed my MacBook from the kitchen island and got to work.

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CHAPTER 7

SEREIA



"AIN'T NO CHEESE ON MY BURGER," SAID THE BITCH STANDING IN FRONT OF me with a screwed look on her face, before tossing the burger on the counter.

Squinting, I stared at her, remembering her from about twenty minutes ago. She was with a group of dirty hoodrat bitches. They walked in loud as hell, taking forever to order. Talking about the bum ass niggas they were fucking rather than what they wanted to eat.

I was at work.

Clearly. Cashiering at one of the most popular coney islands in Wildermere. I hated it. Hated it real bad, but what else was I supposed to do? Not work? Jobs were limited here. If you didn't have a nursing certificate or didn't have pull to get into one of the warehouses, nine times out of ten you were working at a fast-food restaurant or some weak ass retail store that didn't pay much.

Coney was good to me, I guess.

They didn't pay but about five dollars an hour, but I got good ass tips so that was a plus. It was enough to contribute to the bills. Pay them fully? Ehhh, I doubted it. That was something else to think about for another day. I still had a couple of dollars from the ten thousand Exodus gave me, but what was I to do when that dried up? I had to stack. I was just winging shit, hoping like hell that I'd be able to cover rent for the coming months. Which was why I'd been so nice all day, despite wanting to cut up on people.

"Because you ordered a hamburger."

She frowned. "What? Duh. Hamburgers come with cheese. The fuck."

“No,” I said, shaking my head. “Cheeseburgers come with cheese.”

She stared at me for a couple of seconds before rolling her eyes and scratching the back of her head. “Anyway. Same thing for real. Can I just get cheese on my burger? No onions, extra mayo!”

I looked down at the burger and pushed it away from me. “You can keep it. I’ll get him to make you another one.”

I walked away and went over to the grill area where the cook, Mike, was. Leaning against the wall, I crossed my arms over my chest, eyeing him, hating I would have to get him to remake a burger he didn’t mess up.

“Mike,” I said, calling out to him. He had on a pair of big ass headphones, bobbing his head to music, flipping patties.

He didn’t say anything. Didn’t even notice me. I took a deep breath, pushed up away from the wall and walked over to him. Shoving him, I finally got his attention.

He pulled one side of the headphones off his ear, resting it on top of his head. “Rei-Rei. What’s good, baby?”

I looked over my shoulder towards the counter and then back at him. “Remember them bitches from earlier? The group that came in, loud as hell not too long ago?”

“Yeah, what up?”

I sighed, rolling my eyes. “The hamburger with no onions, extra mayo? She really wanted a cheeseburger. Can you remake it?”

He sucked his teeth. “Man what?”

“Exactly. Talking about hamburgers come with cheese. Dumb ass bitch.”

He shook his head and snatched the hamburger tray from its warmer.

Sensing his frustration, I leaned in a little. “Give that bitch extra, extra mayo too, Mike. You hear me?”

“So, she can come back and complain about that? Dawg—”

“And if she bring her raggedy mouth ass in here complaining about that I’m going to look her dead in her face and tell her she asked for extra mayo. Just make it.”

I walked away, back up to the front of the restaurant and told the bitch it would be up in about five minutes. You know this bitch still gave me attitude? I didn’t let it bother me though. I expected such. I dealt with bitches like her all day, every day.

Sighing, I picked my phone up to check the time. 5:15PM. I got here at eleven and wouldn't be leaving until eleven. I didn't usually work long hours. I didn't work past five, for real. Mainly because Meech didn't like for me to get off late and partially because I didn't have to work like that. He had everything covered. What I made was just extra. But because he was gone, I had to pull all of the weight so, I was here. Told my boss I could work seven days a week too. He was only able to give me four days because of the other girls but… whatever. It was more than what I used to work so it helped.

About five minutes later, Mike yelled about the burger being up. I smirked when I picked it up, noticing the mayo residue on the side of the aluminum foil. I grabbed a fresh brown paper bag and put it inside before handing it to her. She snatched it, walked away and out of the restaurant.

I took a deep breath, shook my head and got back on my phone. Working here required a lot of patience. Patience I didn't really have these days. I was still heavy in my feelings about Meech, mad most of the day. But because I needed the tips, I had been nice at work. Although I really, really, didn't want to be.

Someone cleared their throat and I looked up from my phone. I rolled my eyes at the sight of Vellz's dumb ass.

"What? That's how you greet yo' customers? Damn, baby," he annoyingly said, cockily smirking.

"What you want, nigga?"

"Where Warren at? I'm gotta tell him how you treatin' his loyal customers."

The niggas he was with snickered, leaned on the counter and spoke. Harold, Darnell, and Eli. The same niggas he'd been cool with for years. They were alright. We weren't friends or anything like that. I spoke to them, and eyed Vellz up and down, waiting for him to order. Ever since I beat his bitch up, he'd been either coming up here or to the apartment trying to explain. If it weren't for me blocking him, he'd still be calling me all day, every day. I told his goofy ass he didn't need to explain anything to me. Fucking him was a decision I made in a moment of weakness. It wouldn't happen again. I was sure of that. And it wasn't just because he had a girlfriend or whatever. It was precisely because he was Vellz and before that night, he couldn't even get my pussy wet anymore.

"*What do you want, nigga*? *Damn*," I asked again.

He sucked his teeth, dug into his pocket, retrieving a knot of money. Glancing down at it, I snorted at all of the five-dollar bills. Vellz wasn't broke but he carried himself as if he was a true money getting nigga. He was a corner boy. Working for Khaos, the same nigga Meech use to work for, putting his life on the line for a couple of measly dollars.

He peeled two twenties off and stuffed them into my tip jar. "Ten minutes to talk."

I tilted my head to the side a little. "About what, Vellz? I told you I wasn't tripping about that shit."

He didn't believe me. Thought I was capping. Swore up and down him having a girlfriend bothered me. Niggas. They really did think they meant more to us than they actually did. I was not tripping. Not even a little bit. I beat her ass because of disrespect. Not because I was bitter.

He leaned on the counter, locked eyes with me and licked his lips. "You know I can tell when you lyin right?"

He gave me the ick.

I mean, the nigga *really* gave me the ick. I should have never given him any pussy. I was trippin. See the type of shit you get me into, Meech? Leaving me down here to sort through grief, alone, hurting? I couldn't lie—when I was in it with Vellz, it felt amazing. He literally gave me comfort. Made me forget for a minute. Made me feel something other than pain. It was everything I needed in the moment. But I felt disgusted immediately after. Now more than before because like… Sereia… why did you do that? Now this nigga swear up and down I'm on his ass like I was before.

Never again.

Vellz couldn't wrap his mind around it because usually when I went back, I was hooked again and open to talking about the possibility of us. He had to think his bitch ruined it. Which… she actually hadn't ruined anything at all.

"I'm not lying though—

"Damn nigga you gon order or what? Fuck goin' on?" said somebody from the back of the line. I hadn't even noticed anyone else walk in. The line was growing.

Vellz squinted and looked over his shoulder. "Hold up nigga, damn. I am orderin'. She won't give me what I want though."

"No, for real. Either order or get out of the way. You see all these people coming in?" I said, irritated.

It was busy.

Coney was typically always busy. This one especially since we had the best corned beef sandwiches, wings, and chili fries in the hood. All of the getting money niggas from around the way came here. Kobra's Coney Island stayed slapping. On Friday's after five, especially. Vellz had picked the perfect time to come up here on that bullshit, hadn't he?

He looked over his shoulder again, sucking his teeth at the steady building line. The bells above the door kept sounding off. They were piling in like crazy.

"Girl, if you don't move this line," said Moe, the cashier at the drive-thru, walking up beside me. "Before Warren's fat ass come out here talkin' shit."

"I'll talk to you when I get off," I said to Vellz. "Now move!"

"Don't forget you said that. I'ma come scoop you and—

"Okay, okay," I said, rushing him, waving him off.

Just as I was getting ready to take Harold's order, the hoodrat from before… extra mayo… stormed back in.

Instead of waiting in line like everyone else, she walked up to the counter and threw her burger down. "Fuck is this shit!? Y'all tryna be funny? Giving me all this fucking mayo? Bitch—

"You asked for cheese," I said, unmoved by all of the extra shit she was doing. "You got cheese. You asked for extra mayo..." I held my hand out with a shrug. "You got extra mayo. What's wrong?"

"Bree, if you don't get yo ho ass on. We tryna order!" yelled one of the niggas in line.

"Nah, this bitch trying to be funny. I should jump behind there and—"

"And what?" Moe asked. "Get beat the fuck up?"

"Chill, chill, chill," said someone else. "Baby girl valid. My nigga Mike, too. Ain't shit wrong with yo burger. You just want some shit to complain about, bitch."

Turning the corners of my mouth up, I looked away from her, and at Harold. "What you say you wanted, Harold?"

I paid that bitch dust.

I was good where I was at. This was my hood. My coney. Everybody fucked with me because I was cool. Known up here as the sweet girl who didn't take any shit. Any time I interacted with people, it was good vibes and good vibes only. I might've been carrying the grief of losing my brother

heavy, but I didn't let that affect how I showed up at work. Yeah, I might've been a little snappy. I might've been on edge. But I didn't walk in with negative energy, making my problems everyone else's. I smiled. I thanked them. I wished them a good day. Every single time, regardless of what I had going on. And in return, they kept my tip cup full and looked out for me whenever shit got a little hectic. Not only did I have the support of the community, but Moe, Mike, Warren and the rest of the girls had my back too. I was one not to play with. Aside from that though, people swore up and down I was a witch because I wore crystals. They stayed joking, saying I would turn the people that fucked with me into roaches. I found it hilarious.

"Let me get a… uhhh… wing ding dinner. Throw chili and cheese on them bitches too," Harold said, fishing a wad of money from his pocket. "Ay, Mike! Look out for me on the wing ding dinner, my baby. You hear me?"

"Hell yeah! I got you, fa sho!" Mike yelled back.

Meanwhile, the boot mouth hood rat bitch stood there, arms crossed over her shoulders, steady talking shit. I paid her no mind, doing my job with a smile on my face, interacting with the people who needed to order. After a while, though, Warren came from his office to address her. He examined the burger and I told him she asked for extra mayo. We locked eyes briefly before he wrapped the burger back up and handed it to her, saying she got what she asked for and told her to leave or she wouldn't be allowed back into the restaurant. Warren got on our nerves for the most part but one thing he always did was back us when he knew for a fact a customer was being a bitch on purpose. Bitch carried her mayo burger and left the restaurant after that. Like I said, Kobra's Coney was the best in the area and if there was one thing a bitch didn't want to lose out on it was access to some good ass coney.

Hours later, the time was inching in on eleven. My feet were killing me. Back and hips too. Swear, sometimes I felt like I was a lot older than twenty-one. It was the shoes and standing up all day that had been doing my body bold. The restaurant was jumping and I'd changed my tip cup four times today already, with cup five overflowing. It was a good ass night.

After getting the line down, I walked away to grab me a cup of water. When I returned to the counter, I was greeted by Zeke.

"What up doe, sis?" he spoke.

“Hey. The usual?” I asked, getting ready to take his order down.

Chili fries, double bacon cheeseburger, and red Kool-Aid. It was the same thing every time he came in here.

“That and throw two corned beef sandwiches and two more orders of chili fries on that bitch, for me. Extra cheese on both. One, put the cheese on the top and bottom. Throw some extra cheese on them sandwiches too, for me, sis.”

He fished around his pocket and pulled a fat knot out. All big faced hundreds. He peeled one off, handed it to me, and stuffed another one in my tip cup. I looked at it and then back up at him with raised brows. After I rung him up and handed him the change, he took it and put that in the tip cup too. We made eye contact for a minute before he leaned on the counter and looked off.

“Thank you,” I mumbled, still feeling some type of way towards him. I wasn’t sure if that would ever change.

“Fa sho,” he replied. “You already know.”

I turned away to grab orders from the back counter. My eyes filled with tears. I took a deep breath, looked up and gripped one of the brown paper bags, reading the receipt. My vision grew a little foggy as I tried to fight off tears. Today had been such a good day money wise. The best I’d had since I’d been back to work. Any time someone would put something other than a couple of dollars in my cup, we’d make eye contact and I’d feel like they did it on purpose. To support. Because, hello… everybody knew. They knew my brother was gone. My fucking heart. To know me, was to know Meech and vice versa. Regardless of if you knew either of us or not, word about him passing spread around Wildermere like wildfire. He was widely known. Either personally, or just by name.

I swallowed my tears, took another deep breath and piled two bags into a plastic handle bag to pass out to the customer. Turning, I stood at the counter and called out for them to come get their stuff, shifting my eyes to the big clock on the wall. 10:40PM. Just twenty more minutes. I was running out of this muthafucka.

Twenty minutes went by pretty quick, thanks to the continuous rush of customers. It got so busy that Warren had to ask the other cashier, Quisha to clock in early, before eleven. We tag teamed customers, getting them up out of there. They wanted me to stay later, but because I was already pushing it, staying until eleven, I told them I couldn’t.

After grabbing my purse and the grilled chicken pita Mike made for me, I told them goodnight and headed out. Walking into the crowded lobby, I looked around for Vellz. He said he would be here before I got off to talk and to take me back to The Woods. I looked around for a couple of minutes before realizing he wasn't there. Shaking my head, I frowned and fished around my purse for my pocket knife before turning to walk out of the restaurant. The Woods was only a fifteen-minute walk away. Not that bad. But for eleven o'clock at night, it was horrible. Meech would whoop my ass, knowing I was getting ready to walk home this late.

Because I was a little scared, I called Lakeland. She answered almost immediately, yelling at RJ in the background.

"Hey bitch. How was work?"

"Good as hell. I made a nice amount of money," I said, pushing the door open, the bells attached to it chiming.

"Straight up? Damn, that's wassup."

"Right. Why Vellz bitch ass come up here earlier, right? He on my ass, trying to talk, annoying me. He say he gon' come pick me up and take me home so we can talk… nigga ain't here."

"Swear to God? Don't tell me you walking home. Why didn't you just ask Mike to drop you off?"

"Mike stayin over. It's cool. I got my knife."

"I'm about to put on my shoes and meet you half way—"

"Girl, I'm good. Just stay on the phone with me."

I walked out of the coney into a crowded ass parking lot. The drive thru line was jumping too. Music was blasting. There was a combination of all types of sounds colliding with each other. Some old school, some new school. Drake, Che, Doughboyz Cash Out, Sada… just about everything. So much was going on that you could barely catch a beat. The bitches were out too. As a matter of fact, extra mayo and her girls were posted up, against a raggedy ass Malibu. I'd be lying if I said I was surprised to see her.

When she saw me, she tapped one of her girls and pushed up off of the car.

"*Oh my fuckin' God*," I mumbled, rolling my eyes, hating that I was about to get into some shit.

I wasn't in the mood.

It was four of them and one of me with my little pocket knife. It would do some damage but not enough before they got me on the ground to stomp

my ass. This was a fight I was about to lose, fa sho.

"What?" asked Lake, sensing the stress in my voice.

Sighing, I looked over at them, shaking my head. "Bitch, I'm about to get jumped."

"*What*?"

"Yeah, let me call you back."

I was chill.

There wasn't a fearful bone in my body. It was what it was. I accepted it but they for sure wasn't about to get off on me. I wasn't going to go down without taking at least one of them down with me.

I stopped walking, took my crossbody bag from around my neck and sat it on the ground, next to my bag of food, waiting.

"What up, bitch?" said extra mayo. "You think shit sweet?"

"Don't talk me to death, bitch," I calmly said, never with that extra talking shit. If we were going to fight, why talk? Just throw them. It was just that simple.

"Ayo!"

I looked over my shoulder at the sound of Zeke's voice. He was hanging out of the back window of that all black Wagoneer. Exodus' truck.

"You good sis?!" Zeke yelled.

I didn't say anything. Turned back around and squared up while extra mayo and her friends started to surround me. Before we could get to going, I heard tires screeching behind me. Glancing over my shoulder, I wasn't surprised to see Exodus's truck now just a couple of inches away. Because I needed to keep my head on a swivel, I turned back around, ready to fight. But extra mayo and her friends' attention was elsewhere. Their eyes were focused on what was behind me. Because I didn't trust either of them bitches, I kept my eyes peeled, thumb grazing the cold steel of the pocket knife, ready. Not even the ringing of my phone tore my attention away.

"Type of time you bitches on? Move around," Zeke said, standing next to me.

"Grab yo shit," said Exodus.

I glanced over at him but stayed where I was at, still ready to fight regardless of the number of bitches. Regardless of Zeke and them diffusing the situation. I just didn't trust it. I didn't trust a damn thing. Not when it came to bitches in Wildermere. However, around here, the word of a Christ was law. We didn't bow down to anybody out here, but they had a crazy

level of respect out here. Mainly because of what they did for the community, partially because people knew they weren't for any bullshit and would disappear a muthafucka real quick for disrespecting them in any way.

A second or two later, Exodus handed me my purse and my food, despite telling me to grab it a minute ago.

I looked over at him, snatched the purse and draped it over my head, over my shoulder before grabbing the bag of food.

"Get in the truck," said Exodus. "Now."

I drew back, ready to curse him out but before I could, he walked away. A couple of feet away, I noticed Vellz pull up. He stopped and wildly blew his horn, trying to get my attention. I looked at him, sucked my teeth and slid onto the soft leather backseat of Exodus's truck.

Once I was inside, Kiss closed the door and got into the front. Zeke sat next to me right after, and Exodus kicked the truck into reverse, then into drive and sped out of the parking lot.

"What was that about?" Zeke asked.

I shrugged, fishing around my purse for my ringing phone. "She's mad about mayo."

Kiss snorted.

Exodus's eyes caught mine in the rearview mirror.

"You walk home?" he asked.

I ignored Lake's call and texted her, telling her I'd call her when I made it to The Woods. Told her I was straight and sent the cross emoji to symbolize the Christ brothers.

"Sometimes."

"You tweakin," Zeke said, shaking his head, his long locs moving effortlessly with him. Reminded me of my brother. I looked away.

The ride to The Woods was short. The minute we got to the 'Welcome to Ironwood Estates' sign, I noticed Lakeland, Alani, and Kiera walking, getting ready to leave the complex. Upon noticing the truck, they stopped.

"You can let me out right here," I said to Exodus.

He didn't stop or say anything. Kept driving until we got to my building. When we made it to the front of the building, he shifted the truck in park, unbuckled his seatbelt and got out. Before I could open my door, he did.

"Ay sis," Zeke said. "You gotta be careful out here, my baby."

I showed him my pocket knife. “I’m careful.”

“Not enough,” Kiss said, before a thick cloud of smoke filled the air around him.

I looked down at the pocket knife, and back up at the both of them. I knew it wasn’t enough. When I first got it, Meech laughed, saying I needed to put that little shit up because if a nigga wanted me bad enough he would get at me, leaking and all. I kept it on me regardless because I was going to have something on me. I couldn’t just be out here naked.

I grabbed my sandwich, and got out of the truck, closing the door behind me.

“Let me holla at you for a minute,” Exodus said, standing on the sidewalk, a couple of feet away from the building's entrance.

I stopped in front of him, resting my arms in the front of me, my hands wrapped around the dusty brown paper bag. Looking up at him, our eyes met and because his look was a little intimidating, I glanced away, noticing my cousins heading in our direction. I took a deep breath and looked back at him.

“Wassup?” I breathed out.

He looked off, stroked his chin and then looked back down at me with this look of confusion on his face. “I got a job for you.”

“A job? For me?”

“Yeah,” he said. “Be ready to get picked up tomorrow around nine. I’ll text you fifteen minutes before.”

I drew back. “I’m not moving no drugs or—

“Man what?” He frowned. “Just be ready at nine.” He eyed me up and down. “Dress comfortable too. Leggings, crocs… shit like that.”

With that, he walked away and I stood there looking dumbfounded. I scratched the back of my head and took a deep breath. A job? I rolled my eyes, automatically thinking he wanted me down at the church for something since clearly it had nothing to do with drugs. I didn’t want to work at the church. He probably wanted me to do some type of volunteer work. That type of stuff wasn’t for me. I wasn’t religious. Believed in God, for sure but I wasn’t a Christian. Wasn’t a Baptist either. I didn't adhere to any religion; I just believed and had faith. If he wanted me to do something like mentor young girls or something, I wasn’t the girl for the job. I’d get in that church and challenge every part of the bible.

A couple of seconds later, Lake and them joined me. We watched him pull out of the parking lot before Lakeland turned to me.

“What happened? Fuck you mean you were about to get jumped? How the hell you end up with them? How y’all keep ending up in the same place?”

“Right,” Alani said, her eyes steady fixed on the back of Exodus’s truck. “What’s really goin on?”

“First the nigga givin you bread, now you pullin up with him. Don’t let me find out!” Exclaimed Kiera.

Just as I was about to say something, Vellz whipped into the parking lot, stopping just a couple of feet away from us. He was going so fast and braked so hard that Alani jumped back, thinking he would hit her.

I rolled my eyes and turned to go into the building. A second later, he got out of the car, slamming the door behind him.

“Rei!” He yelled.

“I know you ain’t callin’ my cousin like you her daddy or some shit. Pipe down,” Kiera snapped. “And I heard you were supposed to pick her up but didn’t. Fuck on, nigga.”

“Sereia!” Vellz yelled again, ignoring Kiera.

I grabbed the door handle to the building to walk in, but he pushed it closed. “You fuckin’ with that nigga, for real ain’t you? That’s why you actin so fuckin’ funny. You know he got a bitch, right?”

I looked at him like he’d lost his mind, sizing up all 5’11 inches of him. “If you don’t get the fuck out of my face with that bullshit, Chevelle,” I said with a laugh. “You in my face like you don’t have a whole ass bitch yourself. Fuck out of here.”

“I thought you didn’t care—”

“I don’t! I want you to leave me alone, nigga!” I yelled, snatching the door to the building open, hitting him with it in the process.

He had some nerve, didn’t he? In my face, questioning me about shit as if I was his bitch. As if he didn’t have someone himself. Did he forget I just beat the bitch up for stepping to me about his goofy ass? Niggas, boy. I swear, they had all of the audacity.

Before he could say anything, Lake stepped in front of him and told him to leave me alone. She said a couple of other things I didn’t hear. I was at the stairs, getting ready to take that uncomfortable trip up. My cousins were behind me, with Lake lingering behind a bit, talking to Vellz. Whatever she

said got rid of him because not too long after I started my trek up the stairs, I heard the entrance door creak open.

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CHAPTER 8

EXODUS



"How it go?" I asked Solo on the other end of the phone as I pulled into the parking lot of the abandoned potato chip factory Zeke had us at.

"Smooth," Solo said through a deep breath. "You ain't heard shit yet?"

I shook my head and killed the engine to my truck. "Hell naw." I brushed my hand over my waves and looked towards the building. "It's smooth though. You know it's a reason for everything. I got a solution."

"You do?"

I nodded. "Hell yeah. Big G put me up on game a couple ago."

"If it came from Him, then it's a move."

"Fa sho. I'll be back in about two."

"Bet."

We hung up and I stuffed the phone into the pocket of my gray joggers. Solomon was at the house with moms. I had a couple of moves to shoot with Kiss and Zeke, so I called him up and had him sit with her. He'd been at the crib all day with her, too. I did the hard part—got her up and showered—all he had to do was walk and sit with her. Anyway… yeah, today was a busy one. I had a couple of things to handle down at the docks. Had to meet with Detective Graves and now I was out here in The Bricks on the westside with Zeke on a mission at damn near midnight.

I didn't know what he had going on. After we left the sit down with Detective Graves, he got a call and told me we needed to stay out this way for another hour or so. We stopped at Coney, ate in the lot, and here we were.

Speaking of Coney. Shorty was there. Sereia. She worked there. Had to take her back to The Woods. She was into some shit. About to get into a scrap. I had to step in the middle of that shit and take her back to the crib. She didn't need to be stomping around this bitch at eleven o'clock at night anyway.

On the way there, I was hit with a message. Not one that came from my phone nor neither one of my brothers. A nudge straight from Big G. She was the one. I got a look at her through the rearview mirror and heard 'hire her'. So, it was a wrap on Guiding Light Nursing. You see how there was a delay? Yeah, that wasn't coincidental. A nigga was looking in the wrong direction. Like I said before, me and Big G had a thorough ass relationship. Any time He told me to move, I moved. I pulled up at her entrance, got out, and told her I needed her tomorrow. She was perplexed—looked at me like I was crazy but didn't question much. I didn't know what her background was. Doubted she knew anything at all about nursing. But that didn't matter. Neither me nor Genny knew what we were doing and moms was doing just fine. I wasn't drawn to her credentials. It was her heart. Her spirit, though heavy, had a lightness to it. She was in pain but underneath all of that grief was a beautiful young woman who just needed a chance.

And well… shit… I was going to give it to her.

"What you on, fool?" Kiss asked, ashing the blunt before passing it to me.

Zeke moved to the middle, leaning on the backs of our chairs. "Come in and see, pussy."

I pulled from the blunt, looked at him through the rearview and pulled from it again before finally putting it out. I grabbed my keys, and my gun and got out.

It was pitch dark out. The only light illuminating the large parking lot was one attached to the grimy building. A few feet up ahead I noticed a family of rats scurry by. Could have been possums though, they were so got damn huge.

The nighttime air brushed by my face, giving me a whiff of the mountains of trash in the alleyway behind us. I pinched my nostrils and fixed my attention on Zeke with a frown. Millard's Potato Chip factory had been closed for over a decade. The residents from the neighborhood used the alley to store overflowing trash the garbage company failed to pick up. Fiends gone off only God knows what lingered around the area, polluting it

with dirty needles and a bunch of other shit. The area around Millard's was deserted and abandoned as hell, but that didn't stop a few stragglers from hanging around. Teenaged kids that had no business in the area, prostitutes… it was a real shithole. A shithole Solomon and the congregation tried to clean up countless times. But clearly failed.

"What?" Zeke asked me, stuffing his gun into the back of his pants.

"Fuck we out here for?" I questioned, looking around, eyes settling on a parked white van with blacked out windows.

"I just said come and find out, nigga, damn. Don't you trust me?"

He walked off and Kiss and I followed him. Whole time, I kept my head on a swivel. Had to.

We made it to a worn, black metal door with a little window on top of it. Zeke tapped on it a couple of times, and turned away, looking around like Kiss and I. After a couple of seconds, I put my eyes on the little window and made eye contact with a pair of cocked eyes I could recognize anywhere. Cash's.

He opened the door just enough for us to walk in. He held his hand out for us to dap. Kiss dapped him up—I didn't. I never did. I didn't want whatever he had on him to get on me. Be it germs, or energy, I was smooth on it. Niggas knew though. I didn't shake hands. As a token of respect, I made direct eye contact and nodded. Which I did with him.

He nodded, and said, "Big Dawg. You good, baby?"

"Hell yeah," I grumbled, looking around, noticing water leaking from the high pipes. "Get to why we here so I can get the fuck out of here."

Places like this made me uncomfortable. Not because I was scared or no shit like that. Too much shit lingered on the walls in this bitch. Buildings like these held a bunch of memories. Stale, lingering energy that made me uncomfortable. A lot happened behind these walls, with the majority of it being after it closed down.

Zeke sucked his teeth and walked off. We followed up until we got to the middle of the factory where I was sure morning meetings were once held. The space was big and unoccupied. Well… free of clutter and machinery at least. Seated in the middle of the room was a young white woman, bound to a chair, her dusty blonde hair tossed wildly in her face. Her mouth was covered with duct tape. Her legs and arms too. She squirmed. The light from the moon creeping into a broken window showed me the look of terror written on her face.

Kiss and I looked at each other before simultaneously turning to Zeke.

“It’s under control,” Zeke said. “Nobody’s looking for this crackhead bitch.”

She murmured, her words fighting against the tape covering her mouth.

“Nobody’s looking for a white crackhead,” Kiss said with a snort. “Yeah, aight.”

“You think she would be here if I felt like somebody was?” Zeke shot back.

I said nothing.

Stood there with my hands resting in front of me, fingers interlocked, staring at her. I didn’t have anything to add. Not yet. I would. In a few days. Maybe in a few weeks… months. When timing permitted. When this backfired and there was some fallout behind it. I didn’t know for sure. I never knew shit for certain. But things like this, if not properly handled, came back to haunt you. And because I knew my brother, better than he knew himself on most days, I knew he hadn’t done his due diligence. Every t wasn’t crossed… every i might’ve been dotted but with shit like this you have to be meticulously careful. And that wasn’t Zeke. He trusted *himself* too much.

Zeke walked around, glancing from the bitch to us, and then back at the bitch again. “She told me the house would be empty. She told me she knew his schedule and—

“You trusted the word of a crackhead bitch?” Kiss asked, asking what I was thinking.

I took in a deep breath, shifting my eyes away from Becky, over to Zeke. His eyes caught mine for a second before he looked away, wildly running his hand over his wild locs.

“She a crackhead but she ain’t a crackhead-crackhead.”

“A crackheads a crackhead,” Kiss stated, spitting a couple of feet away.

Zeke waved him off, glanced at me, and then away again.

“Why am I here, Zeke?” I asked, finally speaking up.

“I’m sayin,” he said. “I got the bitch responsible for what happened to bro. You… I’m… shit… I’m handlin an issue.”

“Say you got the bitch responsible for what happened huh?” I asked with a snort.

We had different opinions when it came to who was responsible. It was Zeke. And shit… maybe it was me. Even if it was a little. But the bitch

sitting in the chair? Nah. It wasn't on her. Zeke wasn't the brightest but I expected better out of him. What I could see was that he'd reacted off emotion. When he knew, first hand, that in this business… or hell, in life in general… there was no room to make decisions based purely off emotion. Emotions will get you fucked up every single time.

"So, what? You gon' kill her?" Kiss asked. "When you weren't supposed to be makin plays in the first place?"

Zeke was quiet for a second. He looked between the four of us. Pacing, he looked again. There it was. That realization of fucking up. I watched as his stride flipped. Noticed when his eyebrows bounced a little. He knew he'd fucked up. He knew he'd fucked up royally. Tying this bitch up, bringing her out here. Hell, bringing us out here to witness it was a dumb ass move to make.

"The move would've been legit if—"

"If you hadn't made it in the first place," Kiss interrupted.

My eyes went back to Becky. She squirmed, trying to free herself from the metal chair. Eyes wide, looking back and forth between us, scared as hell.

"Damn," Zeke mumbled, stroking his chin. "You right. I—damn!"

"You want me to take this bitch back to the block?" Cash asked.

Zeke glanced at him, roughly ran his hand over the top of his head again and shook it. Kiss said a couple of words. Called Zeke dumb. Said he'd wasted our time. Said he'd done all of that shit for no reason. Said he was the one responsible. Said that if anybody needed to be strapped to the chair it was him. Zeke ate it. Took it and didn't say shit. If I said I was surprised by any of this, I'd be lying. This was Zeke. Wild card. Impulsive. Quick to prove a point. Or try to at least. It wasn't what happened that weighed heavy on him—it was what I thought that had him down. He didn't like to look incompetent. He didn't like to look like the fuck up that he was. He wanted to correct it. This didn't correct a thing. This made things harder. Not on him, but on me. I had a ton of patience. Despite Zeke constantly weighing heavy on it… I was patient. He was baby bro—some things would fall between the cracks with him.

I watched as he kneeled at the chair. Looking up, he asked Cash for a knife to unleash her. Cash walked up, handed him a pocket knife, and Zeke slashed at the thick tape. Before she could get her legs good enough away

from the chair, I walked up, put my gun against her head and pulled the trigger, catching Zeke and Cash off guard.

Closing my eyes, I took in a deep breath and mumbled, “Father forgive me.”

Zeke, steady kneeling at the chair, covered in ‘Becky’, hung his head low. I didn’t know if it was with disappointment or embarrassment. Either way, I didn’t give a fuck.

She couldn’t just go.

I couldn’t just let her walk out of here.

What the fuck was wrong with him? Zeke… he couldn’t have been that stupid to think I’d let the bitch walk. She was a crackhead, yeah. But she was a crackhead who had been close to getting murdered and she’d seen my face.

“I was goin’ take her back to the block…” mumbled Cash as I walked by him, heading out of the warehouse.

* * *

“SHE SAID WHAT?” I asked Rocc, holding my phone on my shoulder with my head, as I peeled moms an orange.

He took a deep breath and paused. “She ain’t riding with me. She don’t know me. Slammed the door in my face and everything.”

I sucked my teeth and took the phone off my shoulder. Hitting the FaceTime button, I told him to knock on the door again. He was at Sereia’s spot, picking her up for me. I texted her a couple ago, letting her know a ride was coming for her. She didn’t like it. Said she wasn’t getting in the car with just anybody. I didn’t think she was serious, so I paid it no mind and sent Rocc to grab her anyway.

She was dead ass apparently.

After Rocc tapped on the door again, I pushed the oranges aside and stared into the camera, waiting for her to open up. A couple of seconds later, the door opened and she peeked out. When I saw her face, I called her name.

“I just told you I was sending somebody to come scoop you—”

“And I told you I wasn’t getting in the car with just anybody.”

I brushed my hand down over my head and looked towards the living room where my mother sat in her usual spot, watching The Bernie Mac Show.

“I need you to leave with him, Sereia. I’m tied up at the moment. Can’t leave. If I could, I would have came and got you. You know that right?”

She scratched the back of her head and looked off. “Why couldn’t you have sent Kiss or… Zeke?”

“Tied up, too. Rocc’s a good dude. I trust him. That says a lot. So,” I paused and took a deep breath. “You can too.”

“I don’t even know what you got me on,” she mumbled, shaking her head.

I understood her hesitation. I mean, I really did. If the roles were reversed, I would have been a little hesitant too but there were facts in this situation that should have made her comfortable.

“Type of time I been on since we met that night?” I asked.

“Huh?”

“What have I shown you since we met?” I asked, leaning on the island, staring at her. She was dressed the way I asked her to be. In black leggings, a white shirt.

She frowned and stammered over her words, hesitant to say what she really felt. “I don’t know. I guess… I don’t know. What that got to do with anything?”

I took a deep breath and shook my head, looking off into the living room again. “I need you to leave with Rocc, sweetheart.”

She crossed her arms over her chest and turned the corners of her mouth up before closing the door in our faces.

Rocc got back into the phone, shaking his head. “How you want me to move, Big Dawg?”

I stood up straight and finished cutting the orange. “Wait. She’s coming back out. This time, to go.”

A couple of minutes later, I heard the door open and Rocc flipped the camera, showing me her. She had on a jean jacket, her purse draped over her shoulder, and a pink pocketknife in her hand. She flashed it at Rocc and tossed a few threatening words his way. Instead of taking it seriously, Rocc snorted, laughed a little and got back into the camera.

“Aight bro. I’m on my way—

“Stay on the phone,” Sereia interrupted. “I want you to see what I do to your mans if he try anything with me.”

I laughed. “Man what?”

She didn’t say anything. Rocc looked into the camera with raised brows and a smile. Neither of us were worried about her little ass. She couldn’t have been no more than 5’2, around 160lbs. She wasn’t a threat. Not with that knife, not even with a blick if she had one on her. Rocc didn’t just run errands and check on shit for me; he was security. Very accredited with his shit too. Sereia was out her damn mind.

“Yeah okay,” I said. “I’ll see you in a couple.”

Rocc flipped the camera again and I got a glimpse of the worry in her face. She gripped the strap to her knock off Prada bag and I took a deep breath. Instead of saying anything, I hung up and carried the plate of fruit over to my ma. After sitting it on the table, I sat on the couch and picked my phone back up to call Sereia.

She answered after the third ring.

“Hello?” She asked, sounding puzzled.

“Relax,” I told her, shifting my eyes over to the TV. “What you eat for breakfast?”

She was quiet for a couple of seconds before mumbling, “A sausage and pancake corn dog.”

I frowned. “You eat that fake ass shit?”

“With extra syrup,” she proudly said.

I shook my head and crossed my arm over my chest, slouched down on the couch. “What would you have rather eaten?”

“Huh?”

“If you had a choice, what would you have eaten?”

I was giving her comfort. She was worried so… I called to comfort her. Didn’t really give a fuck about what she ate or what she wanted to eat. She was a worrier. Which again, I understood. She didn’t know me for real. Didn’t know what I had her on. Like me, though, she was moving with faith. Because she was hesitant about leaving with Rocc I knew she’d probably been battling between fucking with me or not, all night. Sereia was apprehensive. Questioned shit a lot. Of course, she did… look at where she came from. Niggas didn’t usually show up on doorsteps with envelopes full of money, help with funeral services, or offer jobs in The Woods. I was an anomaly, for real. She had every right to question what was going on.

Especially since it was coming from me and not Solo. I was the mean one. The quiet one. The asshole. Big 6’3, 250lb, intimidating nigga. I wanted her to chill though. She’d done enough worrying and overthinking in her life. I wanted her to be at ease when it came to dealing with me.

“Cheese eggs, bacon and hashbrowns with cheese,” she softly said.

“I bet you be gassy as hell, eatin’ all that cheese. I can’t fuck with it. I’m lactose intolerant.”

She laughed and I smirked. There we go. She was loosening up.

About forty minutes later, the security system let me know Rocc was pulling in. I pushed up from the couch and headed for the front door to let them in. When I opened the door, Sereia turned around to face me. She eyed me up and down and I looked down at myself, wondering if a nigga was dressed weird or some shit. I had on a pair of red hoop shorts and a black beater. On my feet were a pair of my Balenci’s. I was straight. Fuck was she looking at?

With pinched brows, I stepped aside to let her in.

“‘Preciate it, my baby. Check on that one thing for me, aight?” I said to Rocc who stood at the bottom of the porch.

He saluted me and told me he would get up with me in a little bit. I watched him walk away before turning my attention back to Sereia who hadn’t moved.

“You gon’ come in?” I asked.

“You didn’t tell me I could.”

“I stepped aside.”

“But you didn’t—

“Come in, Sereia.” Shaking my head, I said, “You a vampire or some shit? You need an invitation? The fuck?”

Sweetly, she smiled and placed a piece of hair behind her ear.

Because I was starting to pick up on her personality, I knew the smile wasn’t genuine. She was being sarcastic.

“If I was, it would be too late now, wouldn’t it? Not Exodus Christ lackin’.”

I laughed and eyed her. “Yeah, aight.”

She was silly.

I liked that shit.

Once she was inside, I closed and locked the door behind her. She stood in the grand foyer, hand resting on her little replica bag, looking around,

eying the skylight. Before I could tell her to, she slid out of a pair of pink Crocs that had seen better days and sat them on the shoe rack.

“This is nice,” she complimented.

“Thank you,” I said. “You can put a pair of the slides on if—

“I’m good,” she said, looking down at her black socks before wiggling her toes. With a deep breath she said, “I’m not taking another step until you tell me why I’m here. All the way across the bridge in some… mansion. That’s,” she paused and looked around. “Clearly not yours. You don’t give floral wallpaper.”

I stared at her briefly, studying her. Brushing my hand over my cheek, I put my eyes on the accent wall she noticed. It was a custom piece. Designed by an artist that went by L. Johnson. She didn’t design wallpaper but after seeing one of her paintings at an associate's spot, I had to speak with her directly. The wallpaper wasn’t just floral. It was of a botanical garden and some more shit. It was layered. The way my moms used to be.

I looked away from the wall and put my attention back on Sereia. “You lack patience.”

“I do,” she admitted, boldly, like it was a good thing. Or rather a character trait she owned.

“I need you to look after my ma,” I said.

She drew back. “*What*?”

“My ma. I need you to—

“No, I heard you. I work at Coney Island, Exodus. I’m a cashier. At. Coney.”

I laughed and walked away, gesturing for her to follow me. “I’m hip. You don’t need to have a certificate or none of that extra shit.”

“How? I can’t do that. I don’t know anything about taking care of people. I don’t—

I looked over my shoulder at her. “Relax. Can you do that for me?”

She eyed me up and down again. This time with a little fire behind her eyes. “You’re not about to keep telling me to relax.”

“I don’t mean it in a disrespectful way, sweetheart. I just want you to chill. You jump to conclusions a lot.”

Her energy was busy. Frantic. Nervous. Shit made me a little uncomfortable, low key.

“What have you heard about her?” I asked, as we made our way to the living room.

“About your momma?” She questioned with dipped brows.

I nodded, brushing my hand down the back of my neck. Because we were who we were, you know… prominent in the hood, known around the community, Marietta’s declining mental health was known. It wasn’t something I wanted out there. It made me uncomfortable as hell, knowing that other muthafuckas knew what was going on within our family. But shit, what could I do about it? Nothing. Just deal. I just wanted moms to be talked about in a good light. I wanted what she’d done for the community to be the topic of discussion. Wanted people to remember her as Mari before Isaiah’s death.

She shrugged. “That she took your dad’s death hard. That’s it, really.”

“That’s it, *really*?” I asked with a light huff. “Yeah, aight.”

“What you want me to say? Tell you every rumor I heard? You know people talk in Brickhaven. They said a few things. Unimportant things. What I know is that she took Pastor Isaiah’s death hard.”

I looked over, nodded and continued through the house. My ma was a sore spot for me. I caught a couple bodies behind her name. Might’ve been erratic, going after niggas who’d said something about her mental health, but I did it. I hadn’t always kept my emotions intact. That was a skill I learned.

“Aight, look,” I said through a sigh. “She don’t require much. Her brain ain’t mush or no shit like—

“Exodus,” she calmly said. “I know her brain isn’t *mush*. I know grief—okay?”

I nodded. “Like I was sayin… she don’t require much. Companionship. Help with meals, showers, brief changes, walks, shit like that. Things you do every day, for the most part. She takes medication too. On a schedule. You don’t need a degree for this. Just a good heart.” I looked over at her. “I think you can handle it. How you feel?”

“Honestly?”

“Of course. I wouldn't want it any other way than that. Ever,” I told her as we made our way into the kitchen where we stood, overlooking the living room at my ma.

“I’m—” She paused and chewed on the side of her lip. “I don’t think I can handle it.”

I crossed my arms over my chest and turned to face her. “What about it intimidates you?”

She nervously smiled and looked down. “Brief changes… I don’t… I’m not a nurse.”

I laughed and nodded. “Felt. Fa sho.”

Stroking my beard, I turned to look back at my ma. Those brief changes were a muthafucka. No lie. There was no way around them though. Moms was out of it. Wasn’t conscious enough to go to the toilet on her own. I wished she was. But it was what it was.

“You’ll be compensated accordingly,” I said before turning to face her again. “Three a week.”

Sereia frowned. “Three hundred dollars a week? I make more than that at Coney. Ain’t no way you brought me all the way over here to offer me three hundred a week to essentially be a CNA. I know I don’t have any certifications or anything but come on now. That’s disrespectful.”

I could have cut her off a minute ago, but I didn’t because I was intrigued. Sereia carried herself in a fashion that I appreciated. Although she was a little hesitant and paranoid, she was a spitfire. Spoke her mind and didn’t give a fuck about who she was speaking her mind to. For me, that was a rarity. Men tiptoed around me. Big Dawg this, Big Dawg that. Heavy dick riding, trying to do everything in their power not to tick me off. And the women? My God… the women were bashful as fuck, rarely made eye contact, and didn’t have morals with me. It was up. They were overly going. Both sexes watched what they said to me. However, not Sereia. Another bitch would have taken that ‘three hundred’ a week with a smile on her face, just to be close to me.

“You might as well call your friend back to take me home. I have to work in about an hour,” she continued, shaking her head, fumbling around her purse. Probably for her phone. Probably wanted to text her girls to tell them about me offering her three hundred fuck ass dollars to take care of my mom.

“Who said it was three *hundred* a week, sweetheart?” I coolly asked, peeping the frown on her face.

She shifted her eyes up at me. “You.”

“No. I said three a week. You assumed I meant three hundred. Why? I don’t fuckin’ know. Considering I just threw you ten bands not even a month ago.”

Her face softened a little and she put her phone back into her purse.

Not only was she impatient but she was impulsive and made assumptions without all of the information. Such a fuckin' woman.

"You want to pay me three thousand dollars a week? Without a certi—

"I told you. All you need for this job is a good heart."

We locked eyes for a couple of seconds before she looked away, arms crossed over her chest. "And you think I'm qualified?"

I nodded. "Uh huh. Wouldn't be here if I didn't think so."

"You don't even know me," she mumbled.

I could have told her about my faith and my relationship with Big G but I didn't need to. I rarely ever spoke on it. If you weren't a part of my immediate family, you had no idea. Not even Jada knew how locked in I was with Big G. That relationship was sacred.

I was a man of big faith.

He said she had a good heart, so… she had a good heart.

"I know enough," I said with a deep breath. "So what up? You willing to change a couple briefs a day for three bands a week?"

She looked at me, drew back and playfully frowned. "Is a…" she looked over at moms and then at me before whispering, "...pigs pussy pork?"

* * *

I STOOD at the top of the porch, watching as Sereia and moms walked away from the house. When my phone went off for the fifth time within the last two hours, I sighed and dug into my pocket to answer it. Any other time I would have picked my phone up regardless of what I had going on but I was in the middle of practically training Sereia on what ma needed. My undivided attention was needed for that. I felt like whatever whoever wanted, they could get up with Kiss about it. They were relentless though—calling twice back-to-back within the last five minutes.

Looking at the screen, I saw that it was Redd, another nigga I had handling shit for me. Right now, his priority was watching the crib. More specifically, Jada.

"What up, nigga?" I answered, watching moms and Sereia until they got out of eyesight.

"What up. You didn't tell me the misses—

“Jada—

“My bad. You didn’t tell me Jada was leaving today.”

With dipped brows, I turned to go back into the house. “Because she’s not. Today is an editing day or whatever the fuck she calls it. That’s why I had you pull up when I had you pull up. Why? She ain’t there?”

He sucked in air and blew it out. “Hell naw. My bad bro—

“Not on you. You got there when you were supposed to.”

I closed my eyes and shook my head. Taking my phone from my ear, I hit the menu button and swiped around until I got to the ‘Find My’ app. She probably went to the grocery store or something.

Clicking on it, I waited for her location to load. Except it didn’t. The last pinged location was the crib, three hours ago. Clicking off the Find My app, I went over to the security system app to check and see when she left. I gripped the top of my basketball shorts and sat on the foyer bench, watching as she climbed into her Benz three hours ago. Clicking off that app, I found the Mercedes Connect app to track the whip. I watched it load and smirked when her location pinged in the hood. Melbourne St. A couple of blocks away from her old block, Lanchester. She was on the move, most likely looking for her crackhead ass daddy.

I brushed my hand over the top of my head and shook it.

“What it’s lookin’ like, boss?” Redd asked.

“I found her.”

“Send me the lo’. You want me to pull up?”

I sat on his question.

Stared at the map and clenched down on my teeth. She was on sneaky shit. Kept taking her ass to that fuckin’ hood without an escort. Well… last time she went she didn’t know she had one, but she did. Same thing, though, low key. I didn’t really give too much of a fuck about her making dumb ass moves. It was the sneaky shit I didn’t like. Fuck was wrong with that bitch?

“Nah,” I said. “She good.”

“You sure?”

I sighed and nodded as if he could see me. “Sure as hell. She said she good in the hood, she good in the hood. I’ll get up with you in a lil bit. Take the day off, my boy.”

With that, I hung up and stared at my phone, debating whether or not I’d call her. The last time I talked to her was a couple of hours ago. This

morning, really. When we talked she said she would be lounging around in pajamas all day. It was a cool, casual conversation. We stayed on for a good fifteen before I had to get moms up and started with her day. I didn’t ask if she was going to see her daddy because shit, she had a routine. Today really was one of her editing days. She usually did stay in the crib, in pajamas, hair in a bonnet on days like today. She was moving flaw and I didn't like it. Yeah, she might’ve been on some innocent, sneaking around to see her pops shit but it was the principle. It rarely ever was about what a muthafucka did. It was the principle that usually got niggas fucked up.

Because I wanted to see just how stupid she was, I sighed and hit her up, wondering if she’d lie about her lo’.

Pressing the phone against my ear, I listened to it ring, waiting for her to pick up. Her phone wasn’t dead so that only told me that she’d purposely turned her lo’ off. Shit was crazy.

After about five rings, the phone was answered.

“Yeah, hello?”

I sat up with dipped brows at the sound of a deep voice that fa sho belonged to a man. “Fuck is this?”

He laughed. “The boogeyman, nigga. You lookin’ for yo’ bitch? Hold on.”

A couple of seconds later, Jada’s cries came through the phone. I closed my eyes, listening to the high-pitched cry that used to bother the hell out of me. She didn’t cry like that unless she was deeply hurt. The last time I heard her like that, Johnny was in the ‘spital from an overdose.

“You want yo bitch back, I need a cool M,” he said before hanging up.

Dropping the phone in my lap, I didn’t move.

I sat there on that foyer bench, staring off, straight ahead, the ticking of the big clock on the wall in the hallway the only sound filling my ears. I wasn’t sure how long I sat like that before the front door opened and Sereia and moms walked back in. She stood in front of me, blocking my view. Sereia said a few things but I didn’t really hear her. I was listening for Him. Big Homie. Big G. I didn’t shift my gaze. I stayed like that. Quiet. Listening. Trying to at least. It was quiet. Up top. In my mind. *Completely* silent.

That meant it would be bad for niggas.

Real bad.

Silence meant He was giving me the green light.

I could handle the situation however I saw fit.

It was game time. Ball was in my hand with only a few seconds left on the shot clock.

TO BE CONTINUED

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ABOUT MISS CANDICE



Miss Candice is a bestselling author from the east side of Detroit, MI. Her debut novel, If Not For Love, was published on Amazon in 2014, marking the beginning of a remarkable literary career. Over the years, she has demonstrated dedication to her craft by producing a staggering collection of over fifty books, with several securing their place on Amazon bestsellers lists'. Her latest and most popular series, "Soul Ties," stands as a testament to her storytelling prowess.

With a palpable passion for her craft, Miss Candice invites readers into worlds rich with emotion and connection, making her a vibrant force in the world of black romance literature.

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